

THE
LIFE AND ADVENTURES
OF
GUZMAN D'ALFARACHE,
OR
THE SPANISH ROGUE.

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OR
THE SPANISH ROGUE.

TRANSLATED FROM THE FRENCH EDITION OF
MONS. LE SAGE.

BY JOHN HENRY BRADY.

SECOND EDITION,
CORRECTED AND CONSIDERABLY IMPROVED.

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THE
LIFE
OF
GUZMAN D'ALFARACHE.

CHAP. XXXV.

Guzman appears at the Grand Duke's Court, where a Lady falls in love with him.

THE Grand Duchess had lately been brought to bed of a Prince, or rather she was just recovering from her accouchement; and there was an entertainment every day at the palace, where all persons of distinction of both sexes did not fail to resort. The Cavaliers who lodged in the same hotel with me, and who were of the first class of nobility of the country, being only come to Florence to join in those diversions, were so much the more assiduous in their attendance, as by these means they made their court to their Prince. My host inquired of me the first evening of my stay, whether I would eat by myself or with those gentlemen. I replied, that I would do myself the honour of supping with them; and when the time came, I entered the room just as they were seating themselves at table. I assumed an easy carriage, and affected the man of consequence, of which I was quite capable, and after I had saluted them politely, I seated myself at the upper end of the room in a chair which was handed me by Sayavedra, who performed his part of the ceremony to admiration.

This bold step attracted the attention of all the company present, who, wishing to know who I was, were uselessly employed in inquiring that information of each other in a whisper. They were most impatient to hear me speak, hoping to discover my nation by my accent. I was malicious enough to keep them in doubt even on this point. In vain did they endeavour to provoke me to speak by little attentions at table; I answered all their civilities either by most gracious looks or by an inclination of the head. Being obliged, however, to utter a few words, I passed in their opinion for a Roman; but afterwards giving orders to Sayavedra in Spanish, puzzled them as much as before.

One of these gentlemen, more curious than the rest, rose from table in order that he might go and interrogate the host as to who I was. In a few moments he returned to his seat with a satisfied air, and whispered something to those next him, and they to the others; and I was in a short

time recognised by the whole party as the nephew of the Spanish Ambassador.

As soon as supper was over, all the company, looking upon me as a young nobleman, crowded round me, and one of them addressing me said: "Perhaps I was not aware that there was almost every day a ball at court, on account of the birth of the young prince, that there would be one held that very evening, and that if I had the least wish to go, they would have the pleasure of conducting me to the palace." I replied, "that it would be most ungracious in me to reject so polite an offer, though indeed my travelling clothes formed some obstacle to the gratification of my curiosity; but that nevertheless, as I was not known at Florence, I would have the honour of accompanying the party to partake of an amusement of which I was exceedingly fond." All the party, except myself, were very elegantly dressed; as to me I did nothing but change my shirt, and adjust myself a little. Ill-dressed as I was, however, in comparison with the others, you will hear what happened to me at the ball.

When we entered the saloon, the Duke and a large party were already assembled there. His Highness fixed his eyes on me immediately; and this somewhat disconcerted me. I thought that he was either displeased at the plainness of my dress, or found something ridiculous in my person; and what convinced me the more was, that he pointed me out to a courtier who stood by him, and as I imagined desired him to ascertain who I was. I was not wrong in my conjecture; the courtier, whom I did not lose sight of, made his way through the crowd and accosted one of the gentlemen whom I had accompanied, whispered something to him, received an answer in the same manner, and then returned to the Grand Duke, to whom I saw him give an account of his commission. All this appeared to me equivocal enough, and I did not know what to think of it, when the same gentleman who had been addressed by the courtier, approached and said to me: "You are known, Signor Cavalier; the Grand Duke knows that you are a relation of the Ambassador from Spain to Rome. I should advise you to go immediately and salute the Prince; he looks at you continually, and seems to wish that you should take that liberty."

I followed the gentleman's advice, thinking that I could not do less; and accordingly advanced towards the Grand Duke, who perceiving my design, was so condescending as to advance half-way to meet me. I commenced with a most profound bow, and addressing his Highness, told him in Italian,

in an easy but respectful manner, "that I had but just arrived at Florence, and I trusted he would pardon my presumption for having ventured even in a ball-room, to offer him my most humble respects; but having been informed that it was his desire to know my name, I had come to announce it to him myself." "I know it already," answered the Prince, "and I am not a little surprised to hear a Spaniard speak Italian as well as a native of Rome." To this remark I answered in Spanish, "that I had long resided in that city." He replied, in the Castilian language, "that he never heard any one of my countrymen pronounce Italian so perfectly." Then, turning the conversation on my Uncle the Ambassador, he told me, "he was well acquainted with him from having had many affairs of consequence between them, and that he should be most proud to testify his respect for him in my person." He then invited me to frequent the Court, with a thousand other compliments, to which I could make no other answer than by bowing almost down to the ground. This was not all; the Grand Duchess came up at that moment, and I had the honour of being presented to her by the Prince her husband, who told her at the same time who I was; and I verily flatter myself that I got out of this dilemma in better style than, perhaps, the real nephew of the Spanish Ambassador would have done in my place.

The ball then commenced, and I retired from where I stood, for fear of incommoding the dancers. After three or four dances, a lady came up and was introduced to me by the Duke's desire. I affected to wish to decline dancing, though in fact I was particularly desirous; and pleaded in excuse, that I had not long alighted from horseback, as might be seen by my frightful dishabille. The Prince who heard me, put an end to the contest, by crying out that he was sure I could not refuse so lovely a lady, even were I to dance in boots. At this desire I instantly obeyed, and my dancing attracted the attention of the whole company. The Grand Duchess especially, who preferred Terpsichore to all the other Muses, was so much pleased, that she requested me to dance some of the newest figures, in which I acquitted myself equally well. This exhilarated my spirits to such a degree, that I made love to all the ladies in company. I would tell you, moreover, friendly reader, were I not fearful of being deemed conceited, that of all the women in Italy, the Florentines understand genteel behaviour the best, and I was by no means badly received among them.

Among the rest there were three young ladies present, who were decidedly the ornaments of the Ball. I never saw more perfect beauties. It

would have puzzled any honest man to have made his choice of one of them. I soon decided, however, favour of a Brunette, who attracted me by a certain *je ne sçai quoi* which the others did not possess. I attached myself to that lady only during the whole ball.

One of the gentlemen who had brought me to the palace, perceiving my *penchant* for this Brunette, approached me; “Signor Don Guzman,” said he with a smile, “how many lovers will you distract with jealousy this night, if you continue your attentions to that lady, who is a rich widow, and has a great number of admirers.” My vanity was flattered by this information, which inspired me with the design of attempting the conquest of a heart which was disputed by so many rivals. I hazarded some soft speeches which were not ill-received, but while my favorable progress inclined me to push my success, the Grand Duchess, who had not danced since her confinement, took a fancy to do me the honour of choosing me for her partner. In fact, foreseeing the consequences, I did all in my power to avoid it: but she would take no denial. The Grand Duke, though he approved of the great respect I paid the Princess by my diffidence, gave me to understand by a nod, that he wished I would comply with the desires of her Highness: so that there were no means of escaping. I danced and performed even better than before: which pleased the Duchess so much that she would not leave off dancing with me, until the Prince was obliged to beg her to desist, lest so much exertion should injure her health.

Their Highnesses then retired, and I accompanied them to their apartment, together with the Lords of the Court, and returned with an air of impatience to the ball-room, when I found the pretty Brunette was also about to retire. I made love to her with so much ardour, that I had the pleasure to see that she quitted me with regret. As soon as she was gone I returned to the Hotel, with the before-mentioned gentlemen who had rejoined me. I was so taken up with the honour that had been conferred on me that evening, that I said but little in answer to the compliments they paid me on my talents for dancing. On our arrival at the Hotel, we took leave of each other with great politeness, and retired to our chambers.

When I was alone with Sayavedra: “My friend,” said I, “my joy overpowers me, I must ease my heart.” At the same time I recounted to him all that had happened at the ball, where I had been so much distinguished, the infinite praise bestowed on me by the Duchess, and my flattering reception from the Duke. My confident cared for nothing but what was

solidly advantageous. Praised he looked on as smoke; but the account of the widow charmed him. His eyes sparkled with joy when I mentioned her to him, "Think nothing of the rest," said he; "this may turn out to your advantage, if you know how to profit by the favourable impression you have made on that lady." Sayavedra and I employed half the night in building castles in the air on this subject, and in deliberating what course we ought to take to bring the affair to a happy issue. It was resolved in council that on the ensuing day we should procure the large trunk we had spoken of before, and that I should purchase as splendid a suit as my purse would afford, to enable me to sustain at Court the character I had already assumed.

This resolution was followed by my giving strict orders to Sayavedra to be in the field early the next morning to put our plans in practice: after which I went to bed. Not that I could close my eyes during the whole night, for it was already day, when, by rocking myself so incessantly with chimeras, I fell asleep for a short time. Sayavedra, who had returned from executing his commissions, came into my room and awoke me. He was followed by a Tailor, at whose shop he had found a suit ready made, which had never been worn. The Tailor told me, that it had been ordered by a young Nobleman, who had suddenly disappeared from Court, after having lost a large sum of money by gaming, and that he desired nothing better than to get rid of it at a fair price. I got up directly and tried it on, and most fortunately it fitted me as well as if it had been made for me. Nothing was wanting but to fix the price: which we agreed on, after a dispute which would have lasted longer, if the Tailor had not wanted money, and if I had not had an earnest longing for the suit; to which he added some gold lace to correspond: which completed it in the fashion of dress at Rome.

I had no sooner paid and sent away the Tailor, than my host came up and informed me that the Grand Duke had sent me, while I slept, a present of wine, fruits, and sweetmeats. This was a compliment that this Prince was in the habit of making to the illustrious foreigners who visited his court. The landlord added that he would not disturb my repose to acquaint me with it. I was not sorry that I had not seen the gentleman whom the Duke had sent with this present, as I must have paid pretty roundly for the carriage; and I could not be too frugal, considering how much I should need money to enable me to make any appearance at Court. I thought then that I should escape this expense, in which I was a little mistaken. Scarcely had my host

ordered the Prince's fruit and wine to be brought into my chamber, when his Highness's gentleman was announced to me. I was obliged to endure a common place harangue, which ended in informing me that the Duchess hoped to see me in the afternoon. I made upon that an abundance of compliments to this gentleman, and Sayavedra, like a well-bred valet, attended him to the door to slip a few crowns into his hand. I amused myself then by trying on the rest of our purchases: such as silk stockings, a superfine hat, ribbons, gay shoes, linen, gloves, and every other necessary article of dress. Seeing that nothing was wanting, I began by shaving, combing, cleaning, and powdering myself; then being dressed, and looking at myself continually in a glass, I turned towards my confidant, to ask him if he thought there was any thing wanting. He answered, that I looked so well, that he was much mistaken if I did not that day distract all the men with jealousy and all the women with love. I did not fail then to put on my elegant gold chain, and fasten below it with a ribbon a miniature portrait of my dear master which he had given me the day before my departure.

I was like another Narcissus, enchanted with myself; I wished myself already at the palace, so desirous was I of showing myself off. I think I should have gone without any refreshment, if Sayavedra had not represented to me that it was necessary to take care of the inside, on which the outside depended; and that starvation was not very likely to improve my complexion. Though I had but little appetite, for I was puffed out with my dress, and my stomach might be said to be as full of wind as my head was; I suffered myself to be prevailed upon to eat a little of what my confidant ordered into my chamber. I was so fearful of soiling myself in eating, that I was quite uneasy until dinner was finished. I tasted the Duke's fruit, and drank a few glasses of verdee which had accompanied the fruits. I found this wine most excellent, and I did not doubt but it would enliven my conversation, if taken in moderation. After this slight repast, I walked up and down my room strutting about; I did nothing but question my squire as to my appearance, and he assured me that I was a very mirror of cavaliers. Satisfied with this testimony, to which my self-love very readily assented, I repaired to the palace, attended by Sayavedra, who, to do me credit, had also made a few purchases for himself at the expense of my purse, which began now to look rather foolish after such copious bleeding.

I was received at the Duke's palace with as many honours as could possibly have been conferred on the Ambassador himself. The Prince first

complimented me on my good looks; he then began to speak of the Ambassador, and communicated something to me in the hope that on my return to Rome I should repeat it to his Excellence. He was completely a man of the world, and never spoke but with some motive. I soon observed that he was anxious to engage me to speak of the Ambassador's private affairs, but I was so completely on my guard against him, that though I staid two hours, not a single indiscreet word escaped my lips. Finding his hints and flattery of no avail, he at length desisted, for fear of exciting suspicion in my mind, and proposed that I should pay my respects to the Duchess.

I was exceedingly glad to be dismissed from a conversation which began to grow tiresome, and I went immediately to wait upon the Duchess, who, after receiving me with great politeness, told me that she had been much delighted with my dancing the preceding evening, and especially with the two last dances, which she should very much like to learn. I replied that my humble ability was entirely at her service, and undertook that she should be perfect in both dances before the next ball-night. She seemed to anticipate much pleasure in the general surprise she should cause in dancing these new figures, and desired that I would not speak of it to any one.

A fine concert was to form the amusement of the court that evening, and I did not fail to appear there in all my charms, after having taken a slight repast at my inn. I need not tell you that my first care was to see if my charming widow was among the crowd. It was not long before I perceived her; her rich and superb dress, and superior charms to all around, could not long be concealed. I advanced towards her with an eagerness which seemed by no means to displease her, and we continued to converse together and admire each other, reciprocally exchanging the most tender looks for some time. All this was exceedingly pleasant, but still I was uncertain of my fate; and thinking that I had no time to lose, I determined to explain myself more clearly, now that I had an opportunity of speaking to her without being overheard. "Madam," said I, in a voice timid but empassioned, "to what punishment would you condemn an insolent who could dare to tell you that he loves you?" The lady blushed a little at this question, but answered, "that it depended upon who it might be, whether she could have resolution sufficient to wish him to be punished at all." "In what a pitiable situation then am I," replied I, "in being prevented by the respect I owe to their Highnesses, from this moment throwing myself at your feet!" My charming widow answered only with her eyes, and I was myself so transported with

joy, that being no longer able to speak, I remained silent for some moments, leaving my sighs to do the office of my tongue.

I had scarcely regained the power of speech, which my joy had deprived me of, when the lady touching my elbow, said with a confused air: "We are observed, the Duchess is watching us with an attention that embarrasses me; I request that you will withdraw a little distance from me." I retired immediately, not without complaining of the Princess's cruelty in disturbing the sweetest moments of my life. I then glided behind the Duchess's chair, whence, as though I had been very attentive to the concert, I cried out: "It must certainly be confessed, that nothing can be better performed." This was really true, for the Duke had some of the best players and singers in Italy; but I had not heard sufficient to be able to decide on their merits, and the Duchess, who well knew it, said it satirically, "You have certainly been so extremely attentive to the concert, that you may boldly decide. But there is some excuse for you," added she smiling, "the lady's charms are much more attractive to you than those of music." Her Highness, observing that this embarrassed me, changed her tone, and asked me what I seriously thought of the voices and performers. I then took the liberty of stating my real opinion; and if I did not answer like a master of the art, I at least made it apparent that I was not altogether ignorant of music.

In about an hour the concert was interrupted by a magnificent collation by way of interlude. I took this opportunity to return to my divinity, to whom I now publicly paid the most marked attention, in preference to the other ladies present; and my rivals now no longer doubted that I was the favoured lover. Whatever malice, however, they might on this account nourish against me, they none of them dared think of being revenged on me, which they were well convinced the Duke would make them repent of. For my part I cared so little for their displeasure, that I thought of nothing but of completing the conquest of my charmer. And love seemed willing to furnish me with opportunity; for just at this moment, a musician passing close by us, I called to him, and asked if he knew the two or three new airs that had lately been so popular at Rome. "I received them only this day," answered he, "so that I have not yet had leisure to study them." The ladies then asked me if I knew them. I replied in the affirmative; and no sooner did they signify that they should like to hear them, than, without waiting like a professional man to be further pressed, I began to hum them in a very faint voice, pretending that I did not wish all the company to hear me. No sooner

had I begun, however, than I was surrounded by all the ladies and gentlemen near me. My notes were not so very inaudible but that they reached the Duchess's ear, who, advancing towards me, requested particularly that I would give my voice full scope.

I must not forget one circumstance. Her Highness made signs to my widow and some other ladies of rank near her, to join the party to partake of the pleasure she anticipated. They advanced towards her directly; and the Duchess, either out of malice or goodness, placed them in such a manner that my mistress stared me full in the face. After which she whispered to me with a smile: "You see I am willing to pay you in advance for the favour you are about to grant me." At these words I bowed most obsequiously, and least she should continue thus to tantalize me, I hastened to begin my song.

Have a care friend Guzman, you will here be ready to tell me, or you certainly are going to praise yourself again. I confess that I am on the point of so doing, and since I have told you all my bad qualities, it is but fair that I should be allowed to say what I can in my own praise. My voice then was so much admired, that the saloon resounded with applause. And this is not much to be wondered at. A man who at Rome had passed for a good singer, was not very likely to fail at Florence. In short I amused the assembly until the fête broke up, when the Duke and Duchess withdrew to their own apartments, and I rejoined my widow, who was evidently waiting only to take leave of me. I had just time to say a few sweet words to her, which were repaid with usury, and to request permission to pay my respects to her at her own house. This is usual at Florence, and was most gracefully granted. The lady even appointed an hour herself, than which she could not have paid me a greater compliment.

CHAP. XXXVI.

Sequel and conclusion of this fine Intrigue.

WHEN I returned home, I thought myself obliged to give my counsellor Sayavedra an account of my fortune that day; even to the minutest particulars. After having listened to me with the greatest attention, he said to me: "Every thing goes well, and I do not doubt but the lady will fall into our snares." "Friend," said I, "a prudent man is always in doubt about the event.

"When I think of the excess of my good luck, when I consider all the advantages of it, and please my imagination that in the course of two days I have reached the very summit of my wishes, I fear that fortune has hitherto flattered my sanguine expectation, but to spoil and confound my rash undertaking by some sad disaster." "True it is," replied my confidant, "that the promises of hope are often fallacious, but yet sometimes they must be fulfilled."

I slept more soundly that night than the last, and as soon as I rose the next day I sent the present of sweat-meats I had received from the Grand Duke, except some fruits and a bottle of wine, to my beautiful Brunette, thinking I could not make a better use of it. I added to it gloves, and all sorts of ribbons, which I had ordered Sayavedra to choose and buy for me. My present pleased the widow exceedingly, as well as the note I sent with it, and to which I was told she would in the evening give me an answer by word of mouth, at the lady's house, who expected to see me. Unluckily the hour appointed for that visit was nearly the same I had promised to be at court to finish the lessons of the two dances which the Duchess had began to learn with me. To conciliate matters, I resolved to go somewhat sooner than I was expected to the Princess's, in the hope of thus being able still to keep my appointment with the lady also. I was mistaken in my reckoning; her Highness, who had a great desire to make herself perfect in those two dances, made me dance them so often with her, that it was not possible for me to take my leave of her for that happy assignation, the hour of which to my great sorrow was already passed, and caused within me the most expressive signs of impatience.

The Duchess perceived it, notwithstanding all my endeavours to dissimulate. "What is the matter," said she, "there is something that makes you uneasy. I see what it is, your widow makes you think the rehearsal rather too long; is it not so?" I plainly confessed the truth, and owned the cause of my uneasiness, thinking by that she would let me go sooner, but she did not. On the contrary she ordered me to remain with her; but, rather than lose my company, she sent for my lovely widow, ordering the messenger to make my excuses, and taking all the blame upon herself. Nothing could be more gracious; I returned her Highness my thanks in the most grateful terms, and then recovering my usual gaiety, I repaid so much kindness, by saying a thousand pleasant sallies, which made my conversation very agreeable to the Princess. When the amiable Brunette came, extremely pleased with the honour the Grand Duchess had done her, her Highness told her that she had sent for her to make amends for the pleasure she had been deprived of while she detained me; then caressing the lady on my account, she said so many obliging and tender things in my favour, that it put me in confusion. We three then began a little ball, till the hour fixed for the great one, which no sooner arrived than we entered the ball-room, and as long as it lasted my mistress and I did nothing but exert ourselves to make our court to her Highness, who was fond of seeing us dance together. From that very night our mutual love became public; every one looked upon us as a couple of happy lovers. My rivals alone thought otherwise.

The next morning I paid my widow the visit I was to have made her the day before. I found that lady in company with two of her friends, whom out of decency she had desired to be there, but who knowing well our mutual inclination, gave us opportunity to whisper our sentiments to one another; I heard from the lovely mouth of my peerless brunette, that from the very first minute she saw me, she had felt for me, what in vain her other lovers had endeavoured to inspire her with. In a word, I might without affectation think myself tenderly beloved. As there was no gala at the palace that day, their Highnesses being gone to honour an important wedding in the city with their presence, my visit lasted the longer. How many empassioned expressions escaped me! how many tender and obliging words did she favour me with! and how happy were we in each other's company!

It was late when I returned home. I was completely in love, and my mind so enraptured with fine ideas, that I could scarcely speak. Sayavedra

suffered me to remain sometime overcome by this charming intoxication; but seeing that my interest required it should be removed: "My dear master," said he, "you indulge yourself too much with the fair prospect of your amorous intrigues; you forget that we are in a town much frequented by travellers. You may chance to meet here somebody returning from Rome, and who may know you. Every minute you run the risk of being discovered. Take my advice and come to the point; know soon from your mistress, how far your lucky stars will carry you, and lose no more time like a whining lover."

The prudence of my confidant restored me to my senses, and the next day I resolved to call upon my widow, fully determined to ask her consent to our marriage. I was afraid of spoiling all by being too hasty, and it was but with a trembling voice I entreated her to complete my happiness. Far, however, from opposing the impatient desire I evinced to become her husband; she confessed ingenuously that her intentions being similar to mine, she had not the least wish for delay. "See my relations in the first place," she continued; "ask their approbation, and after you have paid them that compliment, my consent shall not be wanting." I threw myself at her feet in an extacy of love and joy, and taking her hand without any resistance on her part, I kissed it with rapture. I then entreated her to seal her promise by accepting of a small ring that I had on my finger. It was a pretty diamond, and extremely well set. She consented to it, and suffered me to put it on her finger, on condition that I should receive one from her in return. After this we talked as freely together as if we were already married. Indeed I believe I might have that very day attained the summit of my felicity, if I had been more bold; but besides that I was extremely fearful of giving offence, by betraying any guilty desires, I was too much in love, and had too much esteem for her, to be capable of such rashness.

When I returned from the house of my enamoured widow, and informed Sayavedra of the result of my last conversation with her, shewing him the token of the promise she had given me, a tear of joy sparkled in his eye. "Cheer up," cried he, "the wind blows fair; you sail before it; proceed and enter the port. Do not fail to-morrow to visit your dear widow's relations, for I am fully persuaded they will give their consent." There was no need to encourage me to it. My mistress had told me their names, and described their characters, that I might the better know how to address myself to each of them in particular. Two of them I knew already, who were about the same

age as myself, and I made no doubt of securing them in my interest. But there were some grave, phlegmatic greybeards among them, of whom I was afraid. However I saw them all that very morning. The two young sparks said presently that they consented with all their hearts, if my addresses were agreeable to their cousin. The uncles were not so easily prevailed upon. They said it was a family affair; that they would have a meeting soon, and would let me know in a day or two what had been resolved. Nothing was more prudent than this proceeding, and whatever sorrow such delay occasioned me, I could find no pretence to complain.

I went after dinner to my mistress to give her an account of all these visits. She told me it was enough; she expected the answer I met with, and that we might in the mean time regulate all the marriage ceremonies and the wedding concerns, to have it performed with all the splendour suitable to persons of our quality; as there was no doubt that their Highnesses would honour us with their company. After three days waiting, two of my future spouse's relations called upon me with an answer in the name of the rest, saying they all approved of the honour I designed their family, in entering into an alliance with their kinswoman, yet they could wish of me, for the greater decency of the thing, that I would condescend to engage my uncle the Ambassador to testify his consent by a line to the Grand Duke, and a note out of courtesy to the family to ask their approbation. I was sadly vexed at these conditions, but collecting all my spirits to conceal the disorder I was in, I replied with unparalleled assurance, that if that was all that prevented our marriage, they should be soon satisfied. I promised to get from the Ambassador not only general, but particular letters to every one of the relations. As to the Grand Duke, I told them I expected every post a letter from my uncle to His Highness, to desire his protection in the affair of my marriage, having written to the Ambassador about it already. The gentlemen were mightily pleased with this answer, and took leave of me, fully relying upon the performance of my promise.

Thus had I brought a pretty load upon my shoulders with these letters, and the recommendation of the Ambassador. Had I attempted by a letter to beg of him to make my fortune, in owning me for his nephew, God knows how his Eminence would have caused me to be treated by the Grand Duke at Florence, and in what fine style he would have recommended me. Therefore I was by no means whatever inclined to adopt such a plan; I rather preferred, and indeed it was the only resource left to me, to make the

last effort, by prevailing upon my mistress to marry me instantly. I flew to her house as soon as her old relations had left me; accosted her with a sad countenance, and related what had passed between us, and how I saw myself doomed to die with impatience. "This delay," said my widow, "will not be so dreadful as you may think." "Excuse me, Madam," said I, with the greatest emotion, "I may easily obtain from the Ambassador to write in my favour to the Grand Duke, and to your relations; I may venture to say that he will give this proof of his regard for his nephew. But allow me to tell you, his temper is the cause of my fear. He has too much prudence and delicacy not to get information first about your family, and even about yourself, dear Madam, if I may venture the word, for fear it might be only the amour of a young man. Such an inquiry will require time that will appear an eternity to me, and almost maddens me to think of." I then expressed my sentiments on the subject, in a manner which I cannot now detail; for when a lover speaks from the dictates of his heart, he expresses himself at the time much more pathetically than he can afterwards describe to another.

All I now remember is, that my lovely widow was moved at my representation of the sufferings I should endure by so long a delay; and being perhaps no less impatient than I was to bend to the yoke of matrimony, she replied, to comfort me, that she did not depend entirely on her relations; that what she had done was for decency's sake, and out of respect to them. "I only desire three days respite," she continued, "to get the consent of such of my relations as are the best disposed to it, and if unluckily they all oppose my design, we may be married privately, and leave them and Monsieur Ambassador to settle their business together afterwards by themselves." It was not possible for me to hear words more kind, and my whole frame was in a rapture. In a word I shewed myself so sensible of her goodness to me, that I threw her into great disorder, and the lady would have willingly spared me the three days to hasten my felicity.

Who would have supposed that a day so agreeable would have been followed by the most fatal of my life! The next morning I rose to go to the Church called *Annunciata*, one of the finest in the city, to hear Mass. Hither all the fashionable people of both sexes used to resort. I met there one of my mistress's young relations, who was inclined to the match. I accosted him, and we insensibly fell into a conversation upon my intended marriage with his cousin. Whilst I was talking with him, a beggar, whom I had

already sent away twice without deigning to look at him, returned a third time to the charge to ask alms. Earnestly engaged as I was, in conversation so interesting, I grew impatient, and struck him in the face with my glove. "You rogue of a beggar, will you not let me be in quiet for you?" The poor man, who expected quite a different sort of treatment from me, gave me this answer: "Oh, Mr. Guzman, if you had been treated thus when you were a beggar like me, you would not have set up for a great Lord as you do now." This man's voice and words, which I heard and knew distinctly, struck me to the heart; I turned my head about, and remembered he was one of my dear comrades at Rome, when I was one of their fraternity. I changed colour in an instant, I blushed, and looked on him with eyes sparkling with rage and choler. But so far from being dismayed at it, he laughed, and made mouths and grimaces at me, and muttered something as he retired. All the gentlemen that were round us, and especially one of my rivals who had heard in what manner the beggar had spoken to me, and observed that I was out of countenance at the sight of him, were quite surprised. My rival who had more interest than any to know the bottom of this adventure, followed the beggar to the Church door, where he stood to ask alms. He took him aside, and after having slipped a few pieces of money into his hand, asked him if he knew me, and how he dared venture to talk to me as he had done. The poor man, resenting yet the blow I had given him, and burning with anger against me, told him the whole history of my life, from the time of my coming to Rome, to my leaving the Ambassador of Spain.

This gentleman who had the greatest pretence of any of my rivals to the hand of my mistress, rejoiced to hear such a singular piece of news, and quite delighted with the information, he gave the beggar more pence, and bade him come to his house after dinner, for a coat he meant to give him; he also advised him to keep him out of the way for fear of me, who might perhaps revenge the affront he had offered me in the very sight of the church. As for him, he went up again to the widow's kinsman, and seeing that he was alone, for in the confusion I was in, I had thought proper to leave him, he accosted him, and burning with impatience to speak of me, he could not help giving him the information the beggar had treated him with. The lady's kinsman, somewhat disconcerted, only answered that he could not believe a word of what the beggar had said, who to all appearance took me for the wrong person.

The two gentlemen then separated; the kinsman with some suspicion that I was not what I appeared to be, and my rival triumphing in having made a discovery which was likely to rid him of his most dangerous opponent. It was half past eleven, and consequently there was a great deal of company at the palace, it being the time when His Highness sat down to dinner. My rival soon appeared, and mixing among the company whom he thought most jealous of the favours I enjoyed with their Highnesses, told them as a secret all he knew of me, praying them, however, not to divulge the adventure, under a strict charge of secrecy, on purpose, no doubt, that they should be the more eager to tell it, as in effect it happened; for in less than a quarter of an hour's time, it came to the duke's ears. This prince only laughed at it at first, and when he heard it was reported by one of my rivals, he took it for a tale invented by a jealous lover incited to it by despair; yet with his usual prudence, and as the Grand Duchess had behaved so kindly towards me, he was extremely anxious to know the truth of it. He commanded the beggar to be brought secretly before him to court, in order that he might hear him himself. He was obeyed; the poor man came, and the duke from behind the hangings heard the whole history without being seen. When the prince had listened attentively to the noble recital of these rare adventures, he commanded the beggar to be put in prison, where, however, he should be well used; with an order that nobody should see or speak to him till he was entirely satisfied on the subject.

If all this while I was not quite easy, at least I had not the slightest suspicion of what was in agitation concerning me. It is true that the cruel accident of the morning had caused me considerable concern; but I expected that by giving a sum of money to the beggar, I should have induced him to leave Florence, or at least obliged him to hold his tongue. I even returned to Church as soon as Mass was over, in the hope of finding him; but as he was not there I put off speaking to him till the next day. As for what he had said to me, I was resolved to turn it into a joke, if any one happened to speak about it, pretending that it was an insolent rascal that had abused me for using him a little scurvily. At last I had almost forgotten it, and went to court as I used to do after dinner. I desired to see the duke, but I was told he was engaged on particular private business. I then went to the apartments of the duchess, who they said would see nobody, being a little indisposed, and that there would not be any assembly that night. All this appeared quite natural to me, and well enough pleased that I should have all

the afternoon and evening to pass with my widow, I flew to her house. There I found the door crowded with her old relations' footmen. I concluded there was a meeting of them on occasion of our marriage; so I let them alone, imagining my presence would disturb them. I made no stay there, and not knowing what to do with myself, I went straight home, to wait till the conference broke up. There I remained two hours, after which I sent my faithful confidant to my mistress, to hear from her the event of it. Sayavedra was told she was gone out. He went there again an hour after, but the answer was, she could neither see nor speak to any one.

Now indeed a dreadful scene opened before my eyes, and my heart became a prey to sorrow and vexation. My faithful squire endeavoured to comfort me, but all his reasonings and consolation could not banish from my mind the dismal thought that fear inspired me with. I went to bed without my supper, and the next morning got up, having taken no rest during the night. I was just going to send a note to my widow, to desire the favour of her to let me know when I should come and see her, when my host brought me word that two gentlemen of my acquaintance wanted to speak with me upon business of some importance. I ordered that they should be introduced. These gentlemen entered with a sedate and serious countenance, and one of them addressing me said: "We are come out of pure friendship to inform you that there runs a very odd report of you at court and in the city. It is said that far from being a man of quality, you have acted mean and different figures at Rome. In a word you have been the Ambassador's domestic, and not his kinsman, as you pretend to be. We know not if the Grand Duke has heard of it yet: however, we would advise you as friends not to go to court, but to procure the Ambassador's attestations in your favour as fast as you can, and prove the falsity of reports so much to your dishonour."

When this gentleman had concluded his speech, so mortifying to me, I was thunderstruck, and ready to swoon away; my speech failed me when I began to make an apology. I answered, however, that I could not have believed my enemies could have carried their slander so far; but before the end of the day, I would take post and go to Rome myself, to obtain authentic attestations more than enough to confound the malicious plan of jealous rivals. The two gentlemen approved of my resolution, and withdrew to make their report to the Grand Duke; for it was by his order that they had come to me, though they had pretended it was purely of themselves, and out

of kindness to me. They were no sooner gone than my trusty friend entered the chamber, and guessing by my looks the afflicting news I had to relate, felt the greatest grief when I told him what was the matter. However, far from being cast down as I was by this misfortune, he bore up against it, and with a firmness that astonished me. "Now master," said he, "you must shew yourself a man of courage and stedfastness. Can you be surprised after having acted so delicate a part as you have done in the eyes of all the world, that some mischance should happen that gives a sad and gloomy turn to the plot of the play? for my part I always expected it; but after all our fall is not so great but we may rise again; thanks to your lucky stars, the free country is left open before you; let us make use of our time, and immediately leave Florence and the Duke's territories, and betake ourselves elsewhere, to comment at leisure on this change of fortune."

This prudent reasoning restored me by degrees to my senses, and upon reflection I could not help thinking that I had deserved to be treated with more rigour than I had been. I told Sayavedra that his advice was too good not to be followed, and if we could set out post within an hour, it would be most desirable. "Nothing is so easy," answered he; "your horse is sold, we are not without cash, and have only therefore to hire post horses, and begin our journey. Depend on me for providing every thing for our departure." "Well," replied I, "my friend, do what you think proper. Alas!" I continued, with a deep sigh, "could I but once more see my beloved widow I should part contented!" I expected Sayavedra would have opposed my desire, but on the contrary he assured me that he would procure me that satisfaction before we were ready to mount our horses.

While I was engaged in expressing to my confidant my satisfaction in having met with a man so entirely devoted to my interest, my landlord came and told me a young woman desired to speak with me. At first I trembled for fear, for the least thing alarmed me, in the situation I was in. However I recovered myself when I found this young woman was one of my mistress's waiting maids, who brought me a note from my widow, containing these few words, "*I expect you at my Cousin's to inform you of circumstances of the utmost importance: farewell!*" I desired the maid to tell her mistress I would call upon her immediately, and as soon as she was gone, turning to Sayavedra: "See," cried I, "what I wished for is come to pass. I fear it will be painful to me to endure the conversation of a lady I am so much in love with, and whom I shall never see again. Be that as it may, however, I must

see her, though I die for it." I charged Sayavedra accordingly, to settle every thing for me. "Make not yourself uneasy," said he, "about any thing, and you may expect that in an hour and a half at the most, I shall be with the post horses near about the house you are going to."

Every thing being settled with Sayavedra, I hastened to my mistress. I found her in a dishabille, which betrayed more of disorder than of negligence; she looked dejected and pale; her eyes were still moist with weeping; in a word she was so altered, that she was not like the same person. On my part I was no less confused than herself. As soon as her cousin perceived me enter the room, she withdrew.

Now that my mistress found herself alone with me, she raised her eyes full of tears towards me and said, "Have you heard all the frightful scandal that is reported of you in Florence?" "Yes," said I, "I have been informed what horrid slander my enemies have circulated against me, and in an hour's time I take horse to return to Rome, and in five or six days I shall bring back such authentic proofs of the falsehood of their calumnies as to confound them." These words somewhat relieved her. She then told me the substance of her relations' conference held at her house; all that the beggar had said; the terrible stories he had told of me to all that asked him any thing about me; and concluded by reprobating the curiosity of the Grand Duke who could condescend to listen to so wretched a fellow himself.

I suffered the lady to talk as long as she chose, without interrupting her; for I was so confused, that I could not immediately make any answer to the purpose. I shrugged up my shoulders, raised my hands and eyes to heaven, groaned, and made a thousand gestures, which persuaded her much more of the falsity of these reports, than all the powers of human eloquence. "Do not suffer yourself to be afflicted immoderately," said she with tenderness; "I have loved your person though your rank was unknown to me, and were you not what I think you are, I feel that I should still love you. Perhaps I should not have taken notice of the charms that I have observed in you, had I looked upon you at first as a person of low condition: my pride and my birth would not have suffered me to cast my eyes on such a one; but having once seen those charms I can never forget them." Her generosity and tenderness had so powerful an effect on me, that I fell down in a swoon. She thought I was dying, and it was with the greatest difficulty that she had strength enough to call her cousin, who had much ado to manage us both, and was obliged to call in the assistance of one of the waiting women. A

minute after these two persons had succeeded in restoring me to my senses, I was told that my valet was in the ante-chamber and my horses ready. It was then that I found what it was to love, and felt the pangs of parting with the beloved object. Never was there a more tender and moving farewell.

I was so little myself, and so full of sorrow when I left the house of her cousin, that I did not see Sayavedra who stood directly before my eyes, but passed by without speaking to him; he followed me, and observing I was almost distracted, spoke not a word, but led me where the horses waited for us. I mounted immediately, and galloped the whole of the first stage without speaking a word: but at the second my squire asked me if I had any object in travelling the road to Rome. I answered that I wished it to appear that I was going to that city, but at the next stage we would stop, and consult what was best to be done.

CHAP. XXXVII.

Guzman takes the road to Bologna, in the hope of there meeting with and prosecuting Alexander Bentivoglio, who had robbed him.

WHEN we came to the first stage, we stopped to take some refreshment and rest, which I stood very much in need of, having partaken of neither for the last twenty-four hours. After that we began to consult together.

“I think,” said I to Sayavedra, “that we ought without delay to go to Bologna. I have some idea that we shall there meet Alexander Bentivoglio, and if it be our good luck to find him, I do not doubt but by composition, or a law suit, I shall get part of my property again.” My confidant confirmed me in my opinion, by saying; “let us hire horses then, and set off to Bologna; but give me leave, if you please, to remind you of the danger I shall run in appearing in that town. I am fully of opinion as well as you that Alexander is there, and if unluckily for me, he should see me there, he will be anxious to know what brought me to Bologna, and as sure as he discovers that we came together, he will suspect your design and either run away himself, or get me assassinated. This is not all,” added he; “I cannot be of any use to you in the business, without running the risk of my own neck; since I must suffer myself to be committed to prison; and once confined, shall never get out again, except by a special dispensation from heaven.”

I approved of Sayavedra’s reasons, and we agreed that he should not appear in the streets of Bologna, but keep as closely concealed as he could in the inn where we should take up our lodging, and not meddle in the law-suit, in case I should institute any. After all, I did not imagine his testimony would be necessary to help me to get my thief compelled to restore at least part of my property. My confidant, pleased with this agreement, professed himself quite ready to follow me. We set off immediately on common hacks, and the next day towards evening we reached Bologna. We alighted at an inn, where I found some strangers brought to that town by their several occupations. I supped with them, and retired pretty early into a neat little room which Sayavedra had bespoke for me. I slept very little, all my thoughts being taken up about that rogue Alexander, and I rose early in the

morning to inquire at once if he was not in the country. I went out by myself, and walked for a quarter of an hour about the streets. As I was passing before the great church, I cast my eyes upon five or six young fellows who were at the door, and I observed one among them whose coat impressed me with a strong suspicion that he was the man I was looking for. I at first mistrusted my eyes, but after a long examination, I knew for certainty that it was the coat which a Neapolitan officer had made me a present of, to whom I had been serviceable in speaking to my Lord Ambassador in his behalf.

I was so enraged at seeing this rascal bedecked in my finery, that it was with some difficulty I could restrain myself from running him through with my sword; but as his good luck would have it, or perhaps mine rather, my more reasonable thoughts prevented me. "Softly," said I to myself, "be not too hasty: let the gaol-bird live, and he may then possibly pay his debts; but if you kill him you will certainly be as much the sufferer as he. Besides those young fellows that are standing by him will of course take his part; and even if they should not interfere, remember that he has the reputation of a bully, and you may not have fair play. At all events, instead of plaintiff, you would become defendant." Having thus fully convinced myself of the folly of exposing myself by such an action, which would have made my journey fruitless at least, if not fatal; I returned to the inn, and asked my landlord if he could recommend me an experienced lawyer. He answered in the affirmative, and immediately sent for one who lived in the neighbourhood, and who, considering his profession, was a tolerably honest man. I first inquired of this gentleman, whether he knew one Alexander Bentivoglio, son of a solicitor of the same name? He replied, "that there were very few who did not know both father and son." I then asked, "if he was any relation or friend to them?" "No, thank God!" answered he with some haste; "I should be very sorry to have any such relations or friends."

After these two questions, which I thought prudent and necessary, I told him the particulars of the loss of my trunks. He listened to me with the utmost *sang-froid*, and did not seem in the least surprised. He even owned to me, that in Bologna, they were quite used to hear such adventures of master Alexander, who frequently played similar games. I am by no means certain, however, continued he, even though you commence an action against him, that you will be at all the better for it. You will have to deal with a formidable opponent in his father, who has put himself above the

laws by the wickedness of his disposition, and rendered himself terrible to all the inhabitants of this city, who dread him as much as fire. The best advice I can give you, is to have a conversation with this father of his, who, perhaps, may rather choose to come to terms with you, than suffer such a piece of villainy to be made public. This is the only probable way to recover any part of the property you have lost. I answered, "that I was of the same opinion; for, besides the dislike I had for law-suits, I considered that I should not get much by prosecuting a thief, and particularly one who happened to be the son of a man of such a character. I therefore requested him to call upon the father himself; but, as I found he did not wish to have any thing to do in an affair disagreeable to counsellor Bentivoglio, I promised him a good reward for his trouble in case of success." He could not stand against this promise, and at once found resolution enough to go to Alexander's father.

My Solicitor soon returned, but his looks showed that his answer was not satisfactory, and I could easily perceive, that his trouble had been in vain. He told me, that the haughty lawyer had used him very ill; that so far from agreeing to any terms of accommodation, he said that he felt his honour wounded, and was so offended at such a proposal, that he insisted that I was the thief, and his son the person who had been robbed, and ended his discourse with the most violent threats against me. I resolved then, since I was compelled to do it, to implore the help of justice. The Solicitor, good man, prayed to be excused; for his undertaking the cause would be the ruin of himself and family, the father of my adversary having threatened to send them all to the hospital, if he knew that either directly or indirectly he gave me the least assistance. "Recommend me then, at least," said I, "to some able lawyer." He was in doubt whether he would even oblige me so far as this, so great was his dread of the Bentivoglio's; but observing that I pulled some money out of my pocket to pay him for his trouble, he named a counsellor of great experience and probity; and what was more, a secret enemy of my adversary's, but he desired me not to mention who had directed me to him.

I went accordingly to this gentleman, told him my case, and how I had been robbed at Sienna. As soon as I had finished, he said, the whole city of Bologna was already informed of this adventure. Alexander returned home laden with clothes, which, it was reported he had won of a young Spaniard at Rome, but it was well understood at what game he must have played to

get them. "Do not lose time, added he; carry on the business briskly; I do not doubt that justice will be done to you, in spite of all the exertion of old Bentivoglio to the contrary." I replied, "that I depended entirely on his integrity and capacity, putting myself and my cause into his hands, not doubting that he would act in the business so that I should have no occasion to repent of having come to Bologna." He assured me, that he would do his best; and that I had only to take a walk in the town, and call upon him three hours after; which I did. When I returned, I found my declaration ready drawn, with a true recital of the case, arranged much to my satisfaction.

We went together and gave it to the magistrate called *El Oydor del Torron*^[A]. The more I observed my lawyer, the more was I convinced that he went regularly to work, as much to maintain my rights as to vex his brother lawyer Bentivoglio; but whether this latter had been aware of my design, or that he was an intimate of the auditor or register, no sooner was my declaration against Alexander delivered in, than he had a hint of it, and another was presented against me before the same magistrate, in the name of the lawyer Bentivoglio, setting forth that I had defamed his son, requiring damages for the injury done his reputation, and further that I should have corporal punishment. My lawyer said that was nothing; "if Bentivoglio," said he, "has no more skill to show us than this, we have not much to fear; we shall be able to answer him when the auditor has answered our petition," which he soon did. But in what manner, good heaven? by ordering that within three days at the furthest, I should produce my evidence of the robbery of which I accused Signor Alexander Bentivoglio.

^[A] The Auditor of the Tower, or Judge in criminal cases.

Had I dispatched a man express to Sienna for a copy of the allegations mentioned in my declaration, I could not have had an answer in so short a time.

The auditor could not be ignorant of this, since in my petition I had expressly declared that it was from Sienna that I expected my strongest proofs. My lawyer remonstrated in a second petition, that it was against custom to prescribe a fixed time to the plaintiff. By this he hoped at least to maintain a longer time, but he was again disappointed. Not being able now to doubt any longer the connexion that subsisted between the auditor and the honest man I had to contend with, he said to me with the utmost confusion, and blushing at the horrible injustice I met with in his own country; "I have no other advice to give you but to quit this town; it is not

safe for you to remain here; I see but too well the wicked trick they have served you; you will only spend your time and money here to no purpose, and I am not sure that you will even get off at so cheap a rate. In one word you are a stranger: and I blush to confess that every thing is thought lawful here against foreigners.”

“Is it possible?” said I, in a tone expressive enough of my indignation; “sure we are not at present in a country of barbarians.” “Yes, worse than barbarians,” said he, “for among them, justice is administered according to the law of nature, but here we have no law at all. I repeat it again,” continued he, “my advice is, that you tarry no longer in a part of the world where the chief magistrates are so little scrupulous as to make the guilty pass for innocent, and treat the innocent as guilty.” I promised my lawyer that the very next day I would follow his advice. I thanked him for the pains and trouble he had been at, and pulled out my purse to recompense him, but he declined taking any thing from me. “You have lost enough already,” said he, “if I were to take any fee from you, I should deserve, I think, to be considered as one of those whom you have to complain of. Besides, I wish, that in quitting the city of Bologna, you may be convinced that though rogues are abundant, yet there are a few men of honour to be found in it.”

I returned to my lodging, mightily pleased with the frank proceeding of my lawyer, and found Sayavedra in no small fear, lest I should sacrifice him to recover my goods. Undoubtedly, if I had produced him in Court, it would at once have defeated the arts of old Bentivoglio; but it never entered into my heart to be guilty of such a piece of treachery. I had forgiven him, and since that time he had served me so faithfully, that he left me no occasion to remember what he had done. I told him that our law-suit was finished, though no judgment had been given upon it; that we had but to seek our fortune elsewhere, and that, as I intended to set out for Milan the next day very early in the morning, he had nothing to do but to hire post-horses, and prepare every thing for our journey. I had scarcely finished giving these orders to Sayavedra, when there entered the inn a great number of bailiffs and bailiffs’ followers,—a trade the devil would not be of. They made no more ado, but took me by the collar and hauled me off to prison. I asked for what I was committed, and what I had done to merit such usage? I was answered I should know in good time; which I did indeed, and found that it was for the crime of having been robbed, and that I should be very lucky if I got out of prison by being sent to the galleys. That Counsellor Bentivoglio,

in order to punish me for my insolence in bringing an action against his son, and presenting petitions that were looked upon as defamatory libels against the nobility of his family, and more particularly against Signor Alexander, whose morals and good manners were so well known in the city of Bologna, had obtained from the justice of the Auditor a warrant to arrest me, until I should be adjudged a punishment suitable to my rashness.

This notable accusation took up a whole sheet of paper, and all the while I read it I raised my hands and eyes towards Heaven with looks of astonishment, to the great amusement of the jailor and his companions, who laughed heartily in their sleeves at me. I remained two or three days without seeing any body but the keeper and his men, who wantonly insulted me, and made me their laughing-stock. This place appeared to me to be the true picture of Hell. I should have been starved had I not had money, and as it was, I paid for what I had at least three times its value. In addition to this, I was obliged to keep on terms with the jailor, who, out of an excess of civility, constantly visited me at my meals, eat up half of what I had paid for, and afterwards had the impudence to say he did not honour any other prisoner so much as to give him his company.

Sayavedra, who, for the reasons I have before mentioned, dared not appear in the town to solicit for me, employed my landlord, who, moved with compassion to see me so ill used, went to my lawyer to prevail upon him not to give me up to the wickedness of my enemies. This counsellor, like a charitable and generous man, indignant at the tyranny that was exercised, in contempt of the laws, against a helpless stranger, again espoused my cause, to get me out of the clutches of these robbers; and, to avoid an ignominious sentence, he advised me to consent to an accommodation proposed to me by the adverse party, and which I shall not fail here to mention. They made me sign a paper containing in substance a recantation of my charge against Signor Bentivoglio, and a declaration, drawn up in excellent form, that I knew this same Signor to be a very honest gentleman, of a moral life and irreproachable honour, begging his pardon for having accused him of so foul an action, and stating that what I had done was at the instigation of some enemies of his, having myself no manner of cause of complaint against him.

These were the honourable means they found to accommodate the parties. I had no sooner signed this declaration against my honour and my conscience than I was discharged; and, in truth, what would not I have

written? What would not a man say or do to get out of prison? Those who know what it is to live in such a place will excuse me for having proclaimed a thief to be an honest man for the sake of my liberty. I repaired immediately to my inn, where I found Sayavedra in a most disconsolate state of mind, much doubting whether the application of my solicitor, and the scandalous reports in the town concerning my imprisonment, would prevail so far as to extricate me from confinement. This dear confidant was overjoyed to see me, whom he did not in the least expect. The gentlemen who lodged at the inn were just going to sit down to dinner. As soon as they saw me enter, they all embraced me, and wished me joy of my enlargement, telling me how much they had been concerned at my misfortune. During dinner the whole discourse ran upon my judges, and Heaven knows they did not spare them. For my part I spoke of them with a great deal of prudence, for fear of some new accident.

CHAP. XXXVIII.

Guzman, being out of Prison, prepares to set off to Milan, but an opportunity offers of getting money, and he delays his journey.

DINNER being over, I ordered Sayavedra to hire horses for Milan, whither I intended to proceed the next day; for, after what had happened to me at Bologna, that place had now become more unpleasant and dangerous to me than Florence. Whilst my squire was gone to execute this commission, I called upon my lawyer again, and offered him my purse, but, still carrying on his generosity, he declined it, telling me that all he wished of me was to be persuaded that he regretted nothing so much as his inability to obtain me justice. I replied, that I felt as much obliged to him as if he had obtained for me a restitution of all I had lost; and we parted with the most sincere protestations of service and friendship.

Having returned to the inn, and finding myself at a loss how to employ my time, I amused myself by looking over three gentlemen who were at cards. I seated myself at the side of one of them, and observed his game; and, by a whim common enough to the human mind, felt myself insensibly more concerned in his behalf than for the two others. When he lost I felt sorry, and when he won I was as glad as if I was entitled to a share of his gains. Fortune was for a long time doubtful between the three players, though the money flew about among them in plenty. They had each at least thirty pistoles before them, and played for large stakes. The one whom I felt interested for seemed to know the least of the game, and was consequently soon the loser, when the company grew warm, and the bets began to run high, I longed mightily to advise; and though I knew that would not be fair, I could scarcely resist when I perceived that he had lost almost all his money. At length he lost the last farthing; after which he rose and left the room, telling the company he would procure more money, and should expect his revenge after supper. By what I afterwards learnt, this young man had just arrived at Bologna, to take his degrees in the civil law, for which purpose his friends had supplied him with sixty pistoles, which he had thus quickly got rid of, without having obtained even his doctor's cap. One of the two gentlemen who had so completely emptied his pockets was one of his fellow-students, a nobleman of Bologna, and the other had the

appearance of a French officer. This latter was somewhat older than his comrades, and the most skilful of the three. The French are no fools at gaming, though they sometimes meet with persons of other nations who trim them in their turns.

I withdrew to my own room, so much the more sorry that my doctor *in fieri* had lost, as I feared I had brought him ill-luck. Prepossessed with this ridiculous idea, I reproached myself in having stood by him all the game, and considered myself as the cause of his ruin. Then recollecting myself, and blushing at my foolish sensibility: what an egregious fool I am, thought I, thus to torment myself about what does not in the least concern me. Have I not troubles enough of my own, but I must grieve for other people's losses? While my mind was occupied with these thoughts, I heard the young man enter his own room which was only divided from mine by a thin partition. He had just returned from the town without having been able to get any more money, and, more enraged against those who had refused to lend him any than those who had stripped him of his last farthing, "What misery!" cried he; "is it possible that in a town like Bologna, an honest man cannot find means of borrowing thirty pistoles? sure the inhabitants must be Turks instead of Christians;—indeed I can scarcely believe but the Turks would have humanity enough to relieve me in such an emergency!" Thus saying, he sighed most bitterly and stalked up and down the room for a considerable time; then relapsing into his passion, he roared like a bull, struck the table with his fist, and bestowed all the curses he could think of on the inhabitants of Bologna. At length, tired of raving and swearing, he threw himself upon the bed, continuing his lamentations in a more plaintive tone.

In vain did I endeavour to harden my heart, for I felt, in spite of myself, much afflicted at his misfortune. At this moment my confidant entered my chamber, and told me that after considerable difficulty, he had been so fortunate as to find return horses to Milan. "Speak low my friend," said I, in a whisper. "My neighbor is so distressed at the loss of his money, that he has excited my pity, and I will confess to you that I have some idea of avenging his cause." "How can you effect that?" said Sayavedra. "By taking his place this evening, and playing in his stead, to be sure," answered I. "It must be neck or nothing—full pockets or empty all of a sudden. At all events, it is very certain that the small sum we have now left will not carry us far. Thirty pistoles, which is the utmost we have, will go such a little way

with travellers who do not condescend to walk, and who live like noblemen at inns, that it appears to me we cannot hesitate a moment. What think you, Sayavedra, what do you advise? Tell me not that I am going to occupy the place of one whose ill-luck may be contagious, as I am no superstitious player, and besides shall be quite a match for my opponents.”

My confidant replied, “that he always approved of whatever I thought proper to do; but that since I condescended to consult him, he would recommend me not to trust too much to chance, but to take measures to ensure good fortune.” “What measures?” said I, pretending to be quite a novice in the business. “Are you ignorant then,” said he, “that when people play for the sake of whining, it is common to make use of every means without ceremony to strip our neighbour’s pockets? Honest folks now-a-days do this without the slightest scruple of conscience. Be assured, that what I tell you is true, and be not a greater fool than others; I will assist you as far as the little knowledge I have in these matters will avail.” I was overjoyed at this proposal of Sayavedra’s; and more particularly as he volunteered his services on this occasion; for up to this moment I had kept up at least the *appearance* of honesty with him, which is absolutely necessary if one expects to be faithfully served.

I now, however, told him that, as he well knew, I could have no other object than that of gain, and that if he was acquainted with an infallible mode of always playing with success, I should be glad to learn it of him; and that if even there were a little spice of knavery in it, it were surely pardonable in the present deplorable condition of my finances. He was charmed in his turn at my apparent readiness to submit to his instructions. “I need only give you one lesson,” said he, “to enable you to get all the money at the table. I shall watch my opportunities to take a turn round the room, either to snuff the candles, or to bring you a glass of wine; meantime I shall see what cards your adversaries hold, which I can easily communicate to you by signs agreed upon between us.” Sayavedra having thus instructed me, I agreed with him that I should be a fool indeed were I lose with such an assistant. We agreed then upon our signs, and my preceptor did not fail to perceive that he had a very apt scholar in me.

About supper time I repaired to the parlour, where the two fortunate players were already in waiting. My neighbour, the young lawyer, soon arrived, and we all sat down to table. During the whole of the repast, this young gentleman, melancholy as he was at heart, used every effort to

appear gay, talked a great deal, drank the healths of all present, and affected the utmost good humour. After supper his two opponents proposed cards, and as they were taking their seats, the young lawyer said: "Gentlemen, I trust you will not object to play with me for thirty pistoles on my honour, having to-morrow a very considerable sum to receive." At these words the Frenchman pulled a long face, and said nothing; and his companion declared at once, that he played with no one upon credit: that he had taken an oath to that effect, having always remarked that it brought him ill-luck. "Very well, gentlemen," replied the other, "have but a little patience, and I will run to a merchant whom I was not so fortunate as to find at home in the morning, who will in a moment lend me whatever I want. The two gentlemen answered that he would be sure to find them in the parlour if he returned before midnight."

It was now my turn to speak; addressing myself therefore to the two gentlemen who remained, I suggested, that if agreeable to them I should not object to make a third hand until the return of their comrade: that I would instantly give up my place to him should he rejoin the party, as having determined to leave that place very early the next morning, I could not have the pleasure of their company long. The gentlemen, who judged from my physiognomy that I could have but little knowledge of the game, answered, with joy, that they should esteem it an honour. While they were preparing the cards, I called to Sayavedra to bring me some money. He threw our whole stock, which was about thirty pistoles, on the table with a careless air, telling me he would go up stairs and get more if I thought I should require it. I replied that it was quite sufficient, for that I should think of retiring to bed when that was lost.

We were soon in a proper train. Sayavedra seated himself in a chair near the fire-place, and remained there by my orders to be in readiness to wait upon us. Being rather lucky in the onset, I soon got a hundred crowns in my pocket, without the least chicanery. This looks well, thought I, and if unfortunately for me he should return with his purse replenished, I shall not have occupied his seat for nothing. My good luck seemed to vex my adversaries exceedingly, who, fearing lest I should retire to bed, as I continually kept threatening to do, in order to irritate them the more, proposed to double the stakes. I made no objection, and a moment after, seeing that now was the time, I called to Sayavedra, "Wake up you lazy dog," said I, "have you nothing to do but to sleep there? give me a glass of

wine directly.” He rose up with the most innocent air possible, pretended to be but half awake, and in pouring out a glass of wine, enabled me by his signals to pocket fifteen of my opponents’ pistoles in a twinkling. My fund was now considerably increased; but to keep up the plan we had agreed upon, I allowed them to win some of this back again, though I might easily have added to my gains.

To say the truth, with my own knowledge of the tricks of the game, I might easily have emptied the purses of these gentlemen, who were by no means good players. It must, however, be confessed that I won their money much quicker with Sayavedra’s assistance, especially when it was not my turn to shuffle the cards. At last, I found myself master of all the money that had been spread upon the table, and said, “Gentlemen, it is very late; you know that I have a right to retire: nevertheless, that you may not think that I wish to carry off your money, and take an undue advantage, let us play again to-morrow, and I will not set off as I intended, though I have already hired horses for that purpose.” Nothing being more capable of consoling losers than the hope of having their revenge, they pressed me no longer to continue the game that night, and we accordingly separated, each taking the way to his own room, they fearing that I should break my word, and I fully determined to keep it.

Joy of having won so much money, and the agitation of my spirits caused by the game, prevented me for a long time from tasting the sweets of sleep. Happily, however, nothing but agreeable images occupied my thoughts. It was very different with my unfortunate neighbour, who had returned from the city without having been able to raise any money, and, not daring to shew his face in the parlour, had sneaked to bed full of rage and shame. I heard him sigh most bitterly, and tossing himself in bed from one side to the other. I was delighted in having avenged his cause to my own profit; but what is strange, felt no longer any compassion for him, as though he was less to be pitied because I had got his money. So true it is that we commiserate the misfortunes which we do not cause, but are insensible to those which are advantageous to ourselves.

The next morning my two gaming friends were particularly anxious to ascertain of the servants whether I was gone or not, and were much pleased when they learnt that I had really postponed my departure. They were afraid that I should escape them, while on the other hand nothing was less in my thoughts than to leave them without making myself master of the remainder

of their money; but to increase their anxiety, I did not make my appearance in the parlour until dinner time. Without appearing to take any notice of them, I soon perceived, even during our meal, how eager they were to return to the attack with me; meantime I affected a coldness and indolence, the better to persuade them that it was purely out of complaisance that I was willing to give them their revenge.

No sooner was dinner over than cards were brought in, and my two champions, to shew that they were well provided for the contest, drew out a long purse each, well stored with good pistoles and Spanish doubloons, which they threw on the table, saying, "Behold, signor cavalier, what you will no doubt carry off to-morrow with you." Little did they think how truly they said this! We took our places then, and the game commenced. It was my intention to lose at this point, so that I had no occasion for Sayavedra. It being by no means my intention that they should win much of me, I manœuvred it so well that I lost but about forty crowns after dinner, when the Frenchman proposed to play higher. "No," said I, "we have played now for a long time; let us therefore rest a little, and we shall then be better able to devote a part of the night to this religious pastime."

The hope they entertained of treating me still worse, or rather of ruining me, enabled them to keep up their patience until after supper. On my side my intentions towards them were not a whit more charitable, which I soon made appear when we set to again. Fortune was at first rather adverse, but with my own skill and the assistance of my faithful squire, I soon obliged her to declare herself for me, and my gentlemen soon lost all their doubloons, which were transferred from their purses into mine. After which, leaving the game to go to their chambers, they told me that if I should be in the humour to give them another game the next day, they should not be afraid of me. I answered that I should like nothing better, and that they would find me always ready to accommodate them.

I then retired to my own chamber with my confidant, who immediately prepared to undress me, but I prevented him. "It is no time now to enjoy rest," said I; "it is too late to enjoy the comfort of reposing between two sheets at this inn. I intend to depart hence without beat of drum as soon as possible." Sayavedra reminded me that I had first promised the gentlemen to play another game with them. "I have not forgotten," replied I, "that I made such a promise; but I am not such a fool as to think of keeping it. Imagine to yourself the dangers I should expose myself to, by remaining

any longer in this city. If it was in the power of the thieves to get me imprisoned, after having themselves robbed me, what may I not reasonably fear from honest folks who have real cause to accuse me of roguery? We have already won above six hundred crowns. Let us be content, therefore, and betake ourselves to a place of safety as soon as possible. Have you not hired horses?" "Undoubtedly," answered he, "I have paid their master for their day's work, and they will be in waiting for us by break of day." "So much the better," replied I, "for I shall not consider my purse in safety till I am at least ten good leagues from this place." My confidant left me to enjoy a few minutes' rest, well pleased to hear that we were possessed of so considerable a booty, and flattering himself with the sweet hope of having some part of it for his share. He was not, however, without some anxiety on this point when he recalled to mind the history of my trunks, which he feared was too recent a transaction to have so soon escaped my memory.

As soon as he heard the least noise in the house, and imagined the servants were stirring, he returned to my chamber, where he found me quite ready for starting. In fact, I had not so much as reclined upon the bed the whole night, but was most agreeably occupied in counting my treasure, putting the gold on one side, and the silver on the other, and in packing up as expeditiously as possible our little property. We soon settled with the landlord, and gained the spot where our horses were in waiting. The city gates were scarcely opened before we found ourselves in the country. Never was so lovely a morning. At any other time I should have admired its charms, but in the agitated state of my spirits the beauty of the day was very indifferent to me. My object was to get over the ground, imagining every moment that the hounds of justice would be up with me, and re-conduct me to the prisons of Bologna, there to compel me to restore the money I had so dexterously possessed myself of. I turned round every moment to see if any one was following us, and when I perceived a gentleman behind trotting faster than we were, my heart beat, my colour changed, and I did not recover myself until he fairly passed us on the road. So true is it, that every criminal carries about with him his own punishment.

I became by degrees more tranquil, and when we had travelled about four leagues, felt but little fear remaining. Breaking the silence which both my companion and I had kept till that moment: "Are you not tired, Sayavedra," said I, "of thus travelling like two Carthusian friars? For my part, I feel quite absorbed in idle meditation. Let us talk. Tell me some story

which may enliven us.” “Signor Don Guzman,” said he, “you will, I am sure, be ready to allow that it much better becomes him who has plenty of money in his pocket to tell merry stories, than him who has not a sous wherewith to bless himself.” “I understand you, my friend,” answered I, smiling; “but I assure you, that at dinner time we will come to a reckoning, and I trust you will not have cause to be dissatisfied.” “How you catch at every joke I pass,” replied he, laughing aloud; “I protest that I had not such a thought, knowing full well that in serving you I have done but my duty, for which I am amply paid in the pleasure of having assisted you in fleecing those two gulls of their doubloons.” The disinterestedness which Sayavedra assumed, whether real or false, pleased me exceedingly; and it being by no means my intention to baulk him of the remuneration due to him for his signs, I made him a present of twenty pistoles, as soon as we arrived at a little inn where we stopped to dine.

CHAP. XXXIX.

Sayavedra, to amuse Guzman on the road, relates to him the history of his life.

WE remounted our horses, after having made a much better meal than we expected on entering so inconsiderable an inn; and, far from preserving the silence we had kept up all the morning, we conversed on various subjects. Amongst the rest I chanced to ask Sayavedra how he first became an adventurer. He answered, that the only way to satisfy my curiosity was to relate to me the history of his life. I assured him, that it would afford me great pleasure to hear his adventures, and, without any more ceremony, he began in these terms:

“Though I told you at Rome that I was born at Seville, it was not the truth. Valencia was in reality my native place, where perhaps may be found more rogues than in any other city in Spain; because it is a place which abounds with good things, and rich countries seldom produce honest men. My father was certainly only a commoner, but of that sort of citizens who pretend to hold up their heads with the nobility. Having lost his wife whom he loved tenderly, he took it so much to heart, that he did not long survive her. He left two sons; and these two sons, of whom I was the younger, sold all his property, which was but trifling, and divided its produce equally. After which my brother asked me what plans I had in my head. I confessed to him candidly, that my ruling passion was to travel. And mine also, said he. I have always taken pleasure in any accounts of foreign countries, and long extremely to see how people live who were not born in Spain. Both led on thus by the force of our stars, or rather, perhaps by our own evil propensities, we set off together one fine morning from Valencia, each with a small parcel under his arm.

“We had not travelled above a league, when my brother said to me: a thought has just entered my head. We are about to abandon ourselves to fortune, and as we cannot know in what manner she may treat us, we may hereafter find ourselves in situations where our greatest pain may be that we are known, and that our real names may be covered with infamy. To prevent this misfortune, let us change them. I approved of this idea, and we soon

found ourselves fresh names. My brother took that of Mateo Lujan, and as I recollected that the most illustrious in Seville was that of Sayavedra, I assumed that name, which I have passed by ever since. Being decked out with these fine titles then," continued he, "we began to think of the route we should take. I had declared my wish to pass into Italy, and my brother testified the same desire; but changing his mind all of a sudden, he took it into his head to go to France. The dispute ran so high between us on the subject, that on arriving at cross roads, one of which led to Saragossa and the other to Barcelona, my brother took the former, and I the latter, wishing each other every sort of happiness and prosperity. After this fraternal separation, I repaired to Barcelona, intending, as well as a great many other persons who were waiting there with the same design, to take my passage by the galleys. They did not arrive, however, until above a month after; during which time I dressed handsomely, sought the best company, and young Signor Sayavedra was extremely well received every where. He gamed, gave entertainments, and did not fail to devote some portion of his time to love. In short I made so merry during this interval, that when the galleys arrived, and my debts were paid, I embarked with six pistoles only in my pocket. We arrived safely at Genoa, where, finding a vessel on the point of sailing for Naples, I would not lose so good an opportunity, and the wind being extremely favourable, we made but a short voyage of it.

"If on the one hand I was now rejoiced to find myself in the city, which of all others I had wished to be in, how mortified was I on the other when I considered the condition of my purse, which was as empty as any hermit's. Doubtless, thought I, Naples is a place where pleasures abound: but they are as dear here as elsewhere, and a man without money in his pocket will cut but a very ridiculous figure. I knew well that I must be industrious, and accordingly addressed myself to certain other gentlemen who lived by their wits. I apprised them of my desire and necessity to become one of their brethren. My roguish air prepossessed them instantly in my favour, and after a short examination which I was obliged to undergo, I was pronounced to be fully qualified to be one of their company. I was no sooner enrolled, than they made me commence my operations in their way of business. By their own confession I acquitted myself as if the principles were innate with me; and accordingly I was soon employed in all sorts of thieving, that is to say, in cutting purses, picking locks, stealing cloaks in the darkness of the night; in short a hundred such-like exercises, which are but A, B, C, to old

practitioners in the science, but have a wonderful tendency to raise an honest man step by step to the gallows.

“But without vanity, my abilities were of too superior a kind to confine myself to these little tricks, and I certainly performed two or three which were considered master-pieces. I must relate one of them to you. The Lord High Constable’s house was the rendezvous of every person of quality, who assembled there of an evening to play. I had already been once in this house while the game had been going on, and had observed every thing with a curious eye. I had particularly noticed that on each of the tables there stood two handsome silver candlesticks with wax lights, and I determined to think of some expedient by which I could possess myself of a pair of them. With this view I bought a pair of pewter ones of about the same height, with two wax candles in them. I managed to get these very conveniently into my pocket, and one evening having dressed myself so that I might pass for a boy belonging to one of the gentlemen of the party, I stole to the high Constable’s house, and posted myself at the door of a small room where two young gentlemen only were at play. I perceived with pleasure that all the pages of the house were engaged in the other rooms, which appeared to be full of company. My two players continued engaged together for a long time, and their candles being almost burnt out seemed to require fresh ones. I seized this favourable moment, and drawing from my pocket my pewter candlesticks, I lighted my wax candles by the lamp on the staircase, and entered the room in which the two gentlemen were with a most respectful bow, and with my two candlesticks in my hand. These I placed boldly on the table in the place of the two silver ones, which I carried off under my cloak after having extinguished them. I then ran as fast as my legs would carry me to our captain, who was the receiver-general of our stolen goods, a very grave personage, and who passed in the city as a very honest man. He acted both as a protector and a lawyer towards us when we happened to be caught in a trap: and out of gratitude we gave him a fifth part of the produce of all the thefts we committed.

“Another time I performed a still more desperate trick. I happened to be passing one morning before a house which appeared to be the residence of some man of opulence, and which turned out afterwards to be really the case. The door being open I walked in. I entered two or three rooms on the same floor, without meeting any one, and I perceived, on the table of the last, a complete new lady’s dress of the finest velvet. I deposited this

without ceremony under my cloak, and in two jumps was in the hall again; but unfortunately I found the master of the house at the door, who seeing me come out with a large parcel under my arm, stopped me short, and enquired in a voice of thunder what I had got under my cloak. Most people in my situation would have been quite confounded; but I, on the contrary, without being in the least at a nonplus, answered him immediately, that it was his lady's velvet robe which I was carrying home in order to set the collar to rights and alter one of the sleeves. So much the better, replied he, but you must bring it back as soon as possible, for my wife will want it this afternoon, to visit a lady of quality of her acquaintance. I assured him that I would not fail, and thus saying, shot from him as swift as a roebuck.

“This adventure soon spread itself in the town; and even the next day I heard that the gentleman, after having spoken to me, immediately entered his house, where he heard his wife and two or three of the servants making as much noise as if they were in a tavern; that the mistress was crying out most vehemently: where is my velvet robe? it was here not one minute ago: you shall pay me for it:—that the servants having seen no one either enter or leave the house, protested that it must have been the devil who had carried it off; and that at last the husband quieted this uproar, by telling them what had really become of it. I was given to understand also, that the officers of justice had been informed of it; that my person had been very accurately described to them, and they were actually every where in search for me, the gentleman whom I had robbed being himself a notary. During all this time, my booty was in safety at our protector's house, where the whole company laughed heartily at their fruitless exertions to find me. Nevertheless this trick, which I played with as much good luck as dexterity, had consequences which do not occupy a very agreeable place in my memory. Thus it happened:

“Happening one day to be taking a stroll out of the city, near a pretty large rivulet, I observed some very fine linen on the banks, which a laundress had just washed and spread out upon the grass. Such opportunities as these always tempted me; and I could not resist my extreme desire of making myself master of some part of this linen; the more especially as I really was in want of some. I only waited, therefore, for the moment when I could make the attempt without being perceived, and that moment at length arriving, I performed the exploit with such rapidity, that to possess myself of some of the very best of the linen, and take the way

back to the town, was done in the twinkling of an eye. Though the old washerwoman had not observed the action at the moment, it so happened that she just afterwards turned her head to look at her linen. Astonished to perceive a reduction of at least two-thirds she looked quickly around her, and seeing nobody but me, she thought rightly enough that I must be the thief, and accordingly, leaving the remainder of her linen to take its chance, she ran after me, crying out: *stop thief! stop thief!* in a voice which made the country resound. In this embarrassment, what could I do? I let the parcel slip gently from under my cloak upon the ground, hoping that the laundress satisfied with having her property, would pursue me no further; but, whether she thought that I had more about me, or was bent upon my ruin, she followed me up to the city gates, where the sentry stopped me, asking what was the matter. The washerwoman was soon up with us, and began immediately by cuffing me, saying that I had stolen the whole of her linen. I was then searched all over, and as my cloak and the under part of my arm were wet through, it was easy enough to guess that I had got rid of the bundle, in order to deny that I had robbed my accuser. Nothing more was necessary to entitle me to a lodging in one of the palaces of justice.

“I communicated my imprisonment to our lawyer, who came to me immediately. I told him the circumstances, and he repaired to a criminal judge. They had a long conversation together, which ended with the promise that I should be set at liberty that very day. He brought me the good news, and I prepared to leave the place. The order was already made out, the gaoler satisfied, and I had one foot out of prison, when by the malice of the devil, my friend the notary, who had been so actively in search for me, and who happened to have a little business there, presented himself before me. He stared me full in the face, and recognizing me immediately, he flew in a passion, gave me a violent blow with his fist, which made me reel back into the prison again, and told the gaoler to lock me in, for that I had robbed him, and he would certainly get me committed. Our lawyer, who was present, exerted all his flowers of rhetoric to appease him. He even went so far as to promise the value of the robe; but the cursed notary, preferring the pleasure of being revenged on me, to that of recovering his property, was inexorable: the consequences of which were that I was honoured with a hearty whipping, and banished the kingdom.

“After this disgrace, which I bore as patiently as I could, my captain, by way of consolation, offered me a letter of recommendation to a friend of

his, the chief of a banditti who inhabited a retreat in the Roman mountains, which, not knowing what better I could do, I accepted of. The chief had no sooner read my letter than he gave me a most gracious reception. He introduced me to the cavaliers of his company, than whom I never saw more savage looking animals. It is true, that having left at Naples comrades so perfectly civilized, it was impossible but these mountaineers must have appeared to me wild and unsociable. Nevertheless, as one must always follow the fashion, I by degrees became accustomed to them, notwithstanding the terrible life they led. We made some good hits, and I found myself in a short time with a purse well stocked. No sooner was this the case than I determined on leaving these honest folks. With this view, I requested leave of our chief for two months, under pretence of having some business at Rome. This was readily granted me, on my taking oath that I would return at the expiration of that time. This oath I certainly submitted to, but fully determined to forget it as soon as I got to Rome.

“I had pictured to myself that in so fine a city, I should find opportunities to exercise my talents at every step I took. When, however, I had been there long enough to study the genius of the inhabitants, they appeared to me to be so cunning themselves, that I stood no chance among them. I made a few hits, but of such a nature as would do me no credit to repeat. In the last of these I narrowly escaped detection. This caused me to leave Rome suddenly, whence I thought proper to make the tour of Italy, that I might know it well, and I spent all my money in this wandering life. At length, being at Bologna, chance made me acquainted with Alexander Bentivoglio, who received me into his little troop. This man seems born for his profession. His custom is to leave his native place from time to time, and travel through the different towns in search of dupes; and after he has made any good stroke, he returns to Bologna, where he is always sure to be safe, as though nothing had happened. I occasionally accompanied him in these trips, and I was at Rome on his business, the day on which your lordship was persecuted by the mob. I called upon you at the Ambassador’s—you had the imprudence to display all your property and expose all your affairs to me—I reported this to captain Alexander, who immediately planned the trick we played you. This action, continued he, is always present to my mind; and my extreme sorrow on this account will be constantly nourished by your excessive kindness to me.”

Sayavedra here concluded his history. After which his various adventures formed the topic of our conversation on the road towards Milan, where we arrived both fresh and merry, and similarly well-disposed to possess ourselves of the property of others.

CHAP. XL.

Of the daring enterprize which Guzman and Sayavedra formed together in the city of Milan.

WE passed the first three days in walking about the streets, examining the different articles with which the shops were decked out, without thinking as yet of turning our genius to advantage. Happy times for the citizens of Milan!

As we were strolling as usual one morning, a young man, tolerably well dressed, accosted Sayavedra who was behind me. I always walked first, and did not perceive him until I had got about a hundred paces on. I then looked attentively at this young man who had stopped my confidant, and there was something mettlesome and cunning in his appearance which I did not like. Oh, oh! thought I, who can this chap be; what business can they have together? This is what I must know; but how can I possibly learn? Were I to call Sayavedra, and ask him the subject of this conversation, he would not fail to frame a lie in an instant, and I should not be a bit the wiser. All I can do then is to keep quiet, let them go on their own way, betray no suspicion of Sayavedra, but keep a sharp eye over him.

Their conversation lasted above a quarter of an hour; after which, the young man took his leave of my confidant, who rejoined me with a thoughtful air, which by no means dissipated my suspicions. I was in hopes that he would have explained the rencontre to me; but he said not a word about it, still remaining in a reverie. I kept silence also until after dinner, when finding myself alone with him, and being able no longer to contain myself: "Mr. Sayavedra," said I, smiling, "may I presume to ask who that young man might be with whom you had so serious a conversation this morning? I think I have seen him at Rome. Is not his name Mendocia?" "No Sir," replied he, "he is named Aguilera, and I assure you very appropriately so called; for he shews himself a true eagle whenever he has occasion to use his claws. He is a good companion, has a tolerable share of wit, and is very clever in many respects. We have known each other for a long time, have travelled in company, and have suffered a great deal together. His head is at present full of a scheme, which, if it succeed, will make his fortune. He

proposed to me to be a party to it, offering me half the profits. I told him that I would undertake nothing, without first apprising you of it. I even went so far as to add that you were so extremely kind to me, that I felt assured you would not refuse us your advice in an affair of such consequence.” “No,” said I, “undoubtedly I would not: on the contrary, my friend, I am well disposed to assist you both. Let me know what is the subject in debate.” “Sir,” replied he, “Aguilera is to call here this afternoon, when you can speak to him yourself. He will disclose his whole project to you, and if there be any alteration required in his plan, you can adjust it to perfection.”

He had no sooner said these words, than he was informed that a young man wished to speak with him. We had no doubt but this was Aguilera, for we knew no one else at Milan. Sayavedra ran to meet him; and after having prepared him for the conversation we should have together, he introduced him to me. We saluted each other with much politeness. Aguilera was a well looking young man, and appeared to me to possess good sense. He confirmed every thing my confidant had told me, and related to me in an agreeable manner several of their exploits together. He then informed me, that having come to Milan in the hope of making some good hit, he had found means to introduce himself to the service of a rich banker, with whom he had lived about six months as his clerk: that he had by his assiduity and fidelity entirely gained the confidence of his patron, waiting patiently until he found a good opportunity of robbing him: that such a one now presented itself; but, that he had occasion for a second to avail himself of it, and that in meeting Sayavedra, he looked upon him as a man sent from heaven for that express purpose, being well acquainted with his abilities that way. I asked him, “if there would be any difficulty in the execution of his design.” “Not a great deal,” replied he, “but you shall judge for yourself. The banker has within these few days deposited in his strong box a large shamois leather purse, containing one thousand good pistoles. It is my intention to take possession of these on Sunday morning, while my patron is at mass, and to join Sayavedra at a certain place, where he shall have two horses in waiting. We shall be off in an instant, and ride our hacks so vigorously that we shall be far enough from the city, before the banker can discover the copious bleeding his strong box shall have sustained.”

After having listened to Aguilera very attentively, I told him that his undertaking was of a much more delicate nature than he himself seemed to imagine: that, being known in the town as the confidential clerk of the

banker, he might meet some person on the road, who, surprised to see him travelling on a post horse, would naturally suspect him of some roguery, and immediately communicate his suspicions to his master: that the banker on his return from mass would perhaps immediately discover that he had been robbed; that this report would soon spread itself about the town, and that it would soon be ascertained that Aguilera had set off with post horses: the consequence of which would be, that his patron would have him pursued by certain persons well mounted, whom it might be rather difficult to escape. I urged many other objections, which convinced him that his plan was but ill-conceived. He confessed this, but told me at the same time, that he should nevertheless execute it, as he saw no better way. I have to do, continued he, with a man who never leaves his house, except on Sundays to hear mass, and then immediately on his return shuts himself up as before in the room in which he keeps his papers and money.

“It matters nothing,” replied I, “be he never so vigilant, ’twill be easy enough to get this same shamois leather purse into our hands, without exposing yourself to the danger you are willing to rashly to incur. In good faith, gentlemen, if you know no better than this, you are as yet but apprentices to your trade. I will shew you a genius superior to that of many besides you. I will take upon myself, if it so please you, the charge of conducting this enterprise, and without implicating you in any misfortune that may happen to me in consequence; even though fortune be adverse to me, I will answer for the thousand pistoles, provided they remain in the strong box eight days longer.” Sayavedra and his friend laughed heartily at this speech, at which they were almost as much delighted as if the pistoles were already in their hands. They thanked me for the offer, and readily left the conducting of this affair to me; well persuaded, particularly Sayavedra, that I should not talk in this strain without being well assured of the event. “Give yourselves no further trouble about it then, gentlemen,” added I, “you shall see that one who has been a page five or six years is somewhat wiser than a Roman bandit.” This hit at Sayavedra redoubled their mirth, and we were all very merry together. I then proceeded to question this confidential clerk of the banker’s more particularly.

“By what means,” said I, “did you intend to get the purse out of the strong box; you have not the key of it?” “Certainly not,” replied he, “for my patron will trust it to nobody. He occasionally gives it to me when I happen to be with him in his private room, and some person happens to come in,

when he is himself engaged, for the payment of a bill. He throws me the key to take out a bag of which he tells me the number, and while I am counting the money, he keeps one eye on what he is writing and the other on me." "This being the case," continued I, "it would be very difficult to take an impression of the key." "Much less so, perhaps, than you imagine," answered Aguilera. "I have, God be praised, a pretty dexterous hand, and will undertake to bring you the impression of it; and also, if you think proper, that of the press, in which the banker locks up his account-books and his daily cash." At these words, which delighted me, I told him that if he could procure both the impressions, we should be much more sure of success.

I did not forget to ascertain the situation of the room; the manner in which the bags were tied up; their marks; in fact every particular that I considered necessary, of which I wrote down a circumstantial account. I then sent Aguilera home to his master, telling him that I would give him timely notice of the part he would have to play. After his departure, I told my confidant that I had put his friend to a difficult trial, and that I doubted much whether he would procure the impressions of the keys. But Sayavedra, who had a better opinion of his talents, thought otherwise, and he was certainly right. Within two days after Aguilera kept his word, and informed me, also, where I might find a locksmith who would make me two false keys, provided I paid him handsomely. "I have but one more question to ask you," said I, "at what hour is your master to be seen? for bankers are generally particular." Aguilera answered, "that the best time was between ten o'clock and noon." "Good," said I, "return home then, and remember well what I now tell you: I shall not fail to be at the banker's house by ten o'clock to-morrow morning; arrange it so that you be with him at that time, and be sure you lose not a word of my conversation with him, in order that you may be brought forward as a witness, if necessary."

Every thing being so far arranged, I carried the impressions to the honest locksmith I had been recommended to, and whom I found in reality the man for my business. He promised to make me two keys immediately for two pistoles, one of which I paid him in advance. On my return to my inn, I espied in a shop window a very neat sort of jewel box, which after having carefully examined, I bought. Sayavedra who accompanied me, appeared somewhat surprised at this purchase. I could not resist laughing at his astonishment: "Friend," said I, "be assured that this little casket will not be

without its use.” “I do not doubt it,” answered he smiling; “you have not made a fool’s bargain. You doubtless know the use you intend to put it to, and I leave that as well as every thing else to your superior judgment.”

I went the next morning at ten precisely to the banker’s counting-house. Aguilera was there, and two or three gentlemen on business. I bowed to the master on entering the room, and addressing him in a loud voice, told him that I was come to Milan with the intention of making some purchases previously to my marriage: that I had brought a considerable sum of money which I should be glad to place in safety, and that instead of leaving it at my inn where there were all sorts of people, I had thought it much better to trust it to a man like him, whose probity I had heard much commended: I added, that I had a short voyage to take to Venice which would oblige me to have a credit from his house. The banker, greedy of gain, made me a thousand offers of service, accompanied by the most profound bows, and asked me the amount of the sum I wished to deposit in his hands. I answered, about twelve thousand franks of gold, and a small bag of silver specie, which I would send him in about an hour. He replied that my time was his: then reaching down his day-book from the press, he enquired my name, which I gave him as Don Juan Osorio. This he immediately wrote down, with the date of the day and month, the better to ensure my keeping my word.

After this, having no further business with him at that time, I took my leave, after a thousand mutual compliments, entreating him not to leave his house until my return. I reached home well satisfied with the happy commencement of my scheme. Sayavedra, who was waiting for me, with the more impatience, as he was more interested in the business than I was, was not a little astonished, when I informed him what I had just done. “But, sir,” said he, “pray where do you intend to get these twelve thousand franks which you have promised to carry to the banker’s? I am at a loss to know this.” “That need not give you the least uneasiness,” answered I, “he has them already. I know well enough that this is Hebrew to you, but I have my reasons. Press me no more on this point at present, but tell me whether your friend Aguilera reckons among his talents that of being able to forge writing.” “Forge!” cried he with transport, “he can counterfeit any one’s hand; it is his fort. Would to heaven that I had only the money he has touched by such means! if he had not excelled in that art, he would still have been at Rome; but he was obliged to decamp thence somewhat abruptly, for fear of falling into the hands of a brute of a merchant, who,

having discovered that he had forged his signature, was in pursuit of him.” “This being the case,” replied I, “our enterprise must infallibly succeed.”

The reliance that Sayavedra placed in my skill, prevented his doubting the success I assured him of, though he knew nothing of my plans. All that vexed him was, that I had allotted no part in the performance to him, of which he complained to me, asking if he was to be dumb in the comedy. “Never fear,” said I, “I have reserved a character for you, which you will perform to admiration.” At the same time I ordered him to take under his arm the casket I had purchased and filled with lumps of lead. In addition to this I loaded him with a bag of money, bound round with red ribbon, and stained with ink in the middle, because, as well as I could remember, there was one exactly similar to it in the strong box. We left our chamber together, as if with the intention of carrying all this to the banker’s. Having got into the street, I said to my confidant, return for one moment into the kitchen, under pretence of asking our landlord what hour we shall dine, and what he intends for our dinner. In short, take care that his wife and he cannot fail to observe the casket with curiosity and attention. It is very essential to us that they should both take particular notice of it before you rejoin me.

No man in the world could be better adapted than Sayavedra, to acquit himself well on such a commission. He went into the kitchen, where, after having asked the landlord the question I had desired him, he displayed without ceremony the casket and bag of money. The landlord and landlady immediately fixed their eyes on them: the casket, especially, was so much admired by the wife, that she could not resist requesting to be allowed to examine it more closely. Her husband did the same, and exclaimed, “Good God, how heavy it is!” “It may well be so,” said Sayavedra, “since it is full of gold coin, to the amount of twelve thousand franks, which we are now going to deposit in a banker’s hands.” “At a banker’s!” cried the landlord abruptly, “though they contained above a hundred thousand franks, both that casket and bag would be as much in safety at my house as at the richest banker’s in the town.” The landlady, as ticklish as her husband on points of honour, added: “Yes, we have occasionally deposits of value left with us; and, thank God and the Virgin Mary, we have always taken good care of them.” “I doubt it not in the least,” replied Sayavedra. “Were you not considered honest people, my master would never have come to lodge with you with so much money. Think not then that he has a bad opinion of your

house; but, the fact is, that he is on the point of setting out for Venice, and having occasion for a letter of credit to that city, we are in fairness bound to leave these twelve thousand franks with the banker who will supply him with one."

"That alters the case," replied the host, appeased; "I have nothing more to say to it. What is the banker's name?" "Plati," replied my confidant. "Plague on him," continued the landlord, "he is as rich as Cræsus, but a very Jew. He will make you pay handsomely for your confidence, I can tell you. If you had only said one word to me, I could have recommended you to a much more reasonable house." "It is too late now," said Sayavedra; "my master has already agreed with this banker. But think not," continued he, "that I can gossip much longer with you, for my master is waiting for me. I merely came into the kitchen to ascertain whether we should have time to settle our business before dinner." The landlord begged that we would not hurry ourselves, and hoped that we should always find him ready to accommodate us in any way while in his house.

My confidant having repeated this conversation to me, we took a walk together quite out of the town. We returned after some time to the inn, where Sayavedra, by my desire, entered without being observed, and replaced both the casket and bag in my chamber. The table was not yet laid, the landlord, out of respect to me, having kept back the dinner, which was served up immediately he was told of my arrival. Having dined, I retired into my chamber and sent for the landlord, who immediately came up, begging to know in what he could serve me. I have a complaint to make against you, said I; how could you think me capable of suspecting so honourable a man as you? To convince you of the injustice you do me, I entreat you to take care of this purse containing a hundred pistoles, until my departure for Venice. So saying, I drew from my pocket a perfumed purse containing that sum exactly. He was so sensible of this mark of confidence, that he could scarcely restrain his joy.

In the evening the banker's clerk stole from his master to join us: "Well, Aguilera," said I, "your patron was doubtless very much surprised at not having seen me again this morning." "In truth he was," replied he: "after having waited above an hour expecting you, he began to fear that you would return no more. As he cannot be ignorant of his bad repute at Milan, he thinks that some person has been charitable enough to caution you against him, and I could perceive that he was extremely mortified." "Did

the three gentlemen who were with him when I called this morning, stay long after I was gone?" said I. "No," answered Aguilera, "nor did any one else drop in during the whole of the morning." I was much pleased at this circumstance, and assured my companions, that in three or four days, at latest, we should bring this piece to a finale. The banker's confidential gentleman, overjoyed with this prospect, wished me good night; but before we parted I desired that he would not call again at the inn, representing the consequences to him, and arranging between us that every day at a certain hour he should repair to a certain place, where Sayavedra should meet him and bring instructions from me.

My false keys were brought home two days after this. Aguilera, who was soon informed of this, told his friend he should have an opportunity of making use of them on the following Sunday after dinner, while the banker was amusing himself, as was his custom, at a game of chess, with one of his neighbours. I then let Sayavedra completely into the secret, in order that he might the better give his friend his instructions; and, on the Saturday evening I despatched him to the rendezvous, entrusting to his care the two false keys, and the casket, in which I put ten quadruples, thirty Roman crowns, and some slips of manuscript, instead of the lead which it before contained. As for the bag of money, I begged leave to keep that at home, having besmeared it with ink, and tied it up with red ribbon, merely that it might be exhibited to our landlord and his wife in that state, that they might testify to having seen it; so I had only put the lead into the casket to make it heavy, and to make these good folks believe that it was full of gold.

As soon as my confidant saw Aguilera, he said to him: "now my friend, listen to me with the utmost attention, and be particular in remembering what I tell you. Take these keys, and to-morrow, when you open the strong box, take out the shamois leather purse which is in it, and empty it into this casket; but be sure you take thirty pistoles out of the thousand you will find there, and substitute these ten quadruples in their place. You will not fail also to put this manuscript in, which contains a specification of the sum, and declares that it is the property of Don Juan Osorio, which is the name my master has assumed in this affair. This other slip of paper," continued he, "you must thrust into the bag in which you say there are three hundred and thirty crowns, and which is stained with ink, and tied up with a red ribbon. You will at the same time extract from this bag thirty of these crowns, and slip in these thirty Roman crowns in their stead. I have but one

thing now to tell, and which is most important of all; that is, to open the press in which your patron keeps his account books, and write in his journal the words you will find on this third paper, taking good care to let it be under the name of Don Juan Osorio, which you will find there entered, and also to imitate with your utmost dexterity the hand-writing of Signor Plati. Signor Don Guzman, my master," added he, "requires nothing more of you but what will be the easiest part of the performance, namely: that on Monday, at the wind up of the scheme, you affect to be a most zealous servant, call him all the vile names you can think of, and even strike him to make the scene more natural."

Aguilera here interrupted his friend. "Enough," said he; "I see plainly the whole of the project, and that the master you serve is indeed a thoroughbred thief. You may assure him that I shall do every thing he has prescribed for me, and it shall not be my fault if his plans be defeated." Sayavedra thereupon delivered up to him the casket with the three papers, the ten quadruples, and thirty Roman crowns, which Aguilera carried home and hid, until the time came to make use of them.

CHAP. XLI.

What was the success of this stratagem.

I DID not pass the Sunday without some uneasiness, fearing lest some untoward circumstance might defeat our enterprise; but my confidant having been to the usual place of rendezvous in the evening, returned full of joy to announce to me that every thing had been executed as I desired, and that Aguilera was preparing himself to play his part well the next day. This news restored my spirits, and I waited patiently for the hour when I should appear before the banker.

No sooner had it arrived, than I repaired to his house; he was alone in his counting-house. After saluting him very politely, I told him I had called to request that he would return me what I had brought him a few days before. He inquired with astonishment what I had brought him. "Zounds!" said I, "why the gold and silver specie which I deposited in your hands." "What gold and silver," answered he. "Oh, oh!" replied I, "what you affect to joke? Upon my soul, this is not bad." "Much more of a joke," rejoined he, "that you should expect me to refund what has never been given to me." "Let us have no more jesting, however," said I, "on matters of business, which, I assure you, is by no means to my taste." "Surely," said he, "it must be you that jest: I recollect well enough that a few days since you called upon me, and promised that within an hour you would bring me twelve thousand francs; but you forfeited your word." "Rather," answered I, "confess that you have lost your memory. I protest that I delivered that sum into your own hands, and will not quit this house until it be refunded in the very same coins in which I paid it to you." "Go about your business," replied he, "or I shall grow impatient with your nonsense. I neither know any thing of you, nor have I ever had any thing that belongs to you. Go and get your money from those to whom you entrusted it."

As the banker and I began now every moment to assume a higher tone, all the passers-by stopped to listen to our conversation, very anxious to know the subject of our dispute. That they might not be long in suspense I cried aloud, "Oh, traitor and infamous thief! may the justice of God and man unite to punish you! When I entrusted you with my money you

received me most obsequiously, but now I am come to reclaim it you affect not to know who I am, and with the most bare-faced effrontery deny the deposit! Cause the money to be counted out to me on this table instantly, or I will tear your soul out!" The banker on his side called me all the names I deserved, until from abusing each other we insensibly came to action, and he endeavoured to push me out of the room by his shoulders; but I repulsed him with such a blow as laid him sprawling on the floor. Aguilera then rushed upon me with a furious air, and gave me a few fisticuffs, which I returned in such sort, that several of the spectators entered to separate us. The confidential clerk finding himself restrained from rejoining me, pretended to struggle with those who held him, like a madman; while on my side, with my eyes glittering and my mouth foaming with rage, I defied him to approach me.

The affray had already lasted an hour, when the Bargello, by chance, or perhaps from some one's having told him what was going on, made his appearance. The first thing he did was to ask the subject of our quarrel, and the struggle now was which of us should speak first. He desired us both to hold our tongues; then having informed himself which of us was the complainant, he desired me to speak first, after which he would hear what my adversary had to say. At these words a profound silence succeeded, and every one present listened attentively. "Six days since," said I, "I came into this counting-house, and requested this same Signor Plati to allow me to deposit in his hands a considerable sum of money which I had brought to Milan with me, and which I did not think sufficiently secure at the inn where I lodge. He answered with much politeness that I had only to send him the money, and he would take care of it as long as I thought proper. I accordingly returned home immediately, and returned an hour after with my servant, who carried in a gilt casket a thousand pistoles in gold, and in a bag stained with ink and tied with a red ribbon three hundred and thirty crowns, thirty of which were Roman. The banker counted and weighed the coin, which he put with their specification in the casket and bag again, and then locked them altogether in his strong box."

Up to this moment the banker, not having dared to interrupt me, although in the fury that possessed him he could with difficulty restrain, had contented himself by raising his hands and eyes towards Heaven to witness my imposture: but his patience now entirely forsook him, and he could hold out no longer. "You see before you," cried he, "one of the most bare-faced

liars on the face of the earth. Should there be found in my house a casket such as that he mentions, I shall be content to forfeit my life and every thing I possess in the world.” “And if what I have told you be not true,” cried I, in my turn, “I will consent that the banker enjoy my property in peace, and that my ears be cut off like a traitor and audacious thief who dares demand what does not belong to him. It is a very easy matter,” continued I, “to discover the truth. Nothing remains but to open the strong box, where you will find my casket and bag, with the accounts which will inform you that the money belongs to me. Give orders, Signor Bargello, give orders immediately, I beseech you, that this old rogue show you his account books, where you will see what he himself wrote the day he received the money.” “You are right,” replied the Bargello, “and further conversation would be superfluous. Come, Signor Plati, if this gentleman gave you the specie, there will of course be an entry in your books.” “Undoubtedly,” answered the banker; “but I have no fear of your finding it, and if there should be any mention made of twelve thousand franks which this stranger assures you he entrusted to me, I will confess that he tells the truth, and that I am the impostor.” At the same time he told his clerk to reach him down the large account book out of his press. Aguilera had no sooner handed this to him, than I cried out: “No, no, thou knave! this is not the book that will bear witness against thee, it was a smaller but longer one.” Aguilera then said to his master, “He must surely mean our journal.” “Let it be the journal then,” replied the banker; “bring forward all the books in the house.” Aguilera then produced the journal, and asked me if that was the one I meant. I replied that it was. The Bargello immediately began to look it over, and finding in it what our colleague had written by my order, he read the following words in a loud voice:

“This day, the 13th of February 1586, Don Juan Osorio remitted me nine hundred and sixty pistoles in gold coin, Spanish and Italian, and ten quadruples, which make together the sum of one thousand pistoles, and which will be found in my strong box in a gilt casket. Moreover, I received from the said Don Juan the same day, a bag tied with red ribbon, in which are three hundred and thirty crowns, thirty of which are Roman.”

The company had no sooner heard this entry read than they all began to murmur against Signor Plati, thus giving me a decided advantage over him. Fortunately also for me, the banker did not pass in the town for an over-scrupulous man; so that every one readily believed the possibility of his

having played me the roguish trick of which I accused him. The Bargello made him read these words, and asked him if he had not written them. The citizen, confounded by so extraordinary a circumstance, answered in an agitation which almost deprived him of the power of speech, "that he had written the first words, but not the remainder." "How so," replied the officer of justice, "it appears to be all in the same hand-writing." "I cannot deny that," rejoined the banker, "but, nevertheless it is not all my writing." "It will avail you nothing to deny it in this manner," said the Bargello; "you must prove its falsity."

A fresh scene now contributed to convince the standers-by that I had not complained without cause. A voice of thunder resounded through the house, and a man with his kitchen apron and a large carving knife at his side made his appearance. This was mine host, whom Sayavedra had been in search of, and who, hearing that the banker denied having received the money, was furiously exasperated against him. "Why," cried he as he entered, "do they not hang this arch Jew? Why not fire his house, and burn him with all his race?" Then perceiving the officer of justice, "can you allow," said he, in a respectful and more moderate tone, "that a cavalier should be robbed, ruined, and struck, with impunity, for having trusted his property to a thief. This good gentleman lodges at my house, and I most solemnly assure you, that I have seen and handled the casket, as well as the bag which he has unfortunately confided to this banker, who is already but too well known at Milan for what he really is."

Signor Plati, thunderstruck as he was, said what he could in his own defence; but his feeble voice, which was scarcely audible at two paces from him, stood no chance with that of my landlord, which could be distinctly heard from one end of the street to the other. The people, therefore, who generally give the palm in such cases to him who makes the most noise, no longer doubting the justice of my complaint, cried aloud, that the banker should be compelled instantly to refund. The Bargello, addressing himself to the accused, represented to him, "that it was in vain to resist in retaining money which did not belong to him; that he would be compelled to make restitution, and that it was his duty to search his house for the casket and bag. Give me," added he, "the key of your strong box; let us begin by visiting that, as your accuser affirms it is there you have deposited them." Plati being apprehensive of pillage during this uproar could not make up his mind to deliver the key; upon which the general cry was to lead him to

prison. "We will do better than that," said the officer, "if he obey not this instant, I will have the strong box forced open."

The unfortunate banker seeing that all resistance was useless, drew from his pocket the key, and delivered it into the hands of the officer, who, after having chosen four citizens out of those present, to be witness of the intended ceremony, opened the strong box before them and Plati, who almost fainted away when the gilt casket and bag were drawn forth. The Bargello then turning to this poor devil, "friend," said he, "did you not say you would forfeit your life and property if this casket were found in your house? what if we take you at your word? Good heavens! what a trustworthy banker." Thus saying, he shut down the strong box, and held up the casket in one hand and the bag in the other. The company present no sooner saw them, than they began, especially mine host, to load the banker with curses and revilings. The officer, in order to sift the thing to the bottom, determined to open the casket. He asked me if I had the key. I drew it from my pocket, and handed it to him. The first thing that presented itself to his view, was the specification in these terms: "*This Casket contains nine hundred and sixty pistoles in gold, and ten quadruples; the whole making one thousand pistoles, and belonging to Don Juan Osorio.*" The quadruples were in a parcel by themselves. These he shewed to the banker, and then proceeded to open the bag in which were found the thirty Roman crowns and the others with a similar account.

The cries of the company redoubled at sight of the sums exactly as I had stated them, and every one pressed the Bargello to give me up the casket and bag; which the officer would immediately have acceded to, if I had not declared that I would not receive my money except at the hands of justice, since we were in a city where, thank God, upright judges were to be found. The banker, being once more called upon to say what he had to allege against such positive proof, answered, more dead than alive, and not knowing what to think of an adventure which appeared so natural; "that it was all magic to him, and that the devil must assuredly have had a hand in it." "If you have no better argument than that to bring forward," said the officer to him, "you have every chance of losing your cause, and being punished severely to boot." Thus saying, he left the casket and bag in the custody of a rich merchant in the neighbourhood, and went to make his report to the Judges, who cited Signor Plati and me to appear before them the next morning. The banker was himself so ill that he found it impossible

to attend, and contented himself by sending his wife and clerk with some of his friends. As for me, I appeared boldly accompanied by Sayavedra, my landlord and landlady, all three of whom were interrogated alternately, and asserted a great deal, especially the two last, more than they had either seen or heard. The judges heard Aguilera and his mistress in their turns, who confessed that not having been in the counting-house the whole of the day on which I stated that I had brought the money, they could not conscientiously swear that I had not been there.

Upon all these depositions the magistrates condemned my adversary to restore my gold and silver, and pay all costs, prohibiting him from ever practising the profession of banker again in Milan. The Bargello, in execution of this sentence, conducted me to the merchant with whom he had left the casket and bag, and having restored them to me, I returned triumphantly to my inn. When I arrived there, I was not a little time occupied in receiving congratulations on my success. The landlord and his wife among the rest could not moderate their joy. To testify my gratitude I made them some trifling presents, and all their servants had reason to praise my generous disposition.

CHAP. XLII.

What share of the booty Guzman gives to his associates, and the resolution he takes of leaving Milan.

As soon as I was safely in possession of a sum of money so honestly acquired, I could have wished myself far enough from Milan; but as too precipitate a departure might have raised suspicions against me, I resolved to defer it for a few days. Sayavedra was so overjoyed at our good fortune, that he scarcely knew whether he was awake or dreaming. Then thinking of the stratagem I had invented, he extolled me above all the rogues in the world. "I did not give you credit for such a genius," said he, "though I confess I had an excellent opinion of your abilities before; but I see clearly now that I am a long way behind you." "Friend Sayavedra," said I, "there is nothing very extraordinary in the scheme. What will be most worthy of praise is how to avoid the possibility of danger by flight: for," added I, smiling, "than to walk into a gentleman's house, the door of which stands open, steal a velvet robe from thence, and afterwards to receive a hundred lashes for one's pains, nothing can be more easy."

We passed the remainder of the day at the inn, and when night came on went out together to meet Aguilera at the rendezvous. As soon as he saw us approach, he began to laugh most heartily, and we followed his example. He then complimented me on my address, after which I proceeded to divide the booty. I drew from my pocket a purse containing three hundred pistoles which I gave to him, telling him that I intended the same sum for Sayavedra, and that I should keep the remainder myself, it being but fair that he who had done the most work should be the best paid. My two associates assured me they were perfectly well satisfied. This business being ended, and having nothing else to detain us, we bade Aguilera adieu, and returned home, where I employed myself after supper in counting my money. How overjoyed was I at finding myself in possession of upwards of seven thousand franks, independent of those I had won at Bologna. I had never been so rich before, and I thought no longer of having been robbed at Sienna.

As I was walking out the next day I chanced to espy in a shop window a gilt chain so well wrought that I mistook it for gold. I went in and asked its weight. The shop-keeper answered with a smile that all was not gold that glittered; but that if I wished to purchase this chain I should have it cheap. Being tempted by this offer, I gave him what he asked, and carried it off with me. Sayavedra, who was with me, could not restrain his laughter at my fine bargain, and when we had left the shop, said to me, "Signor Don Juan Osorio, if I mistake not, means to make this chain more expensive to some other person that it has been to him?" "That is by no means impossible," replied I, and with that praiseworthy intention I immediately carried it to a skilful goldsmith, who in a few days made me a chain of gold so exactly similar to mine, that it was difficult to distinguish the one from the other.

At length I left Milan, carrying with me these two articles of jewellery, as well as all the feathers I had plucked out of Signor Plati's wings. I gave out at the inn, previously to my departure, that I was going to Venice; but instead of following that route, I took that to Pavia. I stopped some time at this latter place, in order to make preparations for my second journey to Genoa, which I had resolved upon making if ever I found myself in a condition to appear before my relations without making them blush. After some consideration I determined to act the part of a Spanish Abbot returning from Rome. To this effect I purchased some fine cloth, with which one of the most famous tailors in Pavia made me a cassock and long cloak. To these I added some black morocco shoes and silk stockings, and the rest of my dress to correspond with that of a prelate. I desired Sayavedra to provide himself with two large baggage trunks, and when all was ready I set out in a litter conducted by a muleteer, with my squire on horseback, a new valet on foot, and another muleteer who led a mule laden with my goods. In this grand equipage was Genoa revisited by that same Guzman whom it had seen six or seven years before in a situation miserable enough.

CHAP. XLIII.

Of Guzman's arrival at Genoa, and the gracious reception he met with from his relations when they learnt who he was.

WE went to lodge at the White Cross, which at that time was the best inn in the place. It was already night, but as my squire had gone before us to prepare the landlord to receive an Abbot of the first rank, I found the house all in a bustle when I arrived. Some of the servants were at the doors with flambeaux, and after Sayavedra had assisted me in alighting from the litter, the master conducted me to the best apartment in the house, from which a gentleman much more worthy to occupy it had been turned out to make room for me.

The inn was at that time full of people of consequence, most of whom were not a little curious to know who I was, and my new valet, well instructed by Sayavedra, told all who questioned him that I was the Abbot Don Juan de Guzman, son of a noble Genoese who had married at Seville. I did not quit my chamber the first day, thinking it better to affect the Abbot of consequence fatigued with his journey from Rome, and to get every thing in readiness to shew myself at Genoa the next morning in the character of a prelate. While I was employed in decorating myself with this view, my faithful squire, who was assisting me, could not refrain from saying, "I fear my dear master grows suspicious of me, since he has not yet deigned to communicate the plan he has in contemplation." "No, my friend," replied I, "thou hast always had my confidence. If during our stay at Pavia I procured this new dress without telling you my reasons, it was merely because it was not at that time necessary that you should know them. But I will now satisfy your curiosity; for so far from wishing to conceal my project from you, I cannot execute it without your assistance.

"I have already told you at Milan that my father, a noble Genoese, married at Seville a lady of the house of Guzman, whence I took my name. I have even related to you the history of my life at large; but I believe I never once mentioned that adventure to you which has been the cause of my forming the enterprise I am about to discover to you. You must know that about seven years since I set out from Toledo in tolerable good plight to

visit my relations here in Italy; but I took so little care of my money on the road, that I arrived at Genoa in a most miserable condition. This did not, however, deter me from presenting myself before several members of the family, and among others one of my worthy uncles, who received me so ill, or rather caused me to be treated so cruelly, that I swore to be revenged on him if fortune ever afforded me the opportunity. This oath I intend to keep now that it is in my power; but the only vengeance that I am desirous of taking on my relations is to rob them. With this view I have assumed the dress which so much surprises you. Besides that it inspires respect; it appears to me more calculated than any other to disguise my features from those who saw me before; the alteration that time has made in them not being so great but that I should be in fear of being recognized. Let us prepare then, my dear Sayavedra, to play off some of our best tricks in our family, to which I am incited not only by a just resentment, but by interest also." My confidant made answer, that I had only to give my commands, and he would not fail to follow my instructions. We consulted together what was best to be done, and proceeded as follows.

The second morning after my arrival I dressed myself out in my cassock and long cloak, and when I looked in the glass I scarcely knew myself. Without any vanity I did not look amiss. If I had not possessed the talent which I did to imitate all sorts of persons, I had seen at Rome so many fine models of Abbots of consequence, that I could not possibly have failed. I soon made myself master of some of their best airs: I learnt how to draw my chin down to my neck with good effect; to assume a grave and austere carriage; hold up my cassock and cloak just high enough to exhibit one leg which was not ill-made, with the silk stocking and handsome shoe; to carry my hat in a manner equally genteel and modest; to look at people with a peculiarly absent air, and to modulate properly the tones of my voice in speaking to them. I possessed this knowledge perfectly well in theory, and now was the time that I should shew the city that I was as able to practise it. My major-domo Sayavedra followed with my lackey, both very appropriately equipped. I was stared at with the curiosity that a stranger generally excites, and many made most profound bows to me, or rather to my fine dress; for one is treated in the world according to the appearance one makes. Let even Cicero present himself ill-dressed, and he would pass for a college servant at the highest.

I continued walking for above an hour, acknowledging the respectful civilities I received like an Abbot who was accustomed to them. After which I returned to the inn, where the landlord immediately informed me that dinner was ready, and asked if I had any objection to some persons of quality dining at the same table. I answered that it would afford me pleasure. Having descended into the dining room, four gentlemen arrived immediately and saluted me with respect. I returned the compliment very politely, and dinner being served up, I took the seat of honour, and then requested the gentlemen to seat themselves at table. The conversation was at first serious on my account. I remarked this, and enlivened it myself, and to let these gentlemen see that I was not the devil, though dressed in black, I related two or three jocular stories, which soon excited the rest to follow my example.

They were usually in the habit of amusing themselves at play after dinner, and sometimes also after supper. They played high, but very honourably. I passed an hour in looking over them, after which I retired. They would have been much pleased if I had taken a fancy to play with them, thinking me a rich Abbot rather than a skilful gamester, though they ought to have known that there are a good many keen hands even among the clergy. I did not choose to satisfy their desire so soon, whatever longing I had for it. On the contrary, I professed a repugnance for play, and it was not until we became more familiar together, that I could be brought to join them, and then I pretended to yield to their pressing entreaties out of pure complaisance. I played only a short time, and for very small stakes, without employing Sayavedra, or exerting my own skill. Thus what I lost was a mere trifle, and I never pocketed what I won. Sometimes I left it to pay for the cards, and at others distributed it among the servants. This conduct acquired me the reputation of generosity, whence it happened that whatever person chanced to drop in after dinner to look at us playing, generally crowded round me in the hope of receiving some ducats.

One day, having won about forty pistoles, I took up five and twenty of them, and left the remainder for those who stood about me. Then turning towards a captain of a galley, who was among the interlopers, I said to him in a low voice, slipping the money which I held in my hand into his: "You have been too long in Spain to be ignorant that a gentleman who has looked over the game and taken an interest in the fortune of any particular player, never refuses any little token of gratitude that may be offered him on that

account.” He appeared somewhat confused by this behaviour; but there are times in this life, as is said, when one pistole is worth a thousand. My officer’s pocket was just at this time so completely drained, that the pleasure of seeing this sudden shower of gold, overcame his shame. In spite of his poverty however, I doubt whether he was more sensible of the benefit than of the manner in which it was conferred. I completely gained his heart. This he made several attempts to assure me of, but I interrupted him by engaging him to talk of his own pursuits. I even requested him to do me the honour to dine and sup with me occasionally, for he did not usually dine at our inn; and in taking leave of him I requested his friendship.

This captain was a man of merit, of good understanding, and agreeable person, and as he was known to be a very honest man, he was received in the best companies, where he made as good an appearance as his limited income as a captain of a galley would permit. He was fond of gaming; and though extremely unlucky at it, he could never restrain himself while a crown remained in his pocket. In addition to this he was much addicted to women, which alone would have been sufficient to have ruined him had he been ever so rich. He called himself Favello, a name which a lady whom he had formerly loved had bestowed on him, and which he had ever since gone by, in remembrance of her. He told me the history of his life a few days after, which I could not hear without sighing, so forcibly did it recall to my mind my amour at Florence. The good qualities of this captain, however, were not the only cause of all my politeness to him; for I knew that the galleys would soon sail for Barcelona, and intending as I did to profit by this opportunity of returning to Spain, after having robbed my honest relations, the friendship of Captain Favello was likely to be too useful to me, to neglect to acquire it.

No sooner was I up the next morning, than he called to tender his services, and to invite me to take a sail with him on the water: which I gladly accepted. I was conducted after dinner to his galley, where I was received with all the honors that the Pope or the Doge of Genoa could have expected. We left the harbour to admire the fine pleasure-houses along the sea shore, which form a most charming spectacle. Our officer, who was a Genoese by extraction, and spoke freely whatever he thought, did not content himself with naming the proprietors, but added their characters also. Among those whom he spared the least, he chanced to mention one of my relations. I began to laugh: “Softly, Mr. Captain,” said I, “I ask quarter for

this last gentleman, for you know that I am one of his family.” “Of his family?” cried he, with surprise mingled with confusion, “How can that be?” “I will tell you,” replied I; “my father was a noble Genoese, but having become a bankrupt to a large amount, was obliged to pass over into Spain. He settled at Seville, where he established his affairs by marrying a lady of the house of Guzman, which name I bear preferably to my own, for two reasons; first, to secure to myself a succession which might otherwise have escaped me; and, secondly, because being at least as much the son of my mother as my father, I thought myself entitled to make choice of which ever of their two names would confer most honour on me.”

“You perhaps imagine,” said Favello, “that you are speaking of circumstances with which I am not at all acquainted; but you are mistaken. I am particularly intimate with two of your cousins, who have more than once conversed with me respecting your father. They have told me that he was a shrewd intelligent man: that he was taken prisoner by an Algerine Corsair, and that after having recovered his liberty through the love which a lady at Algiers conceived for him, he went to Seville in search of his correspondent, where he captivated a lady of quality and married her. You are then the son of that illustrious house?” “At your service,” replied I, smiling again. “Know then,” continued he, “that Signor Don Bertrand, your father’s eldest brother, is full of years, still unmarried, and one of the richest nobles in Genoa.” “You tell me what I was ignorant of,” said I; “for I have never seen him, and my mother never had any correspondence with him.” “I am surprised,” said he, “that you have not already made yourself known to him. Your relations are certainly of great consequence in this country, and I know not what should prevent your seeing them.” “What would you have me do?” answered I; “would you have me announce my name before people who do not know me, and who will naturally be apt to discredit what a man says who has only his own word as a security. No no, I stand in no need of their acquaintance, for I want nothing of them. Let us remain as we are. Though they should know that I am here, as a stranger, it is not for me to make the first advances.” “You are right,” said Favello, “but allow me to call and apprise them to-morrow morning of your arrival. I am persuaded that I shall no sooner have informed them than they will behave with proper attention towards you.” “You are a man of prudence and good understanding,” replied I, to the captain, “and may therefore do what you

think best. Only recollect to put no restraint on their inclinations, for it is by no means my wish to intrude myself on their acquaintance.”

While we were conversing in this manner, Favello had a very handsome collation of the best fruits and sweetmeats served up, which he had prepared on purpose for me, and on which he must have expended the greater part of the pistoles I had presented him with. We still continued to talk together, and the officer, who was perfectly well acquainted with my uncle and cousins, told me so many particulars relating to them, that I soon knew almost as much of their affairs as my own. Night coming on obliged us to re-enter the harbour, where we left the galley, and I took the captain home with me to my inn, where we supped with the gentlemen who lodged there. After supper these gentlemen invited me to play a game with him, saying they had not forgotten the forty pistoles I had won of them the preceding day, and that it was but just I should give them their revenge. I consented; and feeling myself in good cue for playing, I said to Favello: “At least Mr. Captain, you will recollect we go halves this time.” He replied with a smile, that he thought me so lucky, that he should be proud to be my partner. Fortune favoured me from the very commencement to the end of the game. I won a hundred pistoles, which I divided with the captain. This was the more agreeable to him as it did not hurt his pride. Thus I gained his friendship by degrees, so that he could not possibly refuse me the favour I expected of him.

He did not fail to keep his promise of going the next day to my relations to announce to them the arrival of the Abbot Don Guzman at Genoa. You will readily imagine that he gave them a fine account of my person, merit, and generosity, for in the afternoon of the same day they called at the inn, completely dressed out for the occasion. My major-domo, to whom I had given my instructions, met them at the door, and conducted them to my apartment where I received them with a grave face, but with much civility. At first there came only two, both children of a senator who had been dead five or six years, and who was one of my father’s brothers. A third next made his appearance, the son of a sister of my father’s, still living. They loaded me with compliments, and made an offer of their house, credit, and purse, because Sayavedra had given them to understand that I wanted neither. If nothing else could convince them that I was a very rich abbot, what they observed in my apartment was sufficient to impress them with that opinion of me. I had taken care to spread negligently on the table my

gold chain, various other jewels, and the Milan casket with the lid open, in which their sharp eyes doubtless espied part of the pistoles it contained.

My uncle, who was the chief of the family, came last. It was particularly to him that I owed a grudge. He supported himself on a large stick, and seemed to walk with difficulty. I could no longer discern that venerable appearance, which had pleased me so much when I first saw him; on the contrary, my blood seemed to curdle at the sight of this malicious old ape, who, with his assistant sham devils had amused himself so cruelly at my expence. In spite of these painful recollections, however, I failed not to receive him more graciously than my cousins, who, shortly after taking their leave, left us alone together. The old gentleman began by assuring me of his extreme joy at the sight of the son of a brother who had ever been dear to him; then surveying me from head to foot, he declared that I was very like my father, and that he felt proud of a connexion so likely to do honour to the family. He then complained that I had not ventured to take up my lodging with him, where I should have found apartments more suitable than any at an inn, for a man of my rank and character. I thanked him very politely, and told him that my cousins also had made an offer of their house, but that I had declined such an accommodation, being very unwilling to inconvenience any of my relatives during the short stay I should make at Genoa, whither I had come merely to ascertain the condition of the family, as much for my own satisfaction, as for that of my mother, who had desired to be kindly remembered.

These last words presented an opportunity to Don Bertrand to make inquiries respecting my mother and her children. I replied that I was her only son, and it had almost escaped me that I had two fathers; but I restrained my tongue in time, and praised my mother up to the skies. My uncle, impatient to relate to me what I knew quite as well as him, interrupted my eulogium, saying: "I must tell you, my dear nephew, an adventure which happened to us six or seven years ago. A little rascal made his appearance in Genoa half naked. He ran about the streets telling all those who were fools enough to listen to him, that he was the son of your father; and this young beggar, who could not be mistaken for any thing but what he was, flattered himself that some of our family would be weak enough to believe him on his word, and humane enough to have compassion on his misery. I threw myself in his way with the intention of being revenged on him for the discredit he brought upon the family, and I

was fortunate enough to meet him. I allured him into my house by soft words, and by promising that I would the next day introduce him to a gentleman who would not fail to be of service to him. When I got him home, I put some questions to him, which soon convinced me that he was a little scape grace. I accordingly determined that he should be punished for his presumption, and perceiving that he was dying with hunger, I sent him to bed without any supper in a magnificent chamber, where I caused him to be tormented all night long by certain devils in masks, who tossed him in a blanket to his heart's content."

In relating this story to me the old rascal laughed with all his might, and it was with the greatest difficulty that I could restrain the rage I felt. I however, managed to dissemble, and forcing a sort of grin, I agreed with him that the adventure was comical enough. "All that I regret," continued my uncle, "is, that he disappeared the next morning, and is still at large. Could I have secured him, it was my intention to have inflicted a much severer punishment on him for his presumption, in daring to assert that he bore any affinity to our family." After this declaration I changed the subject, and a quarter of an hour after the old gentleman took his leave, and I accompanied him to the street door, paying him all the respect due to my father's elder brother.

CHAP. XLIV.

Guzman gives a grand entertainment to his relations, and makes them pay pretty handsomely for it.

AFTER dinner I desired Sayavedra to go out and purchase four good trunks of the same size. While he was gone on this commission, Favello called upon me, to give me an account of the conversations he had with my relations respecting me, and he assured me all the family were charmed with my person, especially Signor Don Bertrand my uncle. This good old man, continued he, says that he almost fancied that it was his dear brother he saw and heard speak, so much was he struck with your resemblance to your father; that he regretted to find that you had embraced the ecclesiastical life, and should propose to you to throw off your cassock and marry one of your nieces on the mother's side; and that though this young lady had no property of her own, it was his intention to provide well for her, she being his particular favourite. In conclusion, the Captain protested to me, that my uncle had conceived a great regard for me. All this, however, did not in the least deter me in my intentions towards him.

I went to return the visit the next morning, first to Don Bertrand, who, in the conversation which we had together, took occasion to observe, that he thought that an only son, as I was, ought rather to think of keeping up the family name than to consecrate myself to a state of life which deprived the family of one of its best branches. I might have answered, that he, having always been a bachelor, had himself wronged the family quite as much as if he also had embraced the ecclesiastical life. He then named the lady whom he had selected for my wife. To amuse him, I pretended not to be much averse to his wishes, and made an end of my visit by requesting his company to dine with me the next day. He pressed hard to be excused on account of his great age; but when I represented to him that none but relations would be of the party except Captain Favello, the common friend of the family, he allowed himself to be prevailed on, and promised to come, that I might be convinced, as he was pleased to say, of the great regard he felt for a nephew whom Heaven had sent him. After this I visited my cousins, one after another, and they all promised to join the party. Nothing was now necessary but to prepare a magnificent dinner for them. My

landlord told me to leave this to him, and he would undertake that my guests should be handsomely provided for.

My major-domo, who returned home while I was speaking to the landlord, told me that he had purchased four trunks as I desired. I looked at them, and was well pleased. He asked me what I intended to do with them. I told he had only to follow me, and he would soon know. I ordered him to take our casket under his arm, and conducted him to the shop of one of the richest goldsmiths in Genoa, whom I requested to lend me for about twenty-four hours a rich service of silver plates and dishes, in consideration of an honest profit, and depositing the value of the plate in his hands. The goldsmith agreed to the proposal; we agreed as to the sum I should pay him for the loan: and, choosing the service I liked best, I deposited nine thousand francs with the goldsmith by way of security. After which, I desired Sayavedra to fetch the two trunks, put the plate in them himself, and have them carried home; which he did accordingly.

All my relations assembled at my lodgings the next day. My landlord, who piqued himself on being an excellent cook, gave us a specimen of his ability in the difficult art of making ragouts, which he served up in so delicious a style, that my cousins, and even my uncle, confessed that they had never eaten better. If they had not expected such excellent fare, how much more were they surprised when they saw the sideboard set out with elegant plate, and the plates and dishes of the same metal. They could not help observing, that a traveller ran great risk in carrying such a service of plate about with him, and particularly in Italy, where thieves so plentifully abound. The good Don Bertrand, who had made the same reflections at sight of the display of silver, applauded their opinion. "It is your own fault, my nephew," cried he; "you might easily have avoided living at an inn in a city where you have so many relations. I grant you that this is the best inn in Genoa; but that signifies nothing. You are yet young, and I, having had more experience, would caution you against trusting to the goodness of the locks or padlocks on your trunks, because either the landlord, landlady, their children, or servants, always keep two or three keys to every room in their house. If you believe me in this respect," continued he, "since you refuse to take up your residence at my house, you will at least send your plate and jewels thither, where they would be in safety until your departure, were there a million of gold."

I thanked my uncle for his obliging anxiety; and pretending that I had no fear of being robbed, I told him, that when I set out for Rome, I had taken the precaution of leaving my most valuable effects in the hands of our Ambassador, and that in respect to the plate, although it was troublesome to a traveller, I was not sorry that I had brought it with me, as in case of necessity I could sell it much more easily than jewels. All the family seemed to acquiesce in this reason; and as I mentioned the Ambassador, my cousins began to speak of that minister. They said that they had seen him as he passed through Genoa on his road to Rome. Upon which, to convince them that I stood well with his Excellence, I shewed them the portrait he had presented me with. This was quite sufficient to persuade them of the Ambassador's great esteem and friendship for me.

Don Bertrand, still harping upon the danger of keeping my plate at an inn, returned once more to the charge, and I was obliged to quiet his apprehensions by promising that I would have it all packed in the two trunks in which I told him I usually locked it up, and send it to his house immediately after dinner. We changed the subject, and began to converse on my intended marriage. My uncle, addressing himself to me, said, that I ought to think seriously of marrying in my youth, and not to defer it to a more advanced age, to have the agonies of leaving orphan children behind me. He then represented to me all the disagreeables of an ecclesiastical life, and concluded his harangue by enlarging on the perfections of the young lady whom he wished me to marry. She is my niece by the mother's side, added he; of noble blood, and of ample beauty to make up for the deficiency of her fortune; besides which, she has a mother who will cherish as the apple of her eye, both you and your children.

As the old buck seemed so determined on this marriage, I thought it more prudent not to profess myself averse to his wishes. "You are so persuasive," said I, "my dear uncle, that you have already destroyed my taste for an ecclesiastical life; and I feel convinced that I shall be perfectly happy in receiving a wife from your hands. Permit me, however, to represent to you, that I already enjoy a benefice of ten thousand crowns a year, and am in daily expectation of fifteen thousand, which some relations of my mother, who have great influence at court, have given me hopes of. It will be most gratifying for me, should I attain my wishes, to have those two handsome presentations to bestow on the children of my cousins." They all approved highly of my resolution, and gave me a thousand thanks in

anticipation of the honour I intended them. Towards the end of the repast, Don Bertrand asked Captain Favello if he had received any orders for his departure. "Yes," answered he, "and we must set sail in three days for Barcelona. We are already very busy in shipping our goods." I was overjoyed at this news, which informed me that I had no time to lose. As soon as dinner was over, I ordered my major-domo aloud, to lock up my plate and casket, and carry them himself to my uncle's house. The room was cleared in less than an hour, and in the presence of my relations, whilst I kept up the conversation with them. I insisted on accompanying my uncle, where I had the satisfaction of seeing, not the two trunks full of my plate, but two similar ones that we had filled the evening before with bags of sand of nearly the same weight, and which Sayavedra had very dexterously exchanged.

It was not possible to have made a better beginning: I continued as successfully. Captain Favello returned at night to the inn; he told me that he regretted the precipitate departure of the galleys, which would so soon deprive him of my agreeable society. "It is by no means certain," said I, "that we shall so soon separate. We may possibly be longer together than you imagine." He reflected a moment on what I said, and then asked me if I had really any idea of returning to Spain. "Yes," answered I; "for know, that it was not so much the pleasure of seeing my relations that brought me to Genoa as the desire to be revenged for an affront offered me by a Genoese who was my rival at Rome. This I tell you," added I, "having found you to be a man of prudence and discretion, in whom I may confide." Nothing further was necessary to engage Favello in my service. "Tell me the name," said he, with enthusiasm, "of the rascal who has insulted you, and I ask but four and twenty hours to fully satisfy your vengeance." "Captain," replied I, "I am much indebted to you for taking up my cause so warmly; and were I in want of an avenger I could not have a better champion than yourself. But you judge ill of me if you think that I want either strength or courage to avenge myself. I know where my gentleman lodges, and my blow is sure. All that I have to request of you is, to allow my baggage to be conveyed privately on board your galley, on the eve previous to her sailing. I have more reasons than one for wishing that even my relations may be ignorant of my departure, and entreat you therefore to keep it secret."

"As to that," replied the officer, "depend upon me." Then alluding again to my affair of honour, "you cannot imagine," continued he, "how mortified

I feel, that my services should be refused in the only opportunity that I may have of testifying my zeal for you!" He said this with such apparent concern, that I embraced and endeavoured to console him by saying, "that he would have many opportunities in the course of our voyage of manifesting his friendship towards me." With similar mutual expressions of friendship towards each other, we parted. The first thing I did the next morning was, to send back all the plate to the goldsmiths by my men, who brought me in return my pistoles which were there in pledge. Scarcely had I deposited them in safety again, when one of my cousins called upon me to say that my uncle Don Bertrand expected me to dine with him the next day. I did not fail to accept of this invitation, and found the whole family assembled when I arrived at his house. We sat down to table in good spirits, and our conversation was lively. Before dinner was over, my major-domo, as I had previously desired him, entered the parlour, and coming up to me with a note in his hand, "Colonel Don Antonio," said he, "has just been to inquire for you at the inn, and not finding you there, has charged me to deliver this letter." I opened it without ceremony, and took great pains to read it so loud that my uncle, who sat very near me, might hear every word. It ran thus:

"I am to be married the day after to-morrow, and I shall fully expect the pleasure of your company on the occasion. I shall never forgive you if you refuse to join us. In addition to this, I have another favour to beg of you: you have often shown me some excellent jewels of your mother's; I beseech you to lend them to me. My mistress has not dared to bring her own to this country with her. We request them for two days only, and promise to take great care of them. I flatter myself that you will confer this obligation on your friend,

DON ANTONIO DE MENDOZA."

After having read this letter, I assumed a troubled and mortified air; and having reflected for some time, I said to Sayavedra: "You do not, of course, know the purport of this epistle. Don Antonio requests the loan of my jewels, to decorate his intended wife on the day of their marriage. You well know," continued I, "that I left all my diamonds at the Ambassador's at Rome. Lose no time then in informing the Colonel, that I am much vexed that it is not in my power to oblige him." "I fear, Sir," replied the major-domo, "he will think it a mere evasion, and that you refuse him." "He will do me great injustice by such a thought," replied I; "sooner, therefore, than

risk the possibility of such an idea, I would hire some jewels. I should imagine that if I place good security in the hands of some jeweller, he would be glad for a very trifling consideration to lend me what I want for two or three days." "Who can doubt that," said my uncle? "But why," continued he, "need you be at the expence of hiring what you may have for nothing? Do you suppose that we have not as fine jewels as you can procure elsewhere; and are we not disposed to oblige you in any way? Your relations will take pleasure in obliging this or any friend of yours." "Mendoza is certainly one of my best friends," cried I; "he is a man of quality, who was very serviceable to me at Rome, and to whom I am indebted for my introduction to the Spanish Ambassador. The Colonel, whose regiment is at Milan, has won the heart of a rich widow in that city, who, in opposition to the wishes of some of her relations, has consented to espouse him. They are come hither, therefore, to solemnize their marriage. He is a man of the nicest honour, to whom I should not be under the slightest apprehensions in lending jewels to the value of 100,000 franks." "Be he what he may," interrupted Don Bertrand, "since he has expressed a wish to see his wife decorated with diamonds, he shall have that satisfaction."

Overjoyed that he bit the hook so greedily, I told him with transport: "Really, my dear uncle, you are too generous, and I ought to be apprehensive of intruding too much upon your goodness." "No compliments, my dear nephew," replied he, with precipitation; "I will lend you my diamonds with all my heart. To convince you, I will this moment go and choose some of the finest for your use." Thus saying, he rose from table and went to his closet, whence he returned, and put into my hands a case containing jewels to the amount of from 7 to 8,000 franks. My three cousins seeing the old gentleman treat me in this kind manner did not wish to be thought less generous than he. They all promised to lend me some, and sure enough they brought me the next morning jewels to nearly the same amount. The most avaricious of the three came last, and in the course of a very long chat contrived to turn the conversation upon my benefice. He gave me to understand that if I was so well off as to wish to dispose of it, and would be inclined to resign it in favour of one of his own children, in preference to either of his cousins, a present of a hundred pistoles should accompany his thanks. I made answer, "that his eldest son having the advantage over all the other children in respect to age, certainly appeared to

me the most proper to succeed to my benefice; but that having obtained it for nothing, I should resign it on the same terms, not being a man to make such sort of bargains." I perceived plainly that this answer did not by any means displease him.

Just at this moment Sayavedra entered the room, having under his arm a small casket containing my gold chain: "Do you still wish," said he, "that I should go where you desired me?" "You ought to have been there and back again ere this," replied I. "Recollect only, before you apply to a goldsmith, to make inquiry in the neighbourhood as to his respectability. You will then get my chain weighed, and return to tell me its exact weight." Though my cousin had already seen this chain, he requested to look at it again, and admired extremely both the workmanship and the fineness of the gold. Then, turning to Sayavedra, "My friend," said he, "tell my servant, whom you will find below, to accompany you to a goldsmith's who lives hard by, and who will tell you conscientiously the value of the chain." "My squire was soon back." I inquired "how much the goldsmith valued it at." "Six hundred and fifty-five crowns," answered Sayavedra. "Well then," said I, "just return and request the loan of six hundred upon it, which I will repay him in three days, with whatever he may demand for interest." "Honest man as he is," said my cousin, "he will make no scruple of taking three per cent, for three days as well as for six months, saying that it makes no difference to him. I regret much," continued he, "that I do not happen at this moment to have sufficient ready money at hand myself; but I know a man of probity who will be satisfied with only two per cent."

This man of probity was no other than himself, who, notwithstanding that he hoped to obtain a good benefice for nothing, rejoiced at the opportunity of depriving the goldsmith of this little profit. I failed not to assure this good cousin that he would much oblige me by getting it done for me. "Not that I am in great distress for money," said I, "as you may see. At the same time I drew from my pocket two large purses full of pistoles, which I showed to him. It is merely by way of precaution that I wish to put my chain in pledge; for as we shall play very high at the wedding of my friend the colonel, I do not like to be at all short of money." My cousin assured me, "that in two hours at furthest, the six hundred crowns should be at my service." Then taking the casket out of Sayavedra's hand, I opened it for an instant, just that my cousin might see that the chain was in it, and

after having shut it again, delivered it to his servant, who returned in about an hour with the six hundred crowns.

Unfortunately for my worthy cousin, my major-domo, in bringing the casket back from the goldsmith's under his cloak, had dexterously drawn out the gold chain, and substituted a brass one in its stead.

Favello came to sup with me at night. He told me it was time for me to strike my blow, for that I must sleep on board the next night, as the galleys were to sail before day-break the following morning. "'Tis well," answered I; "my business shall be settled in less than four and twenty hours' time, and I will not fail to be on board by to-morrow evening. If you will assist me by sending some of your people about midnight for my boxes, my departure will be more secret." The captain promised this, and took his leave of me shortly after. We passed almost the whole of the next day in getting every thing in readiness for our departure. We packed up our best effects in our two largest boxes, and filled with rags the counterparts of those which my honoured uncle kept in his closet for me with such pious care. A quarter of an hour before midnight, four of captain Favello's men conveyed our two largest boxes on board, leaving our two others to satisfy my landlord, whom I desired Sayavedra to tell not to be anxious on my account, for that I was going to sup at a friend's, where I might very likely pass the whole night at play. We at length got safe on board our captain's galley. He had been rather uneasy at my being so late, and asked me the first thing, how my affair of honour had terminated. "My revenge is satisfied to my heart's content," replied I. "I rejoice at it extremely," said he; "for I must acknowledge that I was beginning to be a little anxious for your safety, the result of such an enterprise being always uncertain."

Favello had caused a little chamber to be fitted up for me, into which he conducted me, and where I found my two boxes, and a table covered with delicate meats. We sat down, and after partaking of a good supper, lay down to take some repose. But our several cares kept us both awake. For my part I was all night terribly alarmed lest some cursed contrary wind should detain us in port, and afford my relations sufficient time to gain information of my flight, and to obtain an order from the senate to have me arrested. My fears, however, were groundless. At day-break I heard a noise which announced to me that the galleys were on the point of departure. I looked through a hole in my chamber, and perceived with joy that the whole crew had begun to ply their oars. We were soon out of port; then taking

advantage of the wind which was directly in our favour, we spread our sails and were soon out of sight.



CHAP. XLV.

Guzman, after having robbed his relations, and re-embarked for Spain, is in imminent danger of perishing at sea, and has the misfortune to lose Sayavedra.

WE had already doubled Cape Noli, when the captain informed me that if the wind did not change for three days, we should have a most agreeable voyage. We watered at Monaco, and the next morning, having put to sea again with a favourable breeze, we reached the Isles of Hieres, where we passed the night. The third day we anchored at Chateau d'If, in sight of Marseilles, and the day following at Roses.

I was congratulating myself on so fortunate a voyage, when my joy was interrupted by word being brought me that Sayavedra had the sea-sickness, and felt extremely ill. I ran to see him immediately, and found that he had a very violent fever upon him. I was much afflicted at it, but consoled myself with the idea that we should soon reach Barcelona, where he should have every attention paid to him. The morning of the fifth day dawned very differently to the preceding ones; the clouds seemed lowering, and there was scarcely a breath of air stirring. We still hoped, however, by dint of hard rowing, to sleep that night at Barcelona. But we found our mistake two hours after. So furious a storm arose, that our destruction appeared inevitable. In vain did we attempt to make to land; the oar became quite useless, and we were obliged to keep out to sea the whole of that night. What a night of horror was it for us! Sometimes the sea raised its waves to the clouds, and at others, opening its bosom, presented to our eyes the awful abyss by which we were surrounded.

Who in the midst of such a scene can attempt to paint the consternation so evidently depicted on every countenance on board, and the various indications of fear created by the dread of approaching death? Some invoked the Saints most honoured in their own country; others offered vows; some on their knees were addressing the most fervent prayers to heaven in private, whilst others confessed their sins aloud, and implored pardon of the Deity. Some few, though death was apparently before their eyes, were still inquiring of the pilot whether all hopes were at an end. He

answered, that there was nothing to fear, and they seemed as willing to trust this liar, as a father, who, seeing his only son dying, eagerly gives credit to the quack who assures him of his speedy recovery. For my part, like another Jonas, I was buried in a profound reverie all this while, and believing myself the cause of this dreadful storm, said within myself: Wretch, now wilt thou meet with the punishment due to thee for having robbed thy relations. Of what service will their gold be to thee? The sea will in a short time swallow up both thyself and thy ill-gotten riches. For thyself, thou hast well deserved it, and those only are to be pitied, who have been so unfortunate as to embark in the company of a scoundrel who has incurred the vengeance of heaven.

With this impression, I awaited death with resignation. It was not so near at hand, however, as we all imagined. The weather suddenly changed, hope succeeded despair, and joy desolation. That night proved fatal only to the unfortunate Sayavedra. This faithful follower, whose brain was already turned by his fever, the violence of which was increasing every moment, lost his reason entirely when he heard the cries and lamentations which the fear of shipwreck excited in the galley. My footman watched him that night, but dropping asleep from fatigue, Sayavedra got up in one of his fits, which gave him new strength, and threw himself from the side of the poop into the sea. The soldier who was on guard heard something fall into the sea, and informed the pilot of it. This made a great noise on board, and every one was anxious to ascertain what it could be; and after half an hour's search, Sayavedra was found to be missing. No possible grief could be greater than mine when I first learned this distressing news. No one has ever wept more bitterly for a brother than I did for my dear Sayavedra. I was inconsolable at his loss, and truly I had good reason to regret him. The joy of all on board the next morning at finding the sea as calm as it had been boisterous the preceding day, had but little effect on my spirits, now that death had deprived me of my faithful servant and companion.

We entered the port of Barcelona towards noon. I had already prepared Favello not to expect I should make a long stay in that city, having told him after the storm, that I had made a vow to visit our Lady of Montserrat the moment I landed, and that from thence I intended to proceed to my mother's at Andalusia. He could not oppose so pious an intention; and besides, not being able to leave his galley that day, he told me sadly, as I was taking leave of him, that in all probability we should never see each

other again, unless I intended to stay the whole of the next day in Barcelona. He then inquired where I should take up my lodging; I named an inn which I knew, fully resolved, however, never to go near it. Sensible of the great proofs of friendship I had received at his hands, I embraced him tenderly at parting, and presenting him with a ring worth a hundred pistoles, requested he would wear it for my sake. He accepted it with tears in his eyes, fearing it was the last farewell, and on my side, feeling myself too much affected, I hastened away, to spare him the pain of reading in my looks the cause of our separation.

My first care when I arrived at the inn where I caused my trunks to be carried, was to have three good mules bought for my use. You may be sure I paid dear for them; but this signified but little in my present situation. In addition to the twenty-five thousand franks which I now possessed, four thousand more had fallen to me by the death of my companion in fortune. I hired also a muleteer who was well acquainted with the roads, and we left the city the following morning as soon as the gates were open. My impatience to leave Barcelona as soon as possible may easily be conceived; a felucca might have arrived there, with orders from my relations to arrest me. It was incumbent on me therefore to be active. To so prudent a fear I added the precaution of avoiding all the high roads, telling my followers, that as my sole object in travelling was my own pleasure, it was my wish to reach the Ebro as fast as possible; that, as I rode along its banks, I might be gratified with a view of the charming landscapes on both sides of it.

CHAP. XLVI.

Guzman, on his journey to Saragossa, makes acquaintance and falls in love with a young Widow. Progress and conclusion of this new passion.

I STEERED clear of the high roads, for the reasons I have already told you, and spurring on my mule through all the byeways towards the Ebro, intending to coast it from thence to Saragossa, I travelled with as much speed as fear. In three days we reached the banks of the river. My mind became now more at ease; and I began to believe myself beyond the reach of pursuit, and to congratulate myself on my riches, without reflecting that I was travelling through a country in which there were as many robbers as in Italy. I had taken the precaution, however, to purchase two firelocks in Barcelona, with which I armed my footman and the muleteer. In addition to this, I concealed my jewels about me so cautiously, that no one could perceive them without stripping me.

I shall pass over in silence, friendly reader, the adventures I met with on the banks of Ebro, which are not worthy to be related, and proceed to make you acquainted with one which fortune prepared for me between Ossera and Saragossa. Night surprised me near a fine abbey, which I took for a castle, and which I approached in the hope of obtaining a lodging; but finding that a wretched village lay under it, I changed my opinion. We stopped before a paltry hovel, at which a sign was suspended, and, knocking loudly at the door, demanded admission. Nobody answered us at first, but at length a country fellow appeared at one of the windows. This was the landlord, who, having surveyed me from top to toe by the light of a lamp which he held in his hand, began to laugh, saying, "Do not waste any further time here, Signor Cavalier, my house is not fit to receive you; go to the abbey, where you will meet with a hearty welcome, and be more suitably entertained." I answered the peasant, that I would follow his advice, and, as we were ignorant of the road, requested him to conduct us to the convent, at the same time slipping a few reals into his hand, to add more efficacy to my entreaty.

The monastery stood on an eminence, so that we were nearly half an hour ascending it by a very rough road, which to me, who was already

much fatigued, was very distressing. Nevertheless, as there is nothing so good as to be entirely free from unpleasantry, so neither is there any thing so bad but has something agreeable to recommend it. The inn-keeper informed me that this was a convent for nuns, all of whom were ladies of quality; that it was one of the richest in Spain, and received all strangers that passed through the village with hospitality. I felt, without knowing wherefore, that this report pleased me; either from reviving my natural predilection for the fair sex, or from a presentiment of what would happen to me. When we reached the great gate we rang several times before any body from within made answer. At length a voice asked us, through the wicket, what we wanted. The inn-keeper, who was known to the porter, told him, "that we were looking for lodging; that he could not entertain us himself, and had, consequently, conducted us to the abbey." The muleteer added, by my orders, "that an asylum was requested, for one night only, for a foreign nobleman, who had lost his way travelling to Saragossa."

The porter answered, "that the convent-gate was always shut at eight o'clock, and that it was now nine; that, notwithstanding such was the rule, he would go, from the consideration he naturally had for persons of quality, and inform the lady abbess of my situation, and obey her orders." I was obliged to wait with patience at the gate for her answer. The porter at length returned and informed us that the abbess could not think of opening the gate at such an unseasonable hour to gentlemen entirely unknown to her. This refusal vexed me extremely. I dismounted from my mule, and advanced towards the wicket; and, speaking myself to the porter, entreated him to return to the abbess, and tell her, on my behalf, that if she knew the favour she would confer on me, in affording me a retreat for that night, she would cease to be inexorable. The porter told me, "it was to no purpose to persist in requesting what she would never permit." Not being able to influence the porter in my favour by prayers, I offered a bribe, which he refused with disdain, and shut the wicket in my face. I feared there was now no chance of sleeping that night in the monastery, and, yielding to necessity, told my servants to lead the three mules back again to the peasant's; that, for my own part, rather than be stived up in that wretched tavern, I felt desirous to pass away a few hours where I was, in listening to the murmuring of the Ebro.

It was a lovely night. I strolled round the house, observing with an eye of curiosity whatever I could discern by the light of the stars, which shone

extremely bright. I followed a sloping path which led me under a balcony that commanded a view of the river. I sat down at the foot of a tree opposite the balcony, which I considered attentively, supposing it to be my lady abbess's apartment. I could perceive a light, and shortly after a confused noise of female voices struck my ear; then all of a sudden a profound silence ensued, which was interrupted in its turn by a Spanish song warbled by a very delicate voice. The singer seemed to please her company exceedingly, and she was much applauded. Another lady then sang an Italian air with which I was well acquainted, and was equally complimented. So immoderate a desire then possessed me to amuse the ladies with my melodious voice, that I could scarcely have the patience to hear this song out. I was half inclined to sing the same over again, for it was one of those for which I had been most applauded at the Grand Duke's concert at Florence. However, I was prudent enough to spare the lady the mortification of the comparison; and having remembered another air which had particularly pleased the Grand Duchess, I chose that in its stead.

Hoping thus agreeably to surprise these recluses by my fine voice, as well as by the singularity of the adventure, I sang, and, when I had finished the air, had the pleasure of hearing exclamations of astonishment mingled with admiration. The glass-door of the balcony flew open, and several ladies hurried forward in the hope of seeing who it could be that sang so sweetly. I affected not to observe them, and, after having paused a moment, began my air again. As soon as I ceased, I could hear myself again applauded by the ladies, who, however, in the hopes of being favoured with another, communicated their admiration only in whispers. I perceived their design, and was malicious enough to provoke them by remaining silent, without stirring from the spot. One of the ladies, more impatient than the rest, then addressed me, saying, "That one song from so charming a voice was but very insufficient for so many ladies who were so passionately fond of music." "'Tis too little," replied I in Italian, "for so many ladies, but far too much for a pilgrim, to whom they have so cruelly refused shelter."

My answer excited great laughter, from which they supposed I was the stranger who had requested to lodge in the abbey. "Signor Cavalier," cried one of them, "be not displeased at the refusal that was returned you. It is a law established in this convent not to admit any strange gentleman after eight o'clock in the evening; but your charming voice has had such influence, that the lady abbess consents, for once, to dispense with the

regulation, and, unless you are so true a knight-errant as to prefer passing the night on the banks of this river, has just given order to open the gates to you." I made answer, "that I was rejoiced to learn that to obtain shelter from my lady abbess it was only necessary to set my request to music." This little trait of raillery excited their laughter afresh, more especially as it was the lady abbess herself to whom I was speaking. They were by no means displeased with my apparent gaiety, and, as they wished to take a nearer view of my figure, of which they could form but an indistinct idea where I sat, they entreated me to walk in, telling me "that the lady abbess would soon be reconciled to me."

At these words, to shew them that I desired nothing better than such an invitation, I rose instantly, and bowing to the company in the most respectful manner as I passed the balcony, I soon regained the abbey-gate, where the porter met me, and, desiring me to follow him, conducted me into a large and very elegant parlour. Here I was received by the lady abbess and a secular lady; they were both seated on cushions of violet-coloured damask, and six or seven nuns stood behind them. All these ladies kept profoundly silent, and preserved an air of gravity which would have disconcerted any other but myself; but I had so often visited the grate at Rome, that I knew well what behaviour to adopt. I accosted them, therefore, in a jocose manner, and some lucky sallies which escaped me soon dissipated their affected gravity. I then complained in so good-natured a manner of the law which forbids them to admit strangers into the convent at night, that I soon succeeded in amusing them.

In the mean time a small table was laid out with some venison pasties, wine, and sweetmeats. I needed no very pressing invitation to eat and drink, for I acquitted myself like a hungry traveller as I was, not forgetting, however, to whisper occasional compliments to the lady abbess, as well as to the secular lady, whom I thought very handsome. She had an air of youth and peculiar sprightliness, which rendered her particularly engaging. Some of the nuns remarking that I admired her, asked me if I did not think that their community had reason to be proud of the acquisition of such a lady. This inspired me with a thousand thoughts in her favour. I spoke nothing but Italian, and being dressed also in the Italian fashion, I easily passed for one of that nation. Such of the ladies as were acquainted with that language were so condescending as not to speak to me in Spanish. When they perceived that I had done eating, they contrived to turn the conversation on

music, and one and all entreated me to favour them with one of the newest Italian airs. I consented willingly, and, animated by degrees, by the praises bestowed on me at the end of each couplet, such a rage for singing possessed me, that no sooner had I finished one song than I began another. As to the company, and especially the secular lady, they were so delighted to listen to me, that they seemed not to have the least thought of retiring, though it was already after midnight. I really believe that day would have surprised us in the parlour, had not the abbess, for the sake of preserving the DECORUM of a monastic life, thought proper to put an end to a pastime so contrary to their established regulations, by reminding the ladies that they were imposing on my good nature. "Our guest," said she, "cannot but be fatigued; besides, you ought to reserve some pleasure for to-morrow. He will not, I trust, think of departing before we have had the pleasure of seeing him again." This was a polite way of desiring me to sing no more; so that, wishing the company good night, I joined the porter, who was waiting at the parlour-door to conduct me to the apartment that was prepared for me.

I was not a little astonished in entering to find my servants there, whom they had been kind enough to send for, with my baggage, and who had been entertained like myself. I found also that even my three mules had not been forgotten, and that, thanks to their master's fine voice, they had had a good bellyful of provender in the convent stables. The chamber in which I lay, occupied my attention for some time. There was in the furniture, although plain, a certain air of simplicity far superior to magnificence; and my bed could not have been better prepared even for the Archbishop of Saragossa. Having got into it, I told my servants to follow the porter to their beds. I then called the muleteer to me, who was no fool, and charged him to be sure to ascertain who the secular lady was whom I had seen with the Lady Abbess. He acquitted himself well of this commission: "Sir," said he, when I rose the next morning, "I have questioned one of the footmen respecting the lady of whom you wish to know, and he has told me every particular without hesitation. She is a widow, as he says, very rich, and of one of the best families in Saragossa. She has many admirers; and among others, a nephew of the Lady Abbess, a young man of about two and twenty at most, wonderfully well made, and extremely handsome. Unless, however, I am much mistaken," added he, "my mistress is but very indifferent to his addresses; while on the contrary my Lady Abbess, who has a great affection

for this unlicked cub, is most anxious to promote the match. This is all," said the muleteer, "that I have learnt from the footman; but the porter has just informed me that this young widow, who arrived at the abbey only an hour or two before you, intends to return home this afternoon."

At the word widow, I sighed deeply. It brought to my recollection my fair one at Florence, and I at first imagined that I was sighing for her; but to say the truth, I soon felt that my heart, less intent upon the past than the present, was captivated by the charms of the widow of Saragossa. I could no longer doubt it when I beheld her again in the parlour, where the abbess, after mass was over, invited me. I appeared there again with all the good humour of the preceding evening. There were but three nuns with the abbess besides the object of my new passion. The conversation soon became lively and facetious, and was by no means damped by the arrival of several more of the most sprightly nuns in the convent, who joined us soon after. My lovely widow, who possessed a fund of wit, contributed her share, and I applauded, from the bottom of my heart, every little repartee that escaped her lips. She saw plainly that I was in admiration at every thing she said, and that I distinguished her from the rest of the company, and she was evidently not a little pleased by my attentions.

In the midst of our laughter, a servant announced to the abbess that Don Antonio de Miras was on the stairs, which seemed to please her extremely; for this was her dear nephew whom she wished to see united to the beautiful widow. His aunt had sent him word the evening before, that Donna Lucia (for that was my charmer's name) was at the abbey, and he could not of course neglect so favourable an opportunity of waiting upon a lady whom he aspired to marry. The portrait that the muleteer had given me of this young gentleman, was by no means flattering, for I never beheld a handsomer cavalier. No woman ever so vain of her beauty but might have been proud to have had such a face. Add to which he was of a handsome figure, and had every appearance of a man of quality. His dress, which was extremely elegant, added also to his prepossessing appearance. I should certainly have died with jealousy at sight of such a rival, had I not been previously informed that he was by no means eminently gifted with understanding. This thought helped to support me against such formidable disadvantages, and an observation which I afterwards made emboldened me at least to dispute with him the heart of Donna Lucia; for I perceived that this lady, so far from testifying any joy at his arrival, seemed to look upon

him with an eye of indifference, and replied very coldly to all his compliments.

Don Antonio and I at first looked at each other like two young cocks; but as it was my interest to be on good terms with him, I loaded him with compliments, and in less than an hour we were the best friends in the world. When dinner hour arrived, the abbess caused two tables to be laid in the parlour, one without the grate for her nephew and myself, and the other within for the ladies. Our repast, which was fit for the first nobleman to sit down to, was seasoned with jests and anecdotes, which amused us all exceedingly. More than half the afternoon was passed away in the same agreeable manner.

I talked, sang, laughed, and in short shewed that I could do any thing; insomuch that the nuns, though accustomed to receive the visits of gentlemen, assured me that they had never yet seen one possessing such a fund of amusement. In the mean time the hour of separation drew nigh. It was time for the fair widow to set off for Saragossa, if she hoped to arrive there before night. She took leave, therefore, of the Lady Abbess and the nuns, and ascended into her litter, which was in waiting for her at the door. As it was my intention to accompany her, I had ordered my equipage also to be in readiness. I vaulted nimbly on my mule, which cut but a sorry figure by the side of Don Antonio's hunter. Besides his having one of the finest horses in Spain, this young gentleman was an experienced horseman, and before we started made his horse pass through a thousand manœuvres with considerable grace. I was extremely mortified that I could not by any means provoke my peaceable and stupid mule to imitate him; my endeavours to make him caper a little, served only to amuse the ladies who were observing us from the windows.

The Don pranced on one side of the litter, and I trotted on the other, for the sake of conversing with Donna Lucia on the road. We began, or rather, I began to discourse with her, for young Miras took so little part in the conversation, that he seldom went beyond a monosyllable, contenting himself with showing off his elegant person on horse-back to the best advantage. Knowing Don Antonio to be no great wit, I should have been a greater simpleton than he, had I not availed myself of so favourable an opportunity. Lucia asked me "if I intended to make a long stay at Saragossa." "That will depend on the pleasure in store for me at that place," replied I: "should my wishes be realized, I shall remain there a considerable

time." A tender glance with which I accompanied these words, spoke volumes. Lucia understood my meaning, and blushed deeply; but her eyes informed me that she felt not offended, and I was well pleased that I had hazarded this declaration, since it had not proved disagreeable to her, nor excited the jealousy of Miras, to whom it was a complete enigma.

I was somewhat surprised that so young and lovely a person as Lucia, should travel above a league from Saragossa, with a retinue consisting only of a duenna, one lackey and a muleteer. I had yet to know the privileges of widows in that country, where they enjoy unrestricted freedom. Travelling with so feeble an escort they frequently expose themselves to unexpected and unpleasant rencontres. Thus Donna Lucia, though accompanied by two cavaliers and her own attendants, was somewhat alarmed at a trifling adventure that befel us on our journey. We were already half way to Saragossa, when we perceived at a distance a most beautiful hunter, whose speed was equal to that of Bayarte or Brigliador,^[B] and who, galloping towards us, raised such a cloud of dust that we could not at first distinguish who was the cavalier who rode him; but no sooner could we discern him, than I fancied I saw the furious Rolando before me, such fierceness was in his looks.

[B] The names of two chargers famous in ancient romance; the former belonged to Reynaldos de Montalvan, and the latter to Orlando Furioso.—See the Octavo Edition of "Don Quixote, translated by Jarvis," vol. 2, page 329. *Trans.*

When he came up within ten or twelve paces of us, he stopped short to look at me. My foreign dress attracted his attention, and he seemed still more surprised at the familiar manner in which I was conversing with the fair widow. He was himself one of this lady's suitors, and flattered himself with great hopes of winning her, relying upon the opinion he imagined all the world must have of his bravery, to ensure him success over all his rivals. Seeing then Don Antonio on one side and me on the other, he rode most furiously between Miras and the litter, so that he almost overturned the one and dismounted the other. The lady was much alarmed at this insolent action, and told this bully in a rage, that the road was wide enough to allow of his passing, without presuming to insult persons who deserved more respect. He apologized to Lucia in a tone and manner more insolent than the action itself.

Miras, at the first impulse of his resentment, clapped his hands upon his pistol, but whether from the fear of missing his aim, or from an excessive

respect towards his mistress, he did not venture further in an engagement, for which, by the bye, he felt no great inclination. I pitied his awkward situation, and felt much disposed to take up his quarrel, thinking that this swaggerer was but a braggadocio. I reflected, however, that I might find myself mistaken; and seeing that the party most interested was not very forward in resenting the affront, I was wise enough to refrain from taking up his cudgels. All that I could do for him was, to request him to come to my side, and yield my place to him, which offer he accepted willingly, quite indifferent as to Lucia's opinion of his courage in being obliged thus to quit his post. Our blustering companion called himself Don Lucio de Ribera. He had been informed that the beautiful widow had slept at the monastery the preceding night, and intended to return this day. Accordingly he rode from the city to meet her, and offer his services to escort her home.

No sooner did this fellow perceive that Don Antonio had resigned his post, instead of thinking of maintaining it, than he took immediate possession of it himself, and prepared to converse with the lady, who, however, deceived his expectation; for, to mortify him, she answered not a word to all he had to say. She deigned not even to look at him, keeping her eyes and attention fixed on Miras and me. In this manner we arrived at Saragossa, and conducted Donna Lucia to her house, where she thanked me most politely for my attentions, adding, that she hoped that the city had sufficient charms to detain me some time. She observed but little ceremony towards the other two gentlemen, acknowledging their civility with a slight bow only. I took no notice of the haughty Don Lucio in parting, but paid a thousand compliments to Don Antonio, which so much pleased him, that he insisted on accompanying me to the Angel, a famous inn at the entrance of the town, and whither I had desired my luggage to be conveyed. Here Miras took his leave of me, in terms which convinced me that so far from suspecting me for a rival, he believed me to be one of his best friends.

I found my servant and muleteer at the inn, where they had engaged a very commodious apartment for me, in which I supped alone. The landlord, who was one of those inveterate jesters who abound with witticisms and puns, joined me soon after, thinking I should be vastly entertained with his company. He began the conversation by telling me all that was going on in the town, the privileges of which he much extolled, not forgetting to praise the spirit with which the inhabitants maintained those privileges. I was not averse to listening to him, for in the midst of a thousand impertinences, a

most excellent stroke of wit would occasionally escape him, as is often the case with babblers like him. When I had finished my supper, however, he ceased worrying me any longer with his nonsense, made his bow, and was about to retire. Stop friend, said I, be kind enough to desire a tailor to call upon me to-morrow morning; I have some work to give him. The entrusting mine host with this commission, furnished him with a new topic for conversation, and he took occasion to enlarge upon the knavery of tailors in general, abusing them as other people usually do. Nevertheless, after having railed at them most vehemently as a body, he finished by assuring me, that he knew one who knew how to behave himself to his customers, without cabbaging an inch of their cloth, and who, he doubted not, would please me.

He was as good as his word; for as soon as I was up the next morning, he introduced a tailor, who appeared to be by no means extravagant, and who understood his business well. I gave orders for a Spanish habit, in the fashion I wished it to be made, and he promised he would send it home in three days, made in so fashionable a style as could not fail to attract the admiration of every one. In the mean time, I wore the Italian suit I had purchased at Florence, in which I cut a tolerable good figure on the Corso, which is the place of resort for all the fashionables at Saragossa, and where I was at least not ashamed to appear as one of Donna Lucia's suitors; but as soon as I made my appearance amongst them in my new dress, I completely eclipsed them all, not only from its elegance, but from the fine jewels with which I thought proper to deck myself out. I was soon looked upon as the favoured lover of the lady, whose attention I certainly attracted; for, whether I accompanied her in her walks, or chanced to pass under her balcony, she evidently distinguished me in preference to all my rivals. The haughty Don Lucio could not conceal his envy of my happiness, and darted the most furious looks at me. With the others I lived on tolerable good terms, especially with Miras, who scarcely ever left me, and procured me all the pleasure he could, by introducing me into the most distinguished families in the city.

Thus I found myself esteemed and honoured at Saragossa, where I was as much in Lucia's favour as I had been in that of my Florence widow, when one morning, my servant announced to me, that there was a gentleman at my chamber-door who wanted to speak to me. Being still in bed, and thinking that it must be one of Don Antonio's friends, I desired that he might be admitted, and was not a little surprised at sight of the

person who had thus announced himself, who was a huge ugly looking fellow whom I had never seen before. He wore mustachios turned up, a high crowned hat which nearly reached the ceiling, and a very long sword, the hilt of which he was very careful in holding up, that it might not dangle on the floor; thus, shrugging up his shoulders, he walked with so heavy a foot, that the chamber shook at every step he took.

You will naturally expect that after so grand an entrance, he would address himself to me in a corresponding style; but no such thing; he was content to strut up and down my chamber, eyeing me from time to time in a most threatening manner. I soon grew tired of this dumb scene, so that jumping up on a sudden, I seized my pistols, and demanded what business he had there. This action seemed to bring him to his senses. "Do you know," said he, with an agitated voice, "the brave Don Lucio de Ribera, the flower and boast of Arragon?" I replied, "that I knew him merely by sight, and that it was but of little consequence whether I knew him or not." "I am come," continued he, presenting me a letter, "to find you on his behalf. This letter will explain the rest." I took the note very calmly, for I perceived plainly that the bearer was more frightened than myself, and having opened it, read these words:

"Be you an Italian or a Spaniard, your presumption is unpardonable in coming into this country to dispute our ladies' hearts with us: but as you appear to be a foreigner, we are willing to excuse your extreme rashness, on condition that you leave Saragossa within four and twenty hours. Should your evil genius induce you to despise our resentment, be prepared to encounter Don Lucio de Ribera, whom no one has hitherto been able to vanquish, but whom you must overcome before you can offer any pretensions to Donna Lucia."

Knowing the letter before I opened it to be from Don Lucio, I guessed that it must be a challenge, or something approaching it; so that I was not in the least astonished at its contents. "Sir," said I to the messenger, "tell your employer on this occasion, that whether Italian or Spaniard, I have two daggers very much at his service, and that I am ready to fight him in my shirt, to prevent the possibility of foul play. No coats of mail for me; the really brave never make use of them in single combat. Let Don Lucio agree to these articles, and he shall find that I am ready to brave any danger to deserve the heart of Lucia. This is my answer." "Give it me in writing," replied the bearer of the letter, "that the regular Don Lucio may be

convinced of my having delivered his message like a man of honour." To satisfy this valiant messenger, I took the trouble of committing to paper the same words that I had just told him aloud, and he left me, promising to return in the afternoon, to fix the hour and the spot on which we should fight. After this rascal had left the room, I congratulated myself exceedingly that I had acquitted myself so manfully on this occasion, for though I had not the slightest inclination to fight, it was not the less necessary to assume the bravo, which has got many a man out of a scrape in similar cases, and which indeed was the only way in which I could receive so boisterous a gentleman. Let the worst come to the worst, however, thought I, my mules being always ready, I can at any time make a retreat. It is true that the idea of leaving Lucia would have caused me some pain, but I was not yet so much in love with her, as to hesitate between the possession of her and the preservation of my own sweet person.

Still this affair caused no inconsiderable anxiety, and I was most intently musing upon it, when mine host entered the room without my perceiving him, to ask whether I was ready for dinner, and seeing me look into my pocket handkerchief after having made use of it, roared out most lustily: "Take care of yourself, Sir, or you are undone!" I shuddered at these words, for my head was so full of the last scene, that I thought nothing less than that Don Lucio was on his way up stairs with the intention of assassinating me; but seeing my landlord laugh at my alarm, I recovered myself a little, and gave him to understand that I did not much admire such jokes; this only caused him to laugh the more at my expence. "How came you then," said he, "to look into your handkerchief after having blown your nose? Know you not that you have thereby incurred a penalty for having broken the laws established against such ridiculous customs?" Knowing the fellow to be an original who meant no offence, I joined him in the laugh, and asked what the forfeit was. "No stipulated sum," replied he, "but I dare say I can let you off for a real." This I paid most willingly, though I would rather have paid twenty times the sum to have dispensed with the fright he had caused me. "In return for this," continued he, "I receive you from this moment as one of our fraternity, and promise to give you a licence, by virtue of which you may in future commit the like fooleries at your pleasure; and since your real has produced you the honour of a place amongst us, it is but fair that I should amuse you after dinner by the perusal of the list of such habits as will entitle any one to a place in our brotherhood."

No sooner had I dined, than he entered the room again, with a long tablet carefully sealed with yellow wax, containing the names of the elders and governors of the fraternity. The following pages contained all the fooleries that would entitle a person to be admitted into Fool's College. I shall quote five or six of these instances, which will suffice to give you an idea of the rest. Preamble: "We declare quite worthy to be admitted into our College, all those who may be addicted to the following habits:"

1st. He who talks to himself either in his room or in the street.

2d. He who in playing at bowls, runs after his own bowl with divers contortions, hoping to make it roll to the exact spot he wishes.

3d. All those who take up their cards one by one, thinking by that means to ensure themselves all the court cards in the pack.

4th. Those who inquire the hour of the day while the clock is striking exactly before them.

5th. Those who, having sent a servant on an errand, plant themselves at the window, thinking thereby to hasten his return.

6th. All those who after having blown their noses, examine their handkerchiefs most attentively, as though they expected to find pearls in them, &c. &c. &c.

I amused myself a great part of the afternoon in reading this budget of extravagances, expecting every moment to hear again from Don Lucio, and was just growing weary of staying so long within doors, when Don Antonio and some friends of his called upon me. They began, by telling me that they were come to offer me their services in the affair of honour that I had on hand, adding that the whole town knew that Don Lucio had sent me a challenge, and that duelling being prohibited, that Cavalier was already arrested. From this circumstance it was pretty clear to me that Don Antonio and his friends were of that description of persons, who are ever most eager to proffer their assistance, when they know that all danger is over. I accordingly related as much to my own advantage as possible, the full particulars of what had passed that morning between me and Don Lucio's messenger; upon which Don Antonio represented to me that I might also be arrested, and invited me to retire to his house. This I did not fail to accede to, for I dreaded any thing like imprisonment for more reasons than one. I passed the remainder of the day at that gentleman's house, but not intending to sleep there, I left him about ten o'clock at night to return to my inn.

On my way home I met two ladies, attended by a footman who carried a large lantern, by the light of which, I soon distinguished that they were extremely handsome. I therefore accosted them in the most polite manner, and they answered my civilities with considerable vivacity; and, judging from my appearance and dress that I should be an easy prey, they ogled me in such a manner that I could not resist accompanying them farther than I intended; but having come to the corner of a street, they stopped all of a sudden, and one of them said: "Come no farther, I beg. Sir; we are only going to visit a sick lady who resides a few doors up this street. If you have time to wait, we shall be walking home again in about a quarter of an hour, and you may not repent of having met us. You shall hear a song, and the lute played to admiration." Thus saying, they escaped from me, leaving me so fully persuaded they would keep their promise, that I was fool enough to wait in the street until near midnight. By that time, however, I was but too well convinced that I had been duped, sharp and cunning as I thought myself; and must further confess, to my confusion, that I had not even saved my purse from the dexterity of these accomplished damsels.

Being obliged, on my way to my lodging, to pass the house of my fair widow, I could not refuse myself the pleasure of gazing on it for some time, and I fancied that I perceived a man at the door. I imagined at first that this must be Don Lucio, knowing that he was in the habit of stationing himself near that spot every night, and this thought was accompanied by an emotion mingled with fear and jealousy. Recollecting, however, that he was in prison, I reflected that it could not be him; I grew confident, and, incited by jealousy, advanced towards the object that created it, and who, apparently, more afraid than myself, disappeared at my approach. Having reached the door, I heard the deafened creakings of a bolt, whence I concluded that some one was opening it as quietly as possible. I was not mistaken in my conjecture, for in a moment after, the door was half opened, so as to admit a man. Curiosity to know the bottom of this affair, in which I believed myself to be more interested than I really was, prompted me to slip in as quietly as possible. I immediately felt a hand held out to conduct me, for there was not a glimpse of light in the passage. I thought from the first, that the person mistook me, and could no longer doubt it, when being led into a back parlour, I was rather roughly regaled with a most fervent embrace, seasoned with the fragrant and delightful smell of pepper, garlic and saffron, which convinced me that this transported lover, who was so profuse of her

favours, could be no other than the cook. In the midst of her transports, however, she began to suspect, from touching my clothes and face, that I could not be the favoured swain whom she expected; and at length being convinced of her mistake, she suddenly let go her hold of me, and thought to escape; but I held her fast by the petticoat. She exerted all her strength to disengage herself, and I was as determined to detain her, until at length we both fell down with a tremendous crash. This noise awoke two footmen, who lay in an adjoining closet. They jumped instantly out of bed, thinking they heard thieves, and each arming himself with a sword, crept softly with a lamp into the parlour, where they found us stretched at our length on the floor.

They recognised me immediately, and surprised to see a gentleman who aspired to the hand of their mistress contending with so much violence for the good graces of a kitchen wench, who had never even tempted themselves, they burst into an immoderate fit of laughter, to my utter confusion. The insolence of the creature herself was surprising: she accused me of a deliberate design to violate her honour, and asserted that I had secreted myself in the house with that view. Without waiting to justify myself, I picked up my hat, which had been knocked off my head by a violent box on the ears, and addressing myself to the servant who carried the lamp, desired him to light me to the street door, which he did, grinning all the way in such a manner, that I was almost tempted to knock him down. I soon reached my inn, cruelly mortified at so disgraceful and pitiful an adventure, not doubting that the story would be all over the town the next day, and that I should be the common talk of all the inhabitants. This idea, which afflicted me more than you can possibly imagine, made me resolve to stay no longer in Saragossa than was absolutely necessary to make preparations for my departure. My equipage was ready, therefore, at break of day, and my mules as though they partook of their master's impatience to leave a place where he could not again make his appearance without shame, commenced their journey with a speed and seeming anxiety which pleased me exceedingly.

CHAP. XLVII.

Guzman departs for Madrid, where he engages in a new gallantry, the CONCLUSION of which does not prove so agreeable as the COMMENCEMENT.

I took the road to Madrid, and six days after my departure from Saragossa, I arrived at Alcala de Henares, a town, the situation of which is delightful, and which the beauty of its buildings renders comparable with the most flourishing capitols in the world. In addition to this, the *belles lettres* were cultivated there to perfection. I should certainly have taken up my abode there, had I not been foolishly desirous to visit St. James's once more, where I had formerly acted so miserable a part.

I stopped but eight days at Alcala, and then proceeded towards Madrid. That celebrated city saw arrive, with three mules in his train, two of which were laden with valuable property, that same Guzman who had formerly carried a basket in its market-place. I hesitated for some time as to where I should take up my lodging; but recollecting that in my time the best inn was in Toledo-street, I determined to alight there. I found it strangely changed. The landlord was dead, and his widow, though a shrewd active woman, who had more than one string to her bow, could not support its reputation on the same footing. It was certainly much fallen off; but the extreme civility with which they treated me, whom they looked upon as a rich young nobleman, prevented me from leaving them.

My next care was, to make special inquiries about my old friend the three-bagged apothecary; and though I did not much fear that I could be recognised, I must confess that I felt a secret joy when I learnt that he had taken his departure for that country whither his drugs had despatched so many of his patients before him. Ten years, however, had now elapsed since I left Madrid, and, besides that, I was much altered in person; who the devil could have recognized poor Guzman in the finery with which he was now disguised? I took great pleasure in shewing myself off in my best suits, particularly in the one I had purchased at Saragossa. I exhibited myself in them by turns, in the morning at the different churches, and in the evening at the Prado.

One night having returned home rather late to bed, as I crossed a corridor which led to my chamber, I heard the voice of a young lady accompanying a harp. I stopped to listen to this little concert, for it was very near my own room, and felt an extreme curiosity to know who were the fair performers. My landlady, who was going to send some sweetmeats and biscuits to refresh the singer, happened to pass by just at this moment, and told me that they were two ladies of Guadalajara, who were but just arrived at her house, to solicit a law-suit at Madrid for a large sum of money. I gave her to understand that I had an extreme desire to hear them nearer, and that she would confer an obligation on me which I should remember all my life, if she could procure me admittance into their company. She replied that she would do all she could in my favour, but that she dared not promise me, for the mother was a very reserved sort of woman, who led a very retired life with her daughter, who was very pretty, and whom she never trusted out of her sight. This only made me the more anxious to see her. My landlady assured me that she would do all in her power. With this assurance, I allowed her to enter the apartment where the ladies were, and I walked up and down the corridor, expecting their answer; which was, that the ladies hoped I would excuse their declining at so late an hour to receive a visit from a gentleman with whom they were not acquainted.

I pretended to be very much afflicted at this refusal, which upon the whole vexed me indeed; so that my good landlady, who appeared on her side as much concerned as I was, went into the ladies' apartment to try again what could be done, and at last she returned to let me know that the ladies consented to grant me an interview, on condition that I would only stay a quarter of an hour with them. I desired no more; sure that once admitted, the condition as to time would not be strictly observed. I presented myself then with the air of a man of quality, first to the mother, whom I saluted with great respect, then to the daughter, and they both received me as it became persons who knew the world. They were both so neatly dressed, considering they were just come off a journey, that I was quite astonished. The mother appeared to me very handsome, though there was in her looks something bold and shy. As for the daughter, she had a soft and expressive countenance, and appeared to me a young lady about seventeen or eighteen years old. I remarked in their room two large silver candlesticks on a table, and two toilets elegantly set out. I saw also three large travelling trunks, and a lackey in a very rich livery attended them with

the most profound respect. I had not the least doubt, therefore, that they must be of one of the first families of Guadalaxara, so that I began my compliments by apologizing for the liberty I had taken: and the better to justify my impatience, added that I had been so enchanted with their concert, that I could not resist the desire of expressing my satisfaction. The mother replied to my compliment with much wit and modesty. Our conversation naturally ran upon music, and I soon let them see clearly enough that I understood that science; then entreating them to renew their concert, I even offered to sing with them.

The ladies, curious to hear me, agreed to it; so the mother took up the harp, and the young lady began to sing an air I knew. I endeavoured to display the full power of my voice, and it produced the same effect here as at Florence, or at the Abbey near Saragossa, and the ladies seemed transported with pleasure; they forgot the condition of a quarter of an hour, for it had already struck twelve, and none of us thought of retiring. The mother, however, as decency required she should give me notice of it, at length did it in the most obliging manner, adding how happy they should be to pass some more agreeable moments with me, during their stay at Madrid. I then took my leave, and let the young lady see by my looks that I was not insensible to her charms; and indeed it was more true than I thought, for during all the night sleep did not close my eyelids.

The next morning my hostess, who usually drank a dish of chocolate every day with me, came into my room smiling, and said: "I have just left the apartment of your fair neighbours, and you cannot conceive how much pleased they are with you. Besides that they find your person altogether pleasing, they are also delighted with your agreeable and cheerful conversation, and if you are inclined to carry it on, I have not the least doubt of your success; the mother and daughter are equally pleased with you." I swallowed these sweet words as if they had been honey, and pleased to have in so short a time made so lively an impression, I answered, that I was equally satisfied with them; that the mother appeared to me to be still very attractive, but as for the daughter, no woman was to be compared with her, and I was willing to undertake her conquest, if any well-disposed person would help me in the attempt. "I understand you," replied the hostess; "you wish me to render you that service. I have no objection; but how shall we begin the business?" "I will this evening," said I, "prevail on the ladies to take a walk, and order an elegant repast for them, in some

house.” “Not for the world,” cried out my hostess; “that would affront the mother, who would soon see into your design, and break off your acquaintance altogether. Let us do something better,” continued she; after having paused a little, “this entertainment must be given in my name. I will have the collation prepared according to your desire, in a garden that I have on the banks of the Mançanares, where I will invite the ladies to pass the evening; you will come and surprise us, as if chance only had brought you thither, and we shall be more to ourselves in that place than in any other.” I approved of the idea, and my hostess took upon herself the charge of inviting the mother to the entertainment.

My confidante went immediately to make the proposal to the ladies, with whom she remained nearly an hour, by which I judged that she had trouble enough to persuade them to accept of it: and indeed, when she returned she told me that the mother had been very hard to be prevailed upon, and that she had for a long time despaired of inducing her to accept my invitation. “All that I require of you is to behave so that nothing appear to have been concerted between us. When you come to the garden, pretend to be astonished to meet us there. In a word, let your coming seem purely accidental.” I answered, that she might be sure I would spoil nothing, and we then agreed how things should be managed to render the entertainment as agreeable as possible.

We succeeded. The entertainment was like that of a young lover who was desirous to please, and the guests received it as if ignorant of any bad motive. We were extremely well amused. As the mother had not her harp with her, her daughter and I were obliged to sing without music, sometimes together, and sometimes alternately, exchanging slyly the most tender looks; mine with the view of expressing my passion, and hers to increase it. Night insensibly surprised us in the garden, and whilst the hostess, out of complaisance for me, held the mother in conversation, I courted the daughter, who did not seem to listen with indifference to my empassioned declaration: at last, being obliged to return to town, I waited on the ladies to their lodgings, where, as a special favour, they granted me half an hour’s conversation, after which I took my leave, as much in love, as I thought, with my new mistress, as I had been with any other before.

The next day I sent the young lady a most pathetic billet-doux by my hostess, but she returned no answer; to have received it, however, unknown to her mother, was a favour of itself. I wrote another, which I gently put into

her own hand in the evening when the ladies were again treated at my expence. This time I had an answer; very short indeed, for there were but two lines of no real import, but in which I fancied I discovered an infinite deal of wit. Thus they made me dispute every inch of ground to increase my desires, or, to tell the truth, all the parts were so well acted in this intrigue, by my good hostess, that she knew how to manage each party to her own advantage, just as she pleased. However, I became every day more and more intimate with my fair neighbour. I scarcely ever stirred out of the house, so charmed was I with her company. The mother often went out, as she said, to make interest respecting her law-suit, and when that happened, my officious confidante gave me notice of it, and without ceremony would conduct me to the daughter, with whom I staid while she was at her toilet; and lest the facility of enjoying such favourable opportunities should lessen the charms of them, she would every now and then disturb us by false alarms of the mother's return.

When my landlady thought I was completely in love, she proposed to me to marry Donna Helena de Melida, which was the young lady's name. This proposal put me upon my guard against my worthy hostess, and I now began to see into the plot which had been laid against me. She had hitherto represented the lady to be too rich, and of too high a rank for me to encourage any hope that she would consent to give her hand to an adventurer. My landlady from this time became suspected by me, and to rid myself at once of her importunities, I told her in plain terms that I was engaged in another quarter. No sooner had I expressed myself in this manner, than the ladies changed their batteries. Hitherto they had constantly refused the presents I had ventured to send them by mine hostess; but they now adopted a plan entirely different, resolving to fleece the bird while they had it in their power, and they did in reality pluck many good feathers out of my plumage. In proportion, however, as I acted with generosity towards her, the less my fair Helena became reserved; so that after several familiar and interesting tête-à-têtes, my passion began to subside, and from that time nothing else passed between us but an interchange of civility and politeness.

A new incident completed my cure. One morning I saw coming out of the Dominican's Church a lady of a majestic deportment and richly dressed, whom I took for a woman of quality; and as she passed near me, though I dared not bow to her, I shewed her so much respect, that she took notice of it, and viewed me with so much attention, that I thought myself highly

honoured; in Spain even the look that a lady bestows on a man being considered a favour. My curiosity induced me to inquire who she was, and I accordingly followed her. She observed me, but walked on at a slow pace. She was followed by two duennas and a valet, which confirmed me in the opinion that I had of her being a lady of quality. When she was in the middle of the broad street, she stopped before a magnificent house and went in. I had not the least doubt that she lived there, and after some inquiries I learnt that she was the daughter of Signor Don Andrea, who assumed the title of Don in quality of the Court Banker, and that this young lady had the reputation of being very virtuous.

I could not get this adventure out of my head the whole of the morning; towards evening I walked up and down before the banker's window again, and my trouble was not lost. I had a full view of the banker, who was conversing with his daughter on a balcony, who appeared to be a very personable man. As for the lady I cannot say that she was a perfect beauty, but she had an agreeable air and easy manners, which pleased me extremely, and prepossessed me in favour of her mind. If I had been charmed in the morning, how much more so was I in the evening. I returned home quite in love with her, and resolved to get acquainted with her father the very next day; which I accomplished in the manner I am about to relate to you. Since my arrival at Madrid, I had the precaution to have my diamonds all new set, for fear my relations should give advice to their correspondents, and cause me to be arrested. I had even run a great risk in showing them to the jeweller. I carried these to the amount of ten or twelve thousand franks to the banker, telling him at the same time, that I had others at home of more considerable value. He looked at them with an eager eye, valued them at twelve thousand franks, and offered to pay me that sum in six months, if I would allow him to sell them for me.

As I had no other intention but to begin a train of business with him, I accepted of his offer, and even refused his note of hand for the value of the jewels, telling him that I knew too well what reputation he had in the world to require of him any other security than his own word. We then agreed that he should pay me in three months six thousand franks, and the other six thousand in three months after. My way of dealing charmed him so much, that he thanked me for the confidence I placed in him, and made me many protestations of service. He then shewed me all over his house, which was richly furnished. I observed equipages for him and his daughter, with a

great number of servants. All these objects dazzled my eyes so much, that I was easily inclined to look upon him as one of the richest bankers in Spain.

If all that was offered to my sight tended to confirm me in this opinion, his discourse was still more calculated to mislead me. He told me that he transacted business to the amount of two or three millions of franks every day. That the court always made use of him, and of his purse, to remit considerable sums to foreign countries; that he had access to the ministers when he pleased; that the greatest lords were his friends, and that but few of them who had not dealings with him.

This statement was not altogether without foundation. He had formerly lived upon such a footing with the great, but by dealing with, and trusting those great men rather too extensively, he had run himself so far in debt, that he only supported himself by his wits, which were such, at any rate, that he kept up his credit. My jewels were a great help to him in his embarrassment; for he was just at this time extremely straightened for a considerable sum of money, and raised half by them; having seized the opportunity of the marriage of the Duke of Medina Sidonia's daughter to dispose of them advantageously. As I could then only judge of his circumstances by appearances, I considered myself very happy in having made an acquaintance with him; and even secretly blamed myself for having conceived so bold an idea as that of aspiring to the hand of his only daughter, who appeared to be a match worthy of a prince.

Don Andrea, on his side, was not without surprise at my mode of proceeding. He therefore sent a trusty person to inquire my character from my landlady, and in what style I was living at Madrid. From all sides, however, he obtained favourable reports of me; for though no one was acquainted with my family, I might easily pass for a man of quality, as far as my mode of living, manners, and conversation, would impress such a belief. After such good accounts of me, he concluded that I was the man heaven had intended for his son-in-law. He mentioned it to his daughter who told him that I had followed her from the Dominican's church to her house; that I continually passed under the windows; in a word, that by all my actions I had given her to understand that I had conceived a passion for her. The father had too much experience not to believe the same thing, and the confidence I had placed in him by giving him my diamonds without a note, could only be the effect of my love for his daughter. They both rejoiced at it in their private conversations, and concluding that I was richer

than a Jew, they resolved to manage it so well as not to miss so fair an opportunity of advancing themselves again in the world.

Accordingly the banker came to visit me at the hotel; I expected him, and I took care to set out in my room all my jewels, which had a great effect upon him. He was especially struck with my gold chain, the workmanship of which he praised much, and offered to sell it for me at a third more than it cost; I took him at his word and let him have it, as I had done with the diamonds, without a note. His joy was extreme; he made me a thousand protestations of friendship, and beginning already to act the part of a father-in-law, gave me advice how to put out my ready money to the best advantage. A few days after, he brought me the sum he had promised me for my gold chain. This increased the confidence I had placed in him, and induced me to acknowledge his trouble by a present suitable for a young lady, which I sent to his daughter, after he had granted me leave to do so. This present having been received favourably, made me bold enough to discover my passion after the custom of the country, that is to say by signs and looks, and it seemed she did not disapprove of it.

As for the father, whom I saw every day, I talked with him of nothing else but trade and business, waiting for the first good opportunity to declare my sentiments. This new amour cooled me very much with respect to my last intrigue. My neighbours perceived but too well the alteration, for there was an end to feasts and presents. I seldom stopped at home, and when I returned in the evening I went directly to bed, or when I could not avoid the conversation of the ladies, it was so cold, that they soon guessed I had shaken off their yoke. Helena, finding that her kindness to me, far from increasing my ardour, had diminished it, shed tears out of spite. She held a grand consultation with her mother and the hostess, on my change, which they did not fail to attribute to some new intrigue; they resolved to try my generosity, and if they had no occasion to be satisfied with me, to have recourse to some of their tricks to be avenged for my inconstancy. An opportunity soon offered for the execution of their design. Two young lords who had plenty of ready money came to live at the hotel; they asked me to play with them, and at two or three sittings I won two hundred and fifty pistoles of them. The ladies were no sooner informed of this, than they prevailed upon me to take a walk with them, which I could not refuse, and in coming back we passed before a shop where they sold silks and gold stuffs. Our landlady, who was with us, was very anxious that I should go in

and buy a new gown for Donna Helena, saying that I had won enough to make her that little present. I suffered the hostess to talk as much as she pleased, and laughing at her entreaties, I baffled the expectation of the ladies, who fully expected to have completely drained my purse. This last action sufficiently convinced them that I was no longer in their snares.

I wanted my money for a better use, for in my rambles about the town I had seen a house newly built; I asked Don Andrea's advice, and he approved of it, and even managed it so that I made a very good bargain. It cost me only three thousand ducats, which I paid down before him with as much sang froid as if I had a hundred thousand crowns in my coffers. You may imagine what an effect it had on my future father-in-law, who, though a man of rather keen understanding, had not the least doubt that he had met with a good son-in-law, and that it remained only for him to allure me cunningly into the snare. I furnished my house elegantly, and prepared to occupy it. The day that I intended to sleep in it, thinking that I could not, without rudeness, dispense with taking the last farewell of my neighbours, I paid them a visit accordingly, and paid them many compliments, which they received with much politeness, and so much good humour, that I was quite surprised; then addressing the hostess, I thanked her for all the attention she had shewn me, which I told her I should remember to the last moment of my life. She answered all my civilities in the most flattering manner, and very obligingly requested the honour of my company to dine with her before my departure. As I knew her to be a woman of very indifferent character, and wished to part amicably, I readily agreed to her request.

I accordingly dined with my hostess, who had provided for me three dishes which she knew I was very fond of; but she kept me for a fourth, which was not at all to my liking. This was brought to me in the persons of an Alguazil and six of his followers, who entered the room with a warrant to apprehend me. At this sight I was thrown into such confusion, that I had not the least doubt I was ruined. All my relations presented themselves to my remembrance, for I expected every moment some persons employed by them would find me out, not so much as dreaming that any other person in Madrid could have any cause of action against me. I rose from the table in a dreadful disorder; I knew not what to do: I attempted the door, but was stopped by three of the fellows; then I went to the window in order to escape that way, but here the three others prevented me. The Alguazil, who was one of the most rational of the brotherhood, observing the confusion I

was in, came up to me smiling, and gently said to me: "Signor Cavalier, cheer up, there is no need of being so much alarmed; this business is but a trifle, and you will clear yourself for a few pistoles. Look," said he again, giving me the warrant, "read, and you will see that you have taken alarm without cause." These words, which appeared to me to come from a fellow, who, well informed of my tricks, only amused himself by bantering me, did not much lessen my fear. I sat down, however, and running over the warrant in as collected a manner as I was able, I read the name of Donna Helena de Melida; I then took breath a little, and turning to the Alguazil: "What does it mean?" said I; "What! is it in the name of that lady I am arrested? what have I done to her?" "She pretends," answered he, smiling, "that you have obtained by force, what her virtue had first refused to your desires."

"What do I hear?" cried I, quite surprised. "Has Helena impudence enough to affirm that I am guilty of such a crime?" "Why not," replied the Alguazil; "she may have some design in accusing you of it. True she will be obliged to prove it, and you will be allowed to defend yourself, but what is the most disagreeable of it," added he, "is, that by the duty of my function, I must carry you to prison." By this time I had recollected myself, and I read the warrant over again; and after considering what I should do, I rose and took the Alguazil aside: "Sir," said I, "I believe you to be a man of honour; consider, I pray, the unjust persecution I am suffering. I declare to you, that far from having used violent means to attain my happiness, the fair Helena has not been backward in promoting it: if you knew how much money I have spent".... "I have not the least doubt of it," said he; "I know this wench of old, as well as the roguish tricks of her mother. They have both lived here at Madrid these ten years, where they have no other trade but to ensnare young foreigners. You are the third they have served the very same trick you complain of, and between ourselves I believe you will not be able to get clear without a sum of money." "I think as you do," said I; "there can be no other means to hush it up quickly, and without noise; I entrust you," I added, slipping privately a diamond ring, worth twelve or fifteen pistoles into his hand, "to accommodate matters." He put the ring on his finger, and, with the tone of an Alguazil, he answered: "I will go and see the ladies, and if they refuse to desist in their action against you, I will threaten them with keeping an eye over their conduct, which will not fail to make them listen to reason."

After these words he left me in the room with his men, who, dazzling my eyes with the points of their spikes, kept me in awe till his return. If the hostess, who I had good reason to suspect had been the inventor of this piece of roguery, had been present then, I should have eased my mind by calling her all the names she deserved; but to avoid my reproaches, she had taken flight at the sight of the blood-hounds of justice. I was not altogether without uneasiness about the conferences held in the apartments of my adversaries. I could not place sufficient confidence in the fidelity of my agent to believe him more in my interest than in that of the ladies. However, he acted fairly on the occasion, obliging them to be contented with a hundred pistoles, of which he had twenty for his own share. I thanked my stars that I had got off so cheaply; I left the inn never to return to it, and repaired to my own house, very happy that the adventure had been hushed up with so little noise.

CHAP. XLVIII.

*Guzman pays his addresses to the Banker's Daughter, and marries her:
consequences of this marriage.*

As soon as I had got rid of Helena, her mother and the hostess, I devoted myself entirely to my new amour, and thought of nothing else but to become the son-in-law of Don Andrea, who, on his side, fearing that I should embark in some new intrigue, had no less impatience to give me his daughter than I to obtain her. I went the very next day to the Banker's house, who kept me to dinner, towards the end of which my intended bride appeared, as if by chance; I rose immediately to pay my respects to her, and express the agreeable surprise her presence excited in me. She returned my compliments with a modest air, and would have retired, but her father prevented her. Eugenia, said he to her, stay with us; this gentleman is my friend, and I am happy to let him have a proof of it by giving you leave to converse with him. I did not fail to thank him for so great a favour, with which I was quite delighted, and more so indeed than I really appeared to be.

I then entered into conversation with Eugenia, and to increase my joy, Don Andrea, under pretence of writing some letters, retired to a corner of the drawing room, to leave us more to ourselves.

If he acted in this manner to afford me the opportunity of a delightful conversation, he did not favour a fool, for I availed myself of this interview, not knowing when I should have a more favourable one, to declare my passion. I called forth all my genius, which served me well enough on the occasion, and the lady enchanted me by the delicacy of her replies; in the mean time, the father still pretending to be very busy, now and then asked pardon for being no better company; I returned him compliment for compliment, and following my point, still courted the daughter in a low voice, as if afraid of disturbing him in his reading. We had been three hours together, when the Banker thinking proper to put an end to our conversation, came and joined us, and Eugenia after having made a curtesy disappeared.

I now felt so much esteem, or rather was so much in love with this lady, that I could not forbear breaking out in praise of her; and speaking from the fullness of my heart, I told Don Andrea, that no one could possibly be more sensible of his daughter's merit than I was. The old fox listened to me very attentively, and to encourage me to explain myself more clearly, he held a long discourse on the necessity of persons of my age marrying, to avoid an infinite number of precipices to which they are daily exposed, and on the importance of the choice of a wife, since it commonly decided the happiness or misery of her husband. He then proceeded to assure me of the good opinion he had conceived of me; telling me that I had won his heart by my ingenuous manners and the confidence I had placed in him; and that I might rely that there was nothing that lay in his power which he would not do to convince me of it. I was not much behind hand with him in professions. I opened my whole heart to him, and protested that he might make me the happiest of men in giving me Eugenia. He considered for some time, or appeared to do so, to persuade me that I set his friendship at too great a trial; however, before we parted, I knew what I had to expect. He embraced me tenderly when I left him, and told me he had certain views of establishing his daughter more advantageously, but that he had given them all up to shew me how dear I was to him. At these words, I took one of his hands, and kissed it with a transport that proved more fully than all I could have said, the gratitude of my heart.

From this time the banker called me his son. He managed all my affairs; the six thousand franks which he had engaged to pay me in three months, he now advanced immediately, to assist me in furnishing my house, and he bought for me, at a cheap rate, several elegant pieces of furniture, which a person in want of money was obliged to sell. In a word, I dined every day with my future father-in-law. I saw his daughter every day, and enjoyed all the privileges of a son-in-law; except that one only, which the title of a husband could give a right to. One thing alone surprised me, which was, that in all the conversations I had as yet had with Don Andrea, he had never uttered a word about any portion. I attempted to sound him on this subject, but he gave me to understand that his intention was not to part with much ready money on the wedding-day. "You will receive only ten thousand franks down," said he, "but you may rely on the sum of fifty thousand after my death." I thought ten thousand franks but a paltry portion for the daughter of a man whom I had thought so rich; nevertheless, considering

that tradesmen do not like to lessen their capitals, I was obliged to be contented.

I now earnestly entreated Don Andrea not to let me languish in the expectation of being in reality his son-in-law. He yielded to my solicitations, and our nuptials were celebrated with great pomp. My father-in-law paid me the ten thousand franks, as had been agreed, and I soon found employment for them. I made my bride a present of all the jewels I had left, bought her most superb dresses; kept up incessant rejoicing in my new house for the first fortnight; provided women and footmen to attend her. In a word, I set up a way of living which would soon have ruined me, had I not by my own industry supplied the means to meet this increased expenditure. The banker, it is true, promised mountains of gold, if fortune would but smile on his speculations. He was a man of vast designs and projects, and his son-in-law being something of the same turn of mind, we thought of no less than monopolizing in a very short time the whole business of the kingdom. Unluckily, however, for the success of our enterprises, his sole reliance was on my purse, and mine on his; and the illusion soon vanished, when we found ourselves obliged to communicate the state of our affairs to each other. The eyes of both of us were opened without recrimination, for, in fact, we had nothing to reproach each other with; on the contrary, our mutual confidence had the effect of making our union more close; and being now known to each other for what we really were, like robbers we swore to be faithful.

Our partnership at first made a great noise, owing to the mysterious tone with which Don Andrea told every body that he had chosen for his son-in-law a man who was possessed of immense riches. It was soon spread about, and every one was for dealing with us, and came to us in preference to other bankers; and we might by our credit only have increased every day the favourable opinion they had of our wealth, if we had been contented to have associated with tradesmen, and no doubt we should have made a considerable fortune; but the uncommon weak partiality that my father-in-law always had for people of the Court, put a check to our success. What he received with one hand was squandered with the other. If a Marquis, a Count, or a Knight of San Jago, were civil to him, they were sure to obtain any loan of money, and knowing his vanity, they would not fail to lavish upon him the most flattering compliments.

If a minister looked favourably on him, the very next day he would send him some rich present to no purpose whatever. He always had his head filled with chimerical projects which he would put in execution, and if I happened to shew him the folly of them, he laughed at me, and treated me with contempt, as a man who had not common sense, and was quite a novice in the business of the great world.

However, with all his experience, our best substance was soon spent, our stock grew low, and we were reduced to make use of every means to renew and uphold our credit. What engines did we not set to work for that purpose? we bought and sold any thing; we received pawns; we lent money at usurious interest; in short there was no sort of commerce which we were not engaged in; besides what I knew already, my industry, improved by exercising it, helped me to new expedients for the good of our society. However, I must own that I was but a mere beginner compared to my father-in-law. Our gains were great, and would have been sufficient to have maintained us agreeably; and if we had understood how to live with economy, we should not have been obliged to make use of some sorry shifts, which in spite of all our skill we were sometimes compelled to resort to. In addition to this, our domestic expenses were most profuse. If Don Andrea was fond of luxury and good living, his daughter was not behind hand with him; there was nothing too rich or too fine for her; we kept as magnificent a table as any nobleman, more servants than we conveniently wanted, and our house was continually full of relations and friends whom we entertained and treated with the greatest profusion.

This bustle did not less please my humour than that of my wife, and while our affairs went on well, I did not in the least oppose it. I got tired, however, in two or three years after my marriage, when I perceived that through bad management, and some unforeseen accidents, our fortune began to diminish apace. Frightened at the prospect of distress, I ventured to remonstrate gently with Eugenia; God knows how I was treated by her! I complained to Don Andrea, who reproved her; and the whole family blamed her for her behaviour; but even my softest words, the reproaches of her father, and the entreaties of her friends, did but exasperate her the more against me: in a word, she declared to me that she did not mean to have the least reform in her family. After this decree, which the temper of my wife made quite absolute, I wisely resolved not to contradict her any more, but endeavour to fortify myself with more patience for the future.

It was, however, with extreme grief, that I saw melting away, like snow, all the money I had brought with me from Italy; and I could not think of the consequences of my marriage without sighing bitterly for having been so deprived of sense as to marry at all. Sometimes, to excuse myself for having acted so foolishly, I recalled to mind the rich figure that Don Andrea made when I became his son-in-law; and who could have imagined that I should find my ruin in an establishment that appeared to possess the means of the most solid fortune? When I observed that there was no longer any hope of being able to live on the same footing, I applied to my father-in-law for advice in my embarrassment.

It was on this occasion that he showed me how skilful he was in all the tricks of business. "The truth is," said he, "you must do here, what I have done myself in similar cases; which is to save the little that remains to you at the cost of others:" then without the least delay, he counterfeited letters of transfer, and false contracts, and I do not know how many similar deeds, all equally worthy of a public reward, if proper justice could always be administered to all honest folks that make use of them. He did not stop here; for in order to establish my credit, which was now become necessary to him, he made me purchase an estate of five hundred ducats a year, which his brother possessed; when I say purchase, I mean only in appearance, for we were not able, both together, to muster a sufficient sum to shew the Notary, that he might witness the payment of the purchase-money. It cost me, however, but fifty crowns to borrow this sum for one day, and thus the sale was apparently completed. At the same time I gave the seller a deed, by which I formally declared that the said estate did not belong to me, but was as much his as ever, to whom I abandoned the enjoyment of it, having no manner of claim. I was well pleased with these shuffling tricks, because they were advantageous to me. Besides, I knew that they were commonly practised in all trading cities.

Thanks to my father-in-law, I had now secured something to myself, let fortune be as contrary as it pleased; and being able to trade again upon the faith of this new estate, I went on in my usual courses. Unfortunately this state of things could not last long. People who have been cheated are sure to be undeceived at last: besides, my wife's always spending more than I gained, was sufficient of itself to ruin me, and I could not hold out against it any longer. Don Andrea was still lucky enough to get himself out of the scrape. As for me, I could no longer keep out of the clutches of a cursed

Alguazil, who arrested me on the part of my creditors, and led me to prison; but they found themselves overreached when they set about seizing my effects, and learned that they were secretly made over. I was not so unconscionable as to wish them to lose all; so I paid each a tenth part of what was due, promising to liquidate the remainder in ten years. I was set at liberty again on these terms.

The proud Eugenia was so extremely mortified at my imprisonment and bankruptcy, the shame of which she thought would fall on her only, that she could not be consoled, and died very shortly after; and as she left no child, I found myself under the obligation of refunding her dowry, which under my present circumstances, could not fail to destroy my every project. To tell the truth, therefore, the tears I shed at her death were not the effect of the loss of my wife, but of regret for my money which she had so foolishly squandered, and for her's which I had to return to her father. Notwithstanding which I did not fail to act the good husband, and ordered her funeral so superb, that my creditors murmured at it. Though I had now become a widower, I did not cease to live on good terms with Don Andrea. Besides that I could not have gained any thing by tricking him, he was the only man who was in possession of all my secrets, and I had still occasion for his assistance. I submitted, therefore, very patiently to all he required of me, and he was so much pleased with my conduct towards him, that he behaved in an equally handsome manner towards me.

CHAP. XLIX.

Guzman, after the death of his Wife, wishes to embrace the Ecclesiastical life, and with that view repairs to Alcala de Henarés to study. The fruits of his studies.

AFTER having rendered the last duties to my wife, and her dowry to her father, I still remained in my own house, which was now all that was my own; and even this was completely stripped, with the exception of one room, which Don Andrea, out of compassion, had furnished for me with a few articles of trifling value. Here I was occupied in making reflections on the past, and in devising means for my future subsistence.

What now can I possibly do? said I to myself. I fear I shall find no more Apothecaries, no Banker like that at Milan, no more relations to trust their jewels to my care. What then is to become of me? O Sayavedra, my dear confidant, how do I now miss you! Why can you not be witness of my troubles when I stand so much in need of your address and advice? Were you now present, we could together devise some scheme for my relief; but, alas, I have lost you! I ought no longer to rely on your assistance, which, perhaps, at this moment, you repent sorely having ever afforded me.

This last thought affected me exceedingly, and I felt so disgusted with the world that I resolved to quit it. I must, said I, turn my thoughts to the church. In that asylum I may possibly find that solid happiness which I have hitherto sought for in vain. How many knaves have made their fortune in this way? why, therefore, should I not try my luck? I may become a good preacher; and the pulpit is the road to bishoprics. Let the worst come to the worst, with the money I may get for my house I may be able to purchase some chance benefice; and even should I be so unfortunate as not to meet with one, I can only put my money out at interest; and if the dividends be not sufficient for me to lead an agreeable life, I must make up for it by becoming chaplain to some rich nunnery. Though I already know more Latin than is necessary to fill a place of that description, yet will I, nevertheless, go to Alcala, and take one course of philosophy, and another of theology, that I may be the more worthy of it. And if the condition of a scholar should appear to me too arduous for a man of my age, I can but at

last have recourse to the good fathers of the order of St. Francis, who, when they have once heard me sing, would receive me among them, though I could not read a word.

Thus you see, friendly reader, that persons of wit are never at a loss. A fine resource, truly! you will answer; to embrace an Ecclesiastical life with the sole view of enjoying every terrestrial comfort, is not seeking a very canonical vocation. Agreed, I will not contend with casuists on this point: but will candidly confess that I consulted custom more than the Canons, and that, in thinking of becoming priest, I studied nothing but my own convenience. I communicated my intentions to my father-in-law, wishing to persuade him that they were the effect of a thousand moral reflections I had made on the uncertainty of all earthly blessings; or rather that I was inspired by heaven. As this banker was not much better than myself, he applauded my resolution, which, he said, he could not sufficiently praise, were it only for the sake of escaping my creditors.

It now only remained for me to sell my house, which I very soon did. I met with a purchaser who gave me almost as much as it had cost me, the quarter of the town having been much built upon since I bought it. As soon as I had completed this sale, I carried the money to the bank. It could bring me in but very little, but in addition to its being there in safety, I could draw it out again whenever I pleased. After having thus disposed of my property, procured a proper dress for a student who aspired to sacred orders, which consisted of a long cloak and cassock, and after having bid adieu to Don Andrea and my best friends, I set out for the town of Alcala, where I arrived a few days before the opening of the colleges. I was at first doubtful where I should take up my lodging; whether to enter myself in a college, or hire an apartment and board in the town. I had been accustomed to enjoy entire liberty at my own house, to live according to my own fancy, to eat what I pleased, without being subject to stipulated hours, which I must conform to in a boarding house, where I should dine and sup with the students, the majority of whom were mere children. On the other hand, when I considered the expense of an establishment of my own; of keeping a servant who might be addicted to thieving, gallantry, or wine, or perhaps all three together; not to mention other inconveniences which are attached to the life of a young man completely his own master, I decided at last that I would enter myself at one of the boarding houses, and accordingly agreed with one which I thought would be most suitable to my age.

I was not long without acquaintances. I was fortunate enough to meet with some students of about my own age. With these I associated; for I was ashamed to keep company with the younger ones. I began by applying myself to the study of philosophy, in which, as I united indefatigable perseverance with a natural happy genius, I soon made great progress, and at the end of two years was considered one of the first students in the university. After having gone through my course of philosophy, I took my degrees as Master of Arts, in which I got the second place, though I well deserved the first. This injustice was winked at in favour of the son of one of our most celebrated professors. I did not murmur at it; on the contrary, I felt more pride in hearing it said by every body that I had been unfairly passed over, than I should have felt if justice had been done to me. I next commenced upon Theology, and continuing to study with the same ardour, it soon became mere amusement to me, and I felt, or, at least, fancied that I grew wiser every day.

Although I made it a point of honour never to miss a single lesson, and was, consequently, much engaged in my scholastic duties, yet I had still some time for pleasure. As I had been long accustomed to good cheer, and fared but badly at the boarding-house, I generally gave a little entertainment twice or thrice a week, by which I acquired the reputation of a rich and generous man; and what will more surprise you, during almost four years that I lived in this manner, I formed no sort of acquaintance with females, even the most modest. I scarcely knew whether there were any lovely women in the town; in fact, I carefully shunned every opportunity of hearing any thing about them. I took great credit to myself for being thus upon my guard against the fair sex; for I knew by experience how dangerous it was for me, and had the resolution during almost the whole course of my studies to avoid that rock: happy indeed, had I completely finished them without at last splitting upon it!

I was now on the point of passing as Bachelor in Divinity; and I was obliged in the first place to take orders, which are only bestowed on persons who possess some cure, chapel, or other living, I was greatly at a loss what to do; for since I had studied at the University I had consumed the better half of my resources. In this dilemma I bethought myself of applying again to the father of expedients, Don Andrea. I had taken care to keep up a correspondence with him, in which I had rendered him an exact account of my success in my studies, which he had always professed himself

extremely pleased at. I now wrote and informed him of my present difficulty, and entreated his advice. He answered that he was much pleased to have it in his power to oblige me; that he would with that view make over my wife's portion to me as if to found some chapel, and that in the deed it should be stipulated, that I should cause a mass to be said every day for the soul of the defunct. But at the same time, I was to declare by another deed, that this property was not a farthing of it my own, and that I would put Don Andrea in possession of it whenever he thought proper. A false conveyance of this description, made for religious purposes, so far from appearing to me to infringe the decrees of the holy councils, did not raise the slightest scruple in my conscience. I grant you I was a man not to be over nice in the business, any more than my father-in-law, who I verily believe had never in his life transacted business less deviating than this from the Ecclesiastical Canons. Be that as it may, however, not being able to do otherwise, this was the gate at which I now fully intended to enter the sanctuary of the ministers of religion.

In the mean time, until I could receive orders, I began to avoid all sorts of company; and to live more regularly in frequenting places of worship. One day when the weather was extremely fine for walking, I quitted the town on a pilgrimage to St. Mary of the valley, an agreeable hermitage, situate about a mile distant. On my way I overtook a great concourse of people on their journey to the same spot, and the Chapel of the Saint was so crowded when I arrived, that there was scarcely room to kneel down in it. A lady, who sat two or three paces from me, observing my embarrassment, retired somewhat further back, as if by that action to make room for me next to her. I was extremely surprised at this polite attention from a female with whom I was not acquainted, and who, I thought, could not know me; and in spite of my affected gravity, I could not help fixing my eyes on her elegant figure, doubting not, from her dress and demeanour that she was a lady of some consequence.

She carefully concealed her face from me, darting, however, an occasional glance at me with one eye, which pierced my very soul. I took possession of the vacant place near her, and wishing to testify my gratitude in some compliment I said in a whisper: "How dangerous is this politeness!" "I can scarcely think that you can be afraid of it," said she in the same tone. I dared not reply for fear of being overheard by the ladies who sat by her, and seemed to be of her party. I looked at them all

attentively, and in one of them I recognized the widow of one Dr. Gracia, a physician, a lady already in years, and who kept a boarding house in the town. I knew that she had three daughters who were called the three Graces, as well on account of the name of their father, as of their lovely persons. I had now no doubt that the lady whom I had just spoken to, must be one of these three celebrated sisters; and as report boasted particularly of the beauty and wit of the eldest, I could not help wishing that it might be her; a wish, however, which I could not entertain without considerable alarm for my heart. With the reputation of being extremely pretty, these young ladies had not the character of being Vestals. This was not much to be wondered at, Doctor Gracia having left his affairs in such a state as obliged his widow to take in boarders for a livelihood. If slander does not even spare young ladies brought up with the utmost severity, how could it possibly respect our three Graces, who were eternally surrounded with gallants? their father had been a man of pleasure, and had caused them to be instructed in music and other accomplishments; more intent upon fitting them for society, than forming their minds to virtue. I was perfectly well acquainted with all this; and they on their side knew well who I was. They had heard that I was well versed in music, that I had plenty of money, and a peculiar talent in spending it. These excellent qualities, which they admired in a man, made them extremely desirous to scrape acquaintance with me, and to induce me to increase the number of their boarders. This proposal had before been made to me, but I had rejected it, for fear of involving myself in some fresh intrigue. I had even made oath to avoid every snare that love might lay for me, and I did not expect, that in the holy place where I now stood, I should break this oath. Nevertheless, I felt a sort of agitation which so much resembled the first emotions of a growing passion, that I was alarmed at it. "Guzman," said I to myself, "make not a fool of yourself here. What God did you come to worship in this church? Let not your heart be taken by surprise. Can you wish to lose the fruits of so many years study?"

While my reason thus contended with my weakness, the ladies having finished their prayers, rose to leave the church. There were seven or eight of them, all of the same party. They passed by where I sat, and I rose to bow to them. The one whom I had so particularly noticed, and who was in reality the eldest of the three sisters, managed very adroitly, under pretence of adjusting her veil, to afford me a view of her beautiful face. I was so struck with it, that it was with the greatest difficulty I could restrain myself from

following her. An impulse, however, which heaven only could have bestowed upon me, held me back from so powerful and dangerous an attraction. I dropped down on my knees again, to continue or rather to begin my prayer, for I had as yet been so absorbed in other thoughts that I had forgotten the duty which brought me to church. I could not, however, divest my mind of the image of the enchantress who occupied it; and more agitated than a vessel without sail or compass in the middle of the ocean, I yielded to the different emotions which possessed my heart.

My extreme uneasiness not permitting me to remain any longer in the chapel, I left it, not to trace the steps of the beauty who had made so much impression on me; on the contrary, my wish was to avoid her, and fearing that I should meet her in the road that led to the city, I took another route, and turned my steps towards the river, in the hope that while I walked along its banks, I should insensibly lose all recollection of this redoubtable personage, whom my philosophy had not been able to withstand. And perhaps I should have become tranquil after a little reflection, but my stars willed it otherwise. A voice which I heard at the distance of ten or twelve paces from me, caused me to turn my head towards the spot from whence it came, and the very first thing that struck my eyes was that same Donna Maria Gracia, whose charms I was so assiduously shunning. She was seated on the grass and singing, while her sisters and the other ladies in company were preparing an elegant collation.

At this sight, I was no longer master of myself, but advanced and saluted them: "You must agree, ladies," said I, "that fate is most propitious to me to day, since it has been its will that I should meet you every where; but to complete my happiness I should be seated by your side." Donna Maria replied with a smile, "that it was my own fault only if I were not; and that it was but just that so many fair shepherdesses should have at least one shepherd to protect them from the wolves." This answer delighted me, and I quickly joined the party, abandoning myself to all my natural gaiety. The mother and the daughter seemed to vie with each other in politeness towards me. I thought that I had never spent many such agreeable moments, and regretted exceedingly that I had declined the opportunity of associating with so charming a family. The other ladies were also very gracious; and I told them more than once, that I thought all the loveliness in Alcala was in my presence. This compliment, as you may suppose, did not in the least offend them; and to shew me that there was some justice in my remark, they

prepared after the collation to entertain me with a concert. Two of the ladies played guitars which they had brought with them, and Donna Maria, and the others who had voices, accompanied them. A guitar was then presented to me, and I was entreated to play some airs to dance to, which I did with much less pleasure than I felt in seeing the ladies trip to it in the meadow like so many nymphs of Diana.

The eldest sister was the dancer I took most notice of. An air of peculiar nobleness and grace distinguished her from her companions. It is not surprising then that a man who took fire so easily as I did, could not resist such fine qualities. In truth I was so enamoured of Donna Maria, that I saw nobody but her. When she left off dancing, I seated myself at her feet, and presenting her with a guitar, entreated that she would play and sing to it. This request she was willing to comply with, on condition that I would accompany her. She had heard my voice praised, she said, and she longed to hear it herself. As I had no less a longing to gratify her desire, I was easily prevailed on, and acquitted myself, as I need not tell you, very much to the satisfaction of the party assembled.

In this manner we continued to amuse ourselves until night, when the widow Gracia sounded a retreat, and we began to file off towards the town, Donna Maria and I walking last. It were useless to tell you that our conversation turned upon love. We were both too intent upon it, to talk upon any other subject, and accordingly made a reciprocal declaration, and from that day perceived clearly that we were made for each other. As the other ladies in company had not so agreeable a conversation together as we had, they walked rather faster, and Donna Maria wishing to overtake them, either by chance or intentionally, made a false step, and must inevitably have fallen, had I not caught her in my arms. In raising her up I was bold enough to snatch a kiss. No sooner had I taken this liberty, than fearful that I had offended, I began to make excuses to the fair one, who, so far from resenting my boldness, told me in a lively manner, that I had done well in paying myself for the service I had rendered her, which she might otherwise have been ungrateful enough to have forgotten.

When we arrived at the widow's house, she gave me an invitation to walk in, which I willingly accepted of. I partook of some refreshments, and prolonged my visit till decency compelled me to take my leave. Before I retired, however, I obtained the widow's permission to call occasionally to assure her of my respect. I then bade adieu to Donna Maria, and was so

transported with love, that instead of returning homewards, I took the way to the University, and only recognized my error in time to prevent my knocking at the gates. You will easily conceive that I slept but little that night, after having passed the day in the manner I have related.

The following day, I went as usual to the schools of the University, where my distraction was such, that when I left them I scarcely knew what subject had been treated of. After dinner I could not resist the pleasure of visiting Donna Maria, to whom I listened much more attentively than I had done to the Professor in the morning, and who detached me so completely from the University, that I soon ceased to go there at all. I renounced the orders I had been so anxious to obtain; changed my ecclesiastical for a most magnificent secular habit, and after having paid my landlord, became a boarder at the widow Gracia's; or rather to speak without disguise, I gave myself up to the demon which possessed me. Every person of sense who was acquainted with me, pitied my blindness, and even the Rector of the University had the kindness to remonstrate with me on my change of conduct; but these friendly endeavours were of no avail. Fate would have it that I should persevere to my own ruin; or rather, perhaps, heaven could no longer behold such a subject a minister of the church.

CHAP. L.

Guzman marries again at Alcala, and shortly after returns to live at Madrid with his new wife.

I LIVED most delightfully with my new landladies; they endeavoured to anticipate my every desire: in short, I was the master of the house. This life lasted for about three months, at the expiration of which time I began to talk of marriage. We soon came to terms; and, by way of making a greater fool of myself, I expended a considerable sum of money in wedding clothes. One would have thought that I had cart-loads of money; though, to say the truth, I was almost at my last shift.

My mother-in-law, who was a good sort of woman, very easily led away by finery, seeing the fine show I made, thought that I was of course possessed of considerable property, and that the fortune of her whole family was made by obtaining me for a son-in-law. As it was necessary that a young man should be employed, she proposed to me to apply myself to physic, telling me that it was a very lucrative profession, and that if her husband had been more assiduous in it, he might have left his widow and children much better off than they were. To induce me to follow her advice, she offered me all Doctor Gracia's books and memoranda, not doubting, as she said, that with such assistance, and my excellent understanding, I should soon become an excellent physician. To gratify her wishes, I was complaisant enough to study for about six months under some of the most famous professors of medicine; but their lessons were not at all to my taste, and I soon became disgusted with a study which at the best could only maintain me in my old age. I pretended, therefore, that I had received letters from one of my friends, offering me a lucrative post at Madrid, in which I could not fail to grow rich in a very few years. I imparted this news to my mother-in-law, who, believing it to be true, was the first to recommend me to accept the situation, much as she really regretted the loss of my society.

The aversion I felt for the study of medicine was not the only reason for my wishing to leave Alcala. My finances were now at a very low ebb, and I did not wish to expose my poverty in a place where I had hitherto been considered in easy circumstances. In addition to this, I must inform you,

that Donna Maria, since her marriage, had thought proper to renew an intercourse with certain students whose tender attentions she had formerly encouraged. This was the more provoking to me, as she could expect no grateful acknowledgments from such gallants but serenades and boxes of sweetmeats. I was by no means satisfied with such empty profits; for it appeared to me, that a husband who kindly condescended to shut his eyes to his wife's gallantries, deserved at least that abundance should reign in his house. I resolved, therefore, to leave a place where my wife had formed such bad acquaintances, and to establish ourselves, at Madrid, where much better were to be met with.

Being quite prepared for the journey, we bade adieu to our friends and family, and set off in a genteel equipage for that city, so justly called the refuge for the destitute, Madrid. I had entirely broken with my father-in-law, Don Andrea, on the occasion of my second marriage, which I had contracted contrary to his advice. I thought no more of him; and as to my creditors, as I had still two years before me, I troubled myself but little on that head, nothing doubting, that before they could legally annoy me again, I should either make some lucky hit, or my wife's beauty would enable us to form, far enough out of their reach, a solid establishment.

A poor devil of a merchant from Alicant was the first who fell into our snares. Unfortunately for him, he had joined us on our route, and having seen Donna Maria, conceived a violent love for her. We clearly perceived this, when having arrived at Madrid, he compelled us, as it were, to stop at the inn where he lodged; and he assured us we should find every thing most comfortable. "The landlady," said he, "is one of the best women in the world. She has most excellent apartments, and a most famous cook." There was no resisting the earnestness of his entreaties, which sufficiently betrayed the goodness of his intentions. We were, therefore, easily persuaded, and were conducted to the inn, where we were exceedingly well received by the landlady, who appeared to us to be really respectable, and very much the friend of the merchant. She allotted to us one of the best apartments in the house, and tendered her services most obsequiously on any occasion that we might require them.

Our travelling companion requested that we would leave to him the care of providing a good supper for us; in which office he acquitted himself like a rich man who wished only to please. He spared nothing during the meal to gain my good graces. He paid much more attention to me than to my wife,

perhaps imagining that I was the most likely to oppose his design. After supper, I inquired what was to pay, and was answered that every thing was settled. I was overjoyed; but to let him see that I knew how to treat as well as he did, I invited him to dine with me the next day, and in the mean time sent orders to the cook to prepare an excellent dinner for three persons. It is true, that I fully intended he should pay for it; and, accordingly, no sooner was dinner over, than I went out under pretence of having some important business at the court end of the town, requesting him to excuse me, and to be so kind as to keep my wife company in my absence. This exactly suited him as well as me. Donna Maria, although sufficiently adorned by her natural beauty, had passed the whole morning in adding to it all the charms that could be borrowed of art, so that she appeared indeed more lovely than usual. She proposed to play to pass the time, and won a hundred ducats of our visitor, which he was obliged to lose to her out of gallantry.

This was nothing to what followed; for beginning to be more liberal in proportion as he became deeper in love, he put himself to a frightful expense. He presented my wife with several magnificent dresses, and a quantity of jewels. He conducted her sometimes to the promenade, sometimes to the theatres, and treated her and me every day in the most profuse manner. All this generosity on his part, you will say, could not be for nothing. I believe so as well as you. Donna Maria was naturally of too grateful a disposition not to make some return for such attentions. But I cared little or nothing about that. The husband of a coquette, when he is in indigence, and finds his account in allowing his wife to flirt, ought at least to be complaisant. The only fools are those gallants who purchase so dearly of him favours of which he is surfeited. As for me, I soon found myself by my prudent behaviour in a most enviable situation. We soon left our lodgings, and took a whole house to ourselves to live at greater liberty, ornamenting it with the most elegant furniture, which Signor Diego (for that was the merchant's name) had the kindness to pay for. What a joyful life did we there lead! good cheer, love, and indeed every pleasure were ours.

The merchant could not be better satisfied than he was with his lot, and we were equally so with ours. Concord and peace reigned in our little abode, when a young German nobleman, handsome, well made, and with a grand equipage, chanced to see my wife at the playhouse with Signor Diego, and thought her so handsome, that he was most anxious to know who she was. Her superb dress and noble air impressed him with the idea

that she was a lady of quality, while, on the other hand, the looks and dress of the merchant were by no means prepossessing. He knew not what to think of such a couple. At first he took Diego to be an attendant upon the lady; but the familiarity with which he treated her made him think at last that he must be her husband. To ascertain the truth, he caused her to be followed after the play by a clever valet, who returned with a faithful account of her situation; and the German, from his report, doubted not that he should soon be able to supplant the ugly merchant in her good graces.

To bring this about, he had a private conference with our late landlady, whom, by dint of presents, he soon gained over to his interests. This woman, from whom we had parted on good terms, was in the habit of calling upon us occasionally. One day, in a private conversation with Donna Maria, she drew so flattering a portrait of the German, that she engaged her to take a walk with her, unknown to Diego, where that young gentleman met her as though by chance. In addition to his fine figure and natural beauty, his manners were agreeable and insinuating. My wife took a fancy to him at first sight, and he did not, therefore, long languish. The proofs of gratitude of this gallant were not like those of Don Diego; but purses of a hundred doubloons each, valuable diamonds, superb tapestry, and rich plate. As soon as we found that this young nobleman was so prodigal of his riches towards us, we attached ourselves to him, and began to neglect our citizen of Alicant most outrageously. Donna Maria even favoured his rival in his presence.

Signor Diego was not deficient in pride. He was one of those rich merchants who look upon themselves as persons of quality. Not being willing to suffer that any one should be preferred to him after what he had done for us, he began to murmur. From murmurs he proceeded to reproaches, and from reproaches to threats. His passion excited my anger, and I told him that I chose to be master of my own house, and begged he would give himself no airs. He had not expected that I should have assumed so high a tone; and judging from that circumstance, that instead of my having been his dupe, he had been mine all the while, he wisely resolved to withdraw, which he did, bursting with rage and spite, instead of returning a thousand thanks to Heaven for having delivered him from such dangerous blood-suckers.

The German gentleman, far from diminishing our household expenses, increased them daily. He loaded us with presents, and we began to give

ourselves great airs. I had three footmen, and my wife two female attendants. We lived as if our property was doomed to last all our lives. It was not, however, very far from its termination. Our gallant foolishly thought fit to boast of his good fortune to a friend, a young Count of the Court, and to bring him with him to visit us. As soon as this latter saw Donna Maria, he became his friend's rival. This was of little consequence. The lady would have had wit enough to have pleased them both; but the Count wishing that two or three other of his fashionable friends should partake of his amusements, introduced them also to our house, where these youths altogether turned the house almost out of windows; nothing was to be heard but laughing and singing, from morning till night: and nothing could be done but gaming and drinking. And as these youngsters' pockets were not always well stored, they borrowed and cheated; and though all this property generally fell into our hands, it went as lightly as it came.

So irregular a life could not fail to draw some misfortune upon us. Two of these young gentlemen, already irritated by jealousy, had a trifling dispute at play one night, upon which they immediately drew their swords. They fought; and before they could be separated, one of them received a mortal wound. The parents of the wounded gentleman, having learnt that this accident happened at my house, which they considered a resort for the disorderly, caused me to be arrested in my bed one morning by a large body of constables, who, after having possessed themselves of the principal part of my property, led me to prison.

This sudden intrusion of justice awoke my wife in rather a disagreeable manner, who rose and dressed herself speedily, in order to intercede with one of the principal judges, a person respectable as well from his venerable appearance as his advanced age. She threw herself at his feet with tears in her eyes, and implored his support with the most affecting language. The old man, notwithstanding his years, was less interested by the entreaties of his fair petitioner than by the charms of her person. He raised her up, and introduced her into his closet, that, as he said, her audience might not be interrupted; and while she related the affair to him, the old satyr, who scarcely listened to a word she said, dried her tears with his handkerchief with one hand, while he placed the other trembling on her bosom. In short, he gave her hopes that the unlucky adventure which had happened to me would have no ill consequences, and immediately sent orders to the gaoler to treat me well; for he was a magistrate of great authority, and might have

released me immediately had he been so inclined, but he wanted a few more audiences with my wife. He appointed her to wait upon him the next day at the same hour. This she did, and was immediately shewn into his closet again, where she found him full dressed, combed, perfumed, and his beard neatly trimmed for the occasion. The success of this second visit was a promise that I should the next day be set at liberty; and my wife was obliged to call upon him again, to receive from his own hands the warrant for my release.

I thought myself very lucky in having got over this affair in so short a time, though it had cost me almost half I was worth. I flattered myself that, with so powerful a protector as my wife had now made, we might in future do any thing we pleased with impunity. Immediately after dinner I repaired to the judge's house, where I thanked him for his great goodness. He received me very politely, and invited me to pay him a visit occasionally. I pretended to be extremely sensible of this honour, and, on taking leave, besought a continuance of his protection. He assured me that I might rely upon it; and, the better to convince me, he honoured us with a visit that very evening. We received him in such a manner, that if he had been Prime Minister of Spain he could not have had more respect shewn him. As he told us that he liked music, my wife and I formed a little concert for his amusement. We afterwards regaled him with fruits and sweetmeats, which he repaid the next day by a handsome present to my wife.

This superannuated gallant accustomed himself by degrees to spend every evening in a house where he was so well entertained. At last he began to find my presence troublesome to him, and to get me out of the way, he told me, one day that I was dining with him, that 'twas a pity a man of sense and learning as I was should pass his youth away in idleness; that he would think of some post that would suit me, in which I should be simple indeed if I did not speedily grow rich. I assured him that my idleness was quite contrary to my inclinations, and that he would most sensibly oblige me if he would procure me an useful occupation, in which I trusted I could acquit myself to his satisfaction. The next day he paid me another visit, and put into my hands a commission to be one of the Receivers of King's Taxes, signifying to me, at the same time, that it would be necessary for me to repair to the precinct to which I was appointed without delay. Although I had but little inclination to this employment, I accepted it, and returned my benefactor as many thanks as if he had raised me to one of the first posts in

the kingdom. My wife was scarcely better pleased at it than I was, but we resolved in secret to make trial, whether, during my absence, our amorous grey-beard would be sufficiently generous to recompense us for the loss of the German gentleman.

I accordingly took leave of Donna Maria, leaving the field open to her old Adonis. I arrived at the department to which I was appointed, entered upon my new charge, and began to exercise it; but, alas! I soon found that, without robbing, extortion, and all sorts of violence upon the poor country people, I should be reduced to worse straits than ever. In short, I did not like the business, for I could not help thinking that a robber on the highway was an honester profession. Accordingly I had determined, at the expiration of the first three months, to be requested to be recalled. That time, however, had not elapsed before my patron wrote to me of his own accord to return to Madrid. This letter caused me more joy than I had felt when he so charitably released me from prison. I gave up my post with all my heart, and returned to my patron, very curious to learn how he could have grown tired of my absence. I went to see him the first thing on my arrival, and he began immediately to complain of Donna Maria's coquettish inclinations. "Your wife," said he, "has one very great fault, which is, that she loves none but young sparks. In vain have I represented to her that the many visitors of this description that she receives must infallibly ruin her; she will not break off such connexions: in short she is incorrigible. My sole reason," continued he, "for recalling you, was to inform you of her indiscretion, and to caution you to keep a better check upon her conduct, lest, in the event of any second accident happening at your house, you may not always be able to find powerful and disinterested protectors." I understood his meaning perfectly, and promised the old man that my wife should be more guarded in her future conduct; after which, I went home, well assured that my wife would tell the story in quite a different way; as in fact she did: for no sooner had I mentioned his name, than she began to declaim against him as an avaricious old curmudgeon, who had made her none but the most insignificant presents ever since my departure.

I entered into her resentment, and permitted more young men than ever to frequent our house; which the old magistrate having remarked, he reproached me for having broken my word with him, and, as though he had made my fortune, he accused me of making him an ungrateful return for all the benefits he had conferred on me. At length we lost all patience, and, to

get rid at once of so troublesome a visitor, I ordered the servants to say we were not at home whenever he called.

No sooner did he perceive that we were determined to release ourselves from his tyranny than his love was converted into hatred, and in his passion he caused us to be condemned to leave Madrid in three days, under pain of imprisonment for the remainder of our lives. He thought that by this he would undoubtedly have reduced us to implore his mercy, and do just as he pleased; but he was much mistaken, for no sooner was this unjust sentence made known to us than we guessed from whence it came, and resolved to obey it, my wife choosing rather to travel all over the world than have any thing more to do with this old rascal, and I beginning to be apprehensive that my creditors would shortly be calling upon me for the remainder of my composition money.

CHAP. LI.

Guzman and his wife, having been obliged to leave Madrid for their exemplary and moral mode of life, proceed to Seville, where Guzman finds his Mother.

THE first day we were fully employed in converting all our effects into ready money. On the second we hired four mules to carry us and our baggage, and departed from Madrid on the morning of the third, according to the sentence.

We took the road to Seville, not only to gratify my great desire to revisit my native country, but to please Donna Maria, who burned with impatience to try the effect of her charms upon the rich merchants who, I had told her, were continually arriving from Peru, laden with gold and jewels. She doubted not that she should fill her coffers at their expense. Notwithstanding our good intentions towards these gentlemen, however, we travelled very slowly for fear of fatigue; and I own that I felt a secret pleasure in surveying the country through which I had formerly passed, although it recalled to my remembrance the sad adventures of my youth. I passed the inn where I had been a servant; and at the sight of Cantillana I fancied I still smelt those excellent ragouts of mules with which I had formerly been regaled; and I did not forget the cudgelling which had been so liberally bestowed on me and the muleteer by the two officers of the Holy Brotherhood. I arrived and dined at that charming inn where they made omelets of pullets. I told my wife this story, and she laughed at it heartily. At last I reached the hermitage, where I lay the first night after I left Seville, and, transported with the recollection, I addressed the Saint in these terms: "Oh great St. Lazarus," cried I, "when I left the steps of thy chapel 'twas with tears in my eyes, on foot, alone, and poor, but innocent; and now thou seest me return, married, and in good condition, and well mounted; but how innocent, Heaven and thou know!"

It was quite night when we arrived at Seville, so that we were obliged to take up our quarters at the first inn we came to; but the next morning I rose betimes and took lodgings in St. Batholomew-street, whither I had my baggage conveyed. The next thing I did was to ask after my mother, but I

could hear no news of her until some months afterwards, when Donna Maria being on a visit to a lady with whom she had made an acquaintance, heard her name mentioned by mere chance, and was much astonished to learn that she lived very near us with a young lady who passed for her daughter. No sooner had I ascertained my mother's residence than I flew to it, found her at home, and we embraced with sincere affection.

We related to each other in a few words the adventures that had happened to us both since our parting, each of us, however, concealing whatever we thought fit. She was very anxious, for example, to persuade me that she had brought up the young lady who lived with her, out of pure charity, having been attached to her from her earliest infancy. I pretended to believe her word implicitly, though I entertained considerable doubt whether she had not other views which she did not choose to confess. After a long conversation, I introduced Donna Maria to her. My mother received her very kindly, and embraced her in an affectionate manner not very common in a mother-in-law.

To celebrate our reunion, my mother invited us to several entertainments, which we returned; and as I had occasion for an old mouser like her to instruct my wife in the coqueties of the ladies of Seville, where the modes of gallantry differed from those at Alcala and Madrid, I proposed to her to come and live with us, representing to her how much more agreeably she might pass her time. She answered "that she could not make up her mind to desert her adopted daughter, and that she feared also she should not be able to agree long with my wife." I endeavoured to remove the first obstacle, by consenting to receive the young lady into my family also. "You cannot think of it, my son," said my mother. "You must know but little of women, if you think that two lively young ladies like Petronilla and Donna Maria, can live even one month together, without quarrelling themselves, and indeed setting the whole house in an uproar."

I succeeded, however, in conquering the repugnance that my mother felt to grant my request. It is true, that she yielded at last upon my assurance that she would always find in my wife a daughter submissive to her wishes. At last she came alone to reside with us, choosing rather to leave Petronilla to herself, than to be the cause of dissensions in my family. At the beginning, all went on smoothly, and the only contention was, who should be the most complaisant. Each seemed to endeavour to anticipate the desire of the other. They addressed each other affectionately, and if this good

understanding had but lasted, we could not have failed in making our fortune; but unfortunately, before the expiration of three months every thing changed, and these same ladies, who had hitherto agreed so well, now began to pursue a different conduct. My mother wished to govern despotically, which my wife would not submit to. They were constantly disputing and quarrelling, and peace was entirely banished the house. Sometimes I endeavoured to reconcile them, and to act as umpire, but this only brought upon me the fury of her whom I decided against. What made matters worse, was, that the ships which were expected from India, did not come in that year. Money became scarce, and consequently the profits of my wife's gallantries were but trifling, in comparison with the daily expense of our establishment. Donna Maria was not one who could listen to economy, and no clothes or ornaments were good enough for her. The natural consequence of all this was, that as our funds diminished, so in proportion our vexations increased. We had placed great reliance upon the merchants from Peru, who never came at all; and my wife, to whom I had given a grand idea of the opulence and generosity of these merchants, reproached me as if I had been the cause of their delay. In short every thing fell upon me.

As good luck would have it, I happened to become acquainted with an Italian, captain of a Neapolitan galley, who by order of the Court had come to Malaga to carry the Bishop of that city to Naples; but that prelate not being ready to embark, he had come to Seville in the hopes of meeting with merchandize to freight his vessel for Italy. I met him by chance one day at a merchant's house, and was delighted in having found a man who spoke Italian as well as myself. He was on his side equally pleased, and we became very intimate. I invited him to my house, and introduced him to my wife, who did not fail to charm him. He made me some trifling presents, which would have been more considerable if his affairs would have permitted him to remain any longer at Seville: but as he could not make the bishop wait for him, and could not bear the idea of parting from my wife, he found means to conciliate his love with his duty, by persuading her to desert me, and fly with him into Italy. After all, I believe that he did not find it a very difficult matter to prevail upon her, for she had been long out of humour with me, and hated my mother more and more every day; so that we had not an hour's quiet for her. However that might be, I cared but little about it; and, indeed, thought myself happy and rich in having got rid of

her, notwithstanding she had taken her jewels and every thing of value about the house with her; in which the captain had very honestly assisted her, before I had the least suspicion of their intentions.

CHAP. LII.

Guzman, after his wife's elopement, resides for some time with his mother; but at length enters into the service of a lady of quality.

I WAS prudent enough to keep this affair secret, knowing that all the scandal of it would be reflected upon me. I sold what remained of my property, which consisted only of some of the worst of the furniture and moveables, which my wife had condescended to leave behind, and employed the money in making merry with my friends. My mother accommodated herself as long as she could to the life I led, but at last growing tired of it, she returned to the house where she had left Petronilla, telling me that she could now live more at her ease with her, than she could expect to do with me. I offered no opposition to her plans, and we parted again in perfect good will towards each other.

You will not be surprised that a continued train of expenditure without any income, soon reduced me to my original condition of life; but an adventurer, in whatever state it may please fortune to place him, should always find resources in his wits. Mine did not now abandon me. I learnt one day that there resided in the town a rich widow, whose husband had been Governor of a city in the West Indies, and died there, leaving his lady in great affluence. This widow, who affected great devotion, had no children, but several relations of consequence; and was at this time in search of a man, to whom she could confide the management of her affairs, well knowing that places of this description are not always filled by men of probity.

This post was a great temptation to me, and I resolved to spare nothing to obtain it, knowing that my fortune was made if I could succeed. After having tormented my brains for some time to invent some stratagem to attain my ends, I learnt that her Father Confessor was a Dominican Friar, who had an absolute dominion over all her wishes, and that he must be gained over to my interest. To this end, I bought a purse, and put eight pistoles, and twenty ducats of gold in it, to which I added a ring of trifling value, and a gold seal which my mother had presented to my wife the first day she saw her. After which I laid by my sword, and put on a very plain

suit of clothes. In this state I repaired to the Convent of the Dominicans, where I asked leave to speak to the Reverend Father before mentioned, who was a very favourite preacher, and had converted many. I was taken for one of his penitents, and was conducted immediately to his chamber, which I entered with an hypocritical countenance, as if afraid to cast my eyes on so sacred a person, and in a low and soft voice: "Most Reverend Father," said I; "I have just picked up this purse which appears to be full of gold and silver coins, and although I am but a poor man, I know that I have no right to keep it. I have therefore taken the liberty of asking for you, that I might place it in the hands of your Reverence to dispose of it as you may think fit."

The good father, charmed with so heroic an action in a person whose wants might have excused his appropriating it to himself, surveyed me from head to foot, and commended my disinterested and religious behaviour. He could not sufficiently extol me; and feeling, at the same time, a desire to render me some service, as a recompense for my virtue, he asked me a few questions as to my situation in life, and talents, that he might know what I was capable of. "Reverend Father," said I, "I have now been at Seville for some time, entirely out of employment. I was Receiver of Taxes at Madrid; but finding myself inclined to spend my own money to assist rather than persecute the poor, I was compelled to resign that situation; from which I became steward to a nobleman, whose affairs were in great confusion. These might soon have been settled; but in proportion as I arranged them, he involved them afresh, so that after having served him four years with the utmost zeal and fidelity, I was obliged to leave him as much a beggar as when I first entered his service, and without even having received my wages."

The Confessor listened to me with great attention; and surprised at hearing a man, whose dress did not much prepossess him in favour of his education, speak in such good terms, he asked me if I had ever studied. I told him that I had studied most assiduously with the intention of entering the church; but, that after having seriously reflected on a vocation which required so many virtues which I did not possess, I had given up such an idea. He was curious to ascertain how far I had gone in Theology; and as all my lessons were still fresh in my memory, I answered his questions in a manner which astonished him. My interview with him lasted two hours, and he was so well pleased with me, that he assured me of his friendship; and,

in taking leave, told me, that on the Sunday following he would advertise the purse I had found, in his church, and that if I would call upon him on the Tuesday following, he hoped he might by that time hear of some place to suit me.

After having left his Reverence I repaired to my mother's. "I have lost," said I, "the purse you gave me, in which were your ring and casket, together with eight pistoles and twenty crowns in gold of my own. Happily, however, it has fallen into the hands of a Dominican Father, who will advertise it in his church on Sunday. You must therefore go there, and claim it as your property, as I do not wish to appear before his Reverence for certain reasons which I will afterwards explain." After a little more instruction, the good woman did not fail to repair on the day fixed to the Dominican's Church, where she heard the father publish the purse as he had promised, not forgetting to bestow the greatest eulogiums on the honesty of the poor man who had found it, and delivered it to him. My mother, who knew as well as I did the contents of the purse, had but little difficulty in getting it restored her, after leaving two pistoles with his Reverence as a reward for the honesty of the person who found it.

My purse then was restored to me with the loss of two pistoles only. Tuesday had no sooner arrived, than I waited upon the Dominican again, who received me very kindly: "My son," said he, "a good old woman who has claimed the purse which you found, has left two pistoles with me in charge for you." I affected to be scrupulous of receiving this present, as I had only done what was my duty, for which I did not deserve or desire to be remunerated: but the good father told me that he thought I well deserved it, and obliged me to accept of it; which, as you will suppose, I no longer refused, purely in obedience to his commands.

He then informed me that he had some better news to communicate; which was, that he had obtained for me the situation as steward in the family of one of the principal ladies in Seville. "You cannot but be happy in this family," said he, "for the remainder of your days, if you perform your duty conscientiously, for which I entertain so good an opinion of you, that I have passed my word." At words like these, so flattering to such a rogue, I prostrated myself at his reverence's feet, and embraced his knees with transport. He assisted me to rise, and assured me of his protection. Then charging me with a letter to the lady, who proved to be the widow before mentioned, he told me that he had already prepared her to receive me.

I went immediately to pay my respects to my new mistress, and it was not difficult to perceive, by the reception I met with, that the Friar had told wonders of me. She addressed me, not as a man who was to be her servant, but as one of whom she already entertained the highest opinion. The good Father had also taken care to fix my salary and perquisites. She asked me if I was satisfied. I answered with a modest air, "that it was more than I deserved, but that I would endeavour to render myself worthy of her bounty by my care and fidelity in her service." My person and conversation pleased her infinitely, and she desired me to consider myself in her service from that moment. Accordingly I had my trunk carried in that evening, in which was all I possessed.

A very handsome room was assigned me, and I remarked with pleasure, that the other servants looked upon me as their superior, and as one whom their lady would have respect paid to. All her private papers were entrusted to me, and I applied myself so assiduously in discharge of my trust, that I despatched as much business in fifteen days, as my mistress expected would have taken up six months. Overjoyed at the acquisition of so expeditious an accountant, she never saw the Dominican, but she praised me exceedingly; which afforded the good Father great pleasure, who really thought me a young man of integrity and virtue.

I was frequently obliged to consult my lady on affairs which could not be settled without her approbation, and these interviews sometimes lasted for some hours. On these occasions I always behaved myself with so much respect, softness, and insinuation, that I perceived I was daily gaining ground in her good will. At first she had fixed certain times for me to speak with her on domestic affairs; which were in the morning at her toilet, and in the evening after supper. This did not last long; for she would come into my room after dinner, under some pretence or other, and spend hours with me in discourse which had no relation to business. Her fondness for me increased daily, and I could not but foresee the happiness she designed me. I affected for a long time not to understand her kind intentions; but flesh is flesh: and she having condescended to make advances at least half way, I could not forbear meeting her the other half. She excused her frailty by saying she designed to marry me privately, and I abandoned myself entirely to my good fortune, from which I should undoubtedly have reaped considerable advantage, had I been prudent enough to maintain my ground.

CHAP. LIII.

How Guzman suddenly loses his Mistress's favour, and is condemned to the galleys.

No sooner had I found in any part of my life that I might swim in deep water, than I was drowned. Finding that I was now beloved by my mistress, and looked upon by the servants as one whose favour was of consequence, I began to act quite a different character in the family, and set myself up to be absolute lord of all. I bought the most expensive clothes; spent money like a gentleman; and to crown all, took an under steward to look after the business of the house. Madam herself was not a wit more prudent, and consulting her love rather than her reason, approved of every thing I did.

This was by no means the case with her relations, who, as they had an eye to the succession, observed her steps most vigilantly. They had conceived no great liking for me when I first entered the service, being rather suspicious, and not without reason, of the very devout air I assumed; but when they learnt that I carried all before me in the family, they began to reflect seriously upon it. They knew who I was, and not thinking that I was married, became very apprehensive lest the too tender widow should eventually take me into the place of the defunct governor, if she had not already done so; especially when they recollected that she had some years before contracted marriage clandestinely with one of my predecessors, who, fortunately for the lady's heirs, had thought proper to die shortly afterwards. This made them very uneasy, and they had many meetings among themselves to deliberate upon the most efficacious mode of ridding themselves of so formidable a rival in the lady's favour. All their endeavours, however, would have been ineffectual, had I not ruined myself in my mistress's opinion by my imprudent conduct.

The tender connexion I had formed with the lovesick lady became daily less lively on my part; for, to say the truth, she was far from possessing qualities calculated long to attach the inclinations of a gallant man. Unfortunately also for our amours, I had cast my eyes on a young girl in the house, a pretty merry wench of about sixteen or seventeen years of age. A man who had money unlimited at his command, and the entire government

of the family, was not a conquest to be despised by a waiting-maid; so that I soon lured her to my purpose, and we concerted measures so well, that we kept our correspondence secret for a considerable time. There were, however, other women in the house, and it was not possible, therefore, that we could remain long undiscovered. Celia, which was the damsel's name, soon began to dress herself out in the jewels and ornaments I had given her, and to boast of her money. Her companions, in consequence, became jealous of her, and informed their mistress, who ordered them to watch her, and neglect nothing to ascertain the source of all this finery. These directions were punctually obeyed; and it was soon discovered that Celia had nocturnal conversations with me for three or four hours in my chamber. This news struck like a dagger to the lady's heart, for she had hitherto been confident of my fidelity. She could not think me guilty of such perfidy, and determined to be thoroughly convinced herself before she satisfied her vengeance.

I lay in a chamber which communicated with my mistress's by a closet in which there was a private door covered with tapestry. In addition to this, there was an opening which I knew nothing of, directly against my bed's-head; so that a person listening might easily hear whatever was said in my chamber, particularly when I was in bed. In this spot the widow placed herself one night, and listening attentively to my conversation with Celia, she overheard us distinctly speaking of herself; and though we had frequently before amused ourselves at her expence, yet, as the devil would have it, we had never before spoken so ill of her. We communicated to each other without reserve the various frailties and natural defects we had observed in her, and, in short, pulled her to pieces from head to foot. You will readily imagine the lady's rage at hearing herself painted in such glowing colours. She was at first tempted to enter my chamber and vent her fury on us immediately; but after a little reflection, she very wisely thought it more prudent to retire, and meditate her revenge more privately, than to make all the servants in the house laugh at her expense.

No sooner had day arrived than she sent for her nearest relation, to tell him that I was a complete rogue; that I had not been content with robbing her and putting all her affairs into disorder, but had dishonoured her house; in short, that she was determined no longer to overlook my knaveries, and only wished that I might be punished according to my deserts. She could not possibly have selected a more fit person to promote her wishes in this

respect than this relation of her's, who, hoping one day or other to be her heir, had more interest than any one to remove me from the testatrix. He was, therefore, highly delighted at so favourable an opportunity, and made haste to profit by it, lest the lady should change her mind. He knew her well, and saw plainly that she only acted this part out of some jealous pique; and accordingly exerted himself with such effect that in less than two hours he obtained a warrant against me, so that before I had risen from my bed, an Alguazil entered my chamber, and led me off to prison.

I was at first inclined to consider this as a token of remembrance, either from my relations at Genoa, or my creditors at Madrid; and it, was upwards two hours before I learnt the real cause of my imprisonment. At first I did but laugh at it, flattering myself that my mistress loved me too well to leave me to the severity of the laws: and I expected every moment to receive a message that she was no longer irritated against me, and had obtained my pardon. Buoyed up with this hope, I bore without impatience or complaint those fetters which I felt convinced love would shortly break for me; and I considered myself more like a lover punished for infidelity, than a steward imprisoned for robbing his mistress. I was, however, most grievously mistaken, for I was required forthwith to render an account of my administration, which had lasted two years. I now began to grow uneasy, for the manner in which I had dissipated the widow's money to my own purposes left so large a balance between the receipts and expenditure, that I would have defied any steward in the most noble family to have filled up the gap. It was in vain for me to puzzle my brain; for, to make the best of it, I was four thousand crowns short. To complete my ruin, the honest man whom I had employed as under-steward, while I thought of nothing but my pleasure, no sooner saw me thrown into gaol, than, to save himself from the same fate, which he knew he equally well deserved, he made off with all the ready money he could lay his fingers on. Being answerable for this man's behaviour, the whole was laid at my door. How then was it possible for me to escape with impunity? I had neither money nor credit; while, on the contrary, my prosecutors were so powerful, that I could entertain no hope of leaving prison, except *to serve the King upon the seas*.

I was so convinced of this, that I made an attempt to escape from prison, in the disguise of a woman, and had already penetrated as far as the outer gate, when a cursed one-eyed door-keeper recognized me. I carried a dagger in my breast, which I drew out to intimidate him; but he roared out for help,

which soon arrived, and I was led back to a dark dungeon, which I was not permitted to leave until I was conducted to the galleys, to which I was condemned for the remainder of my life.

CHAP. LIV.

*Guzman is conveyed to Port St. Mary with other honest folks like himself.
His adventures on the way, and on board the galleys.*

THE chain composed of twenty-six young galley-slaves, all decorated with the collar peculiar to the order, being ready to march, we set out for Port St. Mary where the galleys then lay. We were divided into four bands, and chained one to another, and our conductor, escorted by twenty guards, led us along by small days journies. We lay the first night at *Cabeças*, a village about nine miles from Seville. The next morning, having started again at break of day, we fell in with a lad driving pigs. This unfortunate youth, instead of driving his beasts out of our way, was imprudent enough to allow them to pass between our bands; the consequence of which was, that he lost half of them. In vain did he complain to our conductor, and entreat him to interpose his authority, to oblige us to make restitution; the conductor, who hoped to eat his share, turned a deaf ear to his prayers, and we passed on with our prize, as proud of the exploit, and as joyful as though we had recovered our liberty.

When we arrived at the inn where we stopped to dine, I made a present of my pig to the conductor, who accepted it willingly, and with many thanks. He then asked the people of the house if they could dress it nicely for him; but it was easily to perceive from their answers that they were but little accustomed to cooking. Upon which I told him, that if he would permit my chains to be taken off for one hour only, I would undertake to cook for him, and doubted not that I should give him satisfaction. He did not hesitate to grant this request, and I provided every thing in such good order for him, that he afterwards used me much more kindly than the other prisoners.

Before we left, I had another opportunity of shewing my skill at the inn, where two merchants happened to come in to dine. Finding themselves in such honest company, they became extremely uneasy for their property. One of them seemed determined not to leave any thing that belonged to him out of his sight, and, accordingly, placed his wallet under the table, keeping his foot upon it. I felt a great itch to be a match for this cunning gentleman,

and accordingly slipped very gently under the table, and cutting his wallet open with a sharp knife, I drew out two parcels, which I handed over in charge to one of my companions; named Soto, with whom I had become acquainted in prison. When we had left the inn, and had walked about a mile, I requested Soto to give me the parcels, that we might see what our booty consisted of, and divide it. Soto replied that he did not know what I alluded to. I thought at first that he was joking, but that was very far from his thoughts, and he persisted with oaths that he had received nothing of me. When I found he was in earnest, I reproached him with his ingratitude and perfidy; but he only laughed at my reproaches and threats, and kept quiet possession of the parcels. His behaviour quite enraged me, and I resolved to be revenged on him, by explaining the whole affair to the conductor, choosing rather that he should profit by the theft, than such an ungrateful and impudent rascal. This resolution I put into execution at night when we reached the inn where we were to sleep.

I had no sooner related the story to the conductor, than he called Soto before him, and asked him for the two parcels. The rascal answered that he had got nothing of the sort, and that I must be a great rogue to make such an accusation. "You will not give them up with a good grace then!" replied the conductor. "Very well, my friend, we will treat you then as you deserve." At the same time he ordered the guards to flog him until he confessed. Soto turned pale with fear at this cruel order; and out of regard to his skin, shortly afterwards confessed that the two parcels were concealed in the belly of the pig he had stolen. Here they were found; and when they were opened, it appeared they were full of beads and bracelets of coral adorned with gold, of excellent workmanship. Our conductor, like a man who understood his calling, thrust them all into his own pocket without ceremony, promising me a handsome reward, which, however, I have been expecting to this day; which proves clearly that this description of persons profit by the evil actions of rogues, though they do not participate in their punishment. From that day Soto and I swore eternal hatred to each other.

We pursued our route, and on our arrival at Port St. Mary, we found that six galleys were careening to put to sea. We were confined a few days in prison, after which we were divided into six bands. I was so unfortunate as to be condemned to live in the same galley with Soto. We were carried aboard our galley. I was seated over against the main-mast, and Soto on the master's bench; so that we seemed doomed to be near each other. The

King's coat was then given us, a red waistcoat, two pair of drawers, two shirts, a red cap, and a sea gown. After which a barber performed the operation of shaving our chins and heads. I regretted the loss of my hair exceedingly, which was long and beautiful. But it was of little consequence; I was now a complete galley-slave, which I should have been long before if I had had my deserts.

As the Commissary is an officer who possesses great authority over the galley-slaves, and which he usually exercises with brutality, my first endeavour was to gain his friendship. He ate and slept very near my seat, and I was always very officious to serve him whenever an opportunity presented itself. I was always the first to anticipate his wants, and testify my extreme desire to be useful to him. All these attentions did not go long unrewarded. I soon perceived that he regarded me with a more favourable eye than the rest. This was a great consolation to me; and to render myself still more worthy of his favour, I redoubled my endeavours to please him: in which I succeeded so well, that he at length never employed any other to assist him, and made me leave my seat to provide his meals for him, having been particularly well pleased with some ragouts I had already made for him. I was not a little proud of this honour, which, in fact, exempted me from my duty as galley-slave.

Our galley was ordered to Cadiz, to take aboard some masts, yards, and ship's tackling. Here a young lord, who was related to our captain, and a Knight of the Order of St. James's, came with his baggage on board our galley, intending to make his first expedition. He wore, as was customary in those days, a gold chain; but he had not been a week on board before he lost this. In vain was every exertion made to discover the thief; the chain was not to be found. Upon which the captain recommended his kinsman to take one of the slaves into his service, who should have the care of his chamber, and be responsible for every thing, on pain of being handsomely flogged if any thing were lost. The Knight approved highly of this advice, and the only question now was, which of the slaves should have the honour of serving him. He had heard a good account of my address and capacity, and wished exceedingly to have me. Accordingly, the captain called the commissary before him, and asked him if he was satisfied with my behaviour. The commissary, not knowing the drift of this question, enlarged upon my merit, and spoke so highly in my praise, that the Knight from that moment resolved to select me. I was immediately sent for; he liked my

looks, and I was enrolled in his service, to the great regret of the commissary.

Behold me now become a valet-de-chambre to a Knight of St. James. That I might be able to serve him the more commodiously, the first favour he obtained for me was, that I should only be obliged to wear a link on my foot; after which, all his clothes, linen, jewels, and other valuables were told out to me, and given in charge to me, with the recommendation that it would be to my own interest to be faithful and vigilant. I put every thing in such order, that I could see the whole at one view. The servants were expressly forbidden to enter the chamber without my permission, when their master was not in it. This regulation saved me a great deal of trouble in watching these sparks, who were as well versed in legerdemain tricks as any of the slaves on board the galley.

I applied myself assiduously to study the humour and disposition of the Knight, and it was not long ere I was beloved by him, and even esteemed, galley-slave as I was. He felt pleasure in conversing with me, and I appeared to him to possess such good sense, that he sometimes consulted me on the most important occasions. One day he entered his chamber with a thoughtful and melancholy countenance. "My friend," said he, "one of my uncles has written me a letter which has put me exceedingly out of humour, in which he urges me, if I wish to be heir to all his property, to marry. He has himself grown idle at the Court, without having dared to take that yoke upon himself, which he wishes me to submit to. I know not what answer to make; for I have no inclination at present for matrimony." "Sir," replied I, jesting, "were I in your place, I would write word back, that nothing could please me more than to comply with his wishes, provided it were with one of his daughters." My master laughed most heartily at this advice, which was only meant by me as a joke, and declared that he would write those very words, which he doubted not would rid him of any further importunity.

CHAP. LV.

Guzman finds himself in the most cruel situation of his life; but it pleases Heaven suddenly to put an end to his troubles, and he recovers his liberty.

I HAD every reason to be content with the life I led in the service of the young Knight, who kept so good a table that I had frequent opportunities of treating my comrades; in which I should not have forgotten Soto, notwithstanding what had passed between us; but this rascal, who had never forgiven me, took great pains to nourish my hatred by constantly speaking ill of me before my master's servants as well as those of the Captain. These servants, who none of them liked me, listened to him with pleasure, and did not fail to report every thing to their patrons; and, among other slanders, that I was only waiting for an opportunity to make some good hit, and that, sooner or later, the Knight would know me for the rogue I really was.

Although imputations coming from such a source ought not to have been looked upon without suspicion, they did not entirely fail in making some impression on my master's mind; and I soon perceived, notwithstanding the implicit confidence he pretended to place in me, that he kept a strict watch over all my actions. On my side, without taking notice of his unjust suspicions, I continued to serve him with fidelity, keeping my eyes always open to any snares my enemies might lay for me. In spite of all my vigilance, however, I fell a prey to Soto's malice, who instigated one of the Knight's servants to steal a piece of plate out of his master's cabin and hide it under my bed between two boards. I soon missed it, and told my master of the loss in a manner which ought to have convinced him that I was not the thief. But I was not believed, and it was at last found where it had been concealed. The Captain, thinking that I had stolen it, in spite of all I could allege in my defence, condemned me to receive fifty lashes; but my master begged me off, on condition that if any thing were again lost, I should have no mercy.

Finding, by this adventure, that I had secret enemies, who were determined to ruin me, I humbly prayed the Captain and my master to take another in my place, and permit me to return to my oar, rather than be exposed to such another misfortune. My master misinterpreted my

intentions; and, thinking that I was more desirous of returning to the Commissary's than of continuing in his service, he determined to keep me whether I would or no. Patience, therefore, was my only remedy, and I stood as much on my guard as I could night and day; yet, watchful as I was, I could not escape. My master having returned from the town one night, sent for me to assist in undressing him. I gave him his gown and nightcap; and while I carried his sword and gloves from one cabin to another, some rascal stole the hat-band. I never could find out how this trick had been executed; but when I was brushing the hat the next morning, I discovered that the band was missing. At this sight I turned as pale as death; looked for it every where, but all in vain; there were thieves on board that galley at least my match.

Nothing was left for me to do but to implore the Knight's mercy; but when I related my new misfortune to him, as well as the malignity of my enemies, to which I attributed it, he laughed in my face. "Mr. Guzman," said he, with a sneer, "I am well persuaded that you are a person of the greatest integrity, although you have not that reputation on board this galley; and I have been told, more than once, of my boldness in having trusted you. Once more, I think you an honest man, and am, therefore, sorry to tell you, that if you do not forthwith produce my hat-band, you must be delivered over to the Under-commissary, who will, doubtless, treat you according to your deserts. This you may rely upon, notwithstanding your protestations of fidelity."

This was the Knight's answer, and the Captain came up at that moment. As soon as he knew what was the matter, and found that I persisted in denying that I had taken the hat-band, he flew in such a passion, and beat me so cruelly, that I fell down half dead. To increase my misery, I was driven from the poop and sent to the last seat on the prow, the most uneasy seat of all, and that in which the slaves work hardest. In addition to this, the Commissary had orders not to spare me, under pain of the Captain's displeasure. This officer, however, really pitied me, and, notwithstanding the orders he had received to treat me with rigour, allowed me to rest for a full month, seeing that I was quite incapable of hard labour.

I regained my strength by degrees; and no sooner had I re-commenced my duty at the oar than Heaven, satisfied with the hardships I had already undergone, took compassion on me, and released me from my pitiable situation. Soto, who had a devilish design in his head, which he could not

execute without my assistance, my seat being near the powder-room, became extremely desirous to be reconciled with me. With this view he availed himself of the mediation of a Turk, who had the liberty of going fore and aft as he pleased in the galley; not doubting that I longed in my heart to be revenged for the cruel treatment I had met with, and that I loved liberty as well as others. He entreated me, through the Turk, to forget the past, and restore him my friendship, which he confessed he had justly forfeited. I pretended to be very desirous to be reconciled to him; upon which the Turk addressed me in these terms:

“Soto has charged me to communicate to you a project which he has formed to deliver us all. It is concerted, that as soon as we reach the coast of Barbary, which we are fast approaching, we are to rise, cut the throats of the officers and soldiers, beginning with the Captain, proclaim *Liberty* to the rest of the galley-slaves, who will immediately assist us, render ourselves masters of the galley, and seek an asylum amongst the Turks. This enterprise has been in contemplation,” continued he, “upwards of two months. We have a sufficient quantity of arms concealed, all our measures are taken, and we have resolved to save ourselves, Turks as well as Christians, or perish in the attempt. All that is required of you is to blow up the powder-room at a signal given. This is our plot; and after the cruel treatment you have experienced from the Captain, we have thought that you would not refuse to join us.” I replied to the Turk, that he might depend there was nothing I was not capable of undertaking to be revenged on the Captain, and that he might assure the conspirators that I would do what was expected of me. This, however, was very far from my intention. When the day approached that the plot was to be put in execution, I requested a soldier who came near my seat to tell the Captain that I had a secret of the greatest importance to reveal to him. “But,” added I, “tell him to send for me immediately; his life depends upon his compliance.” The Captain considered this as a trick of mine to reconcile myself to him, and regain my post in his kinsman’s service; and though he did condescend to hear what I had to say, he resolved to make me suffer for it, if I was only trifling with him. He sent for me, however, and I discovered all I knew; told him where the arms lay concealed; and named the principal inventors of the plot, at the head of which I did not forget to rank my friend Soto.

The Captain, perceiving now that it was no trifling matter, resolved to proceed with caution, and ordering all the soldiers to their arms,

commanded a search to be made, and found a vast quantity of fire-arms and other weapons in the place I had pointed out. He then caused the ringleaders of the conspiracy to be seized, who, being put to the torture, confessed all. Soto and one of his comrades were condemned to be drawn in quarters by four galleys, and the rest were decimated, of whom five were hung, and the others had their noses cut off. Soto, before he died, owned that it was by his contrivance the piece of plate and hat-band had been taken out of the Knight's cabin, and that I was innocent of it. The Captain commended me highly for my zeal and fidelity, after the unjust usage I had met with; asked my pardon publicly; ordered my irons to be struck off; gave me the liberty of the galley; and he and all the officers signed a letter setting forth the considerable service I had rendered the King in saving the galley and so many lives; which was transmitted to Court to procure an order from his Majesty for my enlargement. It were needless to state with what a grateful heart I returned thanks to Heaven for such a revolution in my prospects, promising to amend, and live better for the future.

Thus, friendly Reader, I have given you an account of the principal adventures of my life. What followed after the King was graciously pleased to grant me my liberty, you may expect to hear, should I live long enough to tell you.

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